

THE MEDIATOR GUIDEBOOK



BECOMING WHO
YOU'RE MEANT TO BE

What's in This Profile?

This profile is designed to cover all the main aspects of Mediators' personality as it affects different areas of their life, including Mediators' key strengths and weaknesses, relationships, academic path, career and professional development, as well as their communication and friend-making skills, parenting tips and advice, and much, much more. It combines personality-type theory with practical, real-world advice from other people who share the Mediator personality type.

Personality type has been the focus of many discussions, some of them dating back to ancient times. It's wise to draw from this source of knowledge and experience, especially when unsure of how to handle a specific situation. This kind of knowledge offers the power to control and understand oneself. As Aristotle said millennia ago, "The hardest victory is the victory over self." Consider this profile a plan for success.

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Who Is “The Mediator”?



The Mediator personality is one of the kindest, most sensitive, and curious types. Fewer than 5% of Americans are believed to be Mediators – averaging 4% among men and 5%–6% among women. These percentages seem to vary across regions; for instance, Asian countries tend to have higher percentages of Introverted types, and locations like Hong Kong and Singapore have a higher number of Intuitive individuals. Furthermore, Mediators are well-represented in the virtual world, where they can express themselves freely and test social norms while keeping the stress of peer pressure at a distance.

Throughout this book, we will discuss how Mediators’ traits manifest themselves into a complete and unique personality type. Every personality type has probable behaviors that affect their lives, and we’ll look at each in terms of the following categories: personal growth, romantic relationships, friendships, parenting, and academic and professional development. We’ll present a brief overview of the Mediator personality type, and then we’ll explore each subtopic in much greater detail.

Personal Growth

Introversion may make Mediators seem reserved or shy, but such an exterior can be deceptive, hiding boundless curiosity and creativity. Although these individuals can be cautious in public arenas, their inner desire to explore new things shines through in other aspects of their lives. This seeking nature helps many Mediators evolve beyond social insecurity, with time and experience. People with this personality type are deeply sensitive and caring, and they express those qualities with quiet empathy – positive human contact nourishes their souls and builds their confidence. They have open minds and hearts, always willing to entertain new perspectives that expand their own ideas.

For Mediators, personal growth is largely about moving from creative thought into action –following through to turn their many beautiful hopes, dreams, and ideas into reality. They have little trouble imagining grand things, and as they grow and mature, they learn to balance their imagination with perseverance, and can effectively develop themselves to achieve what matters most to them. Although their natural attitude is often one of exploration and adaptation, they can learn to deliberately craft circumstances to suit their will and desires – it takes practice, but it’s a skill with long-term payoffs in every aspect of life. When Mediators learn to translate their mental energy into focused practices, their creativity becomes unstoppable.

Friends, Family, and Relationships

Mediators are tireless in their desire to create harmony through understanding, and they gently elevate their friends, family, and intimate partners in beautiful, subtle ways. Deeply compassionate, people with this personality type give of their energies freely, opening themselves fully to those they love and treating close friends like

family. When they have families of their own, Mediators are a sincere well of support and love, minimally judgmental and very open-minded. Unfortunately, their emotionally giving nature can leave these types feeling neglected themselves, as few people ever understand them the way they can understand others. Mediators think nothing of extending their hearts to others, yet many times, they don't feel comfortable asking for the same care they so readily give.

The same hope and sensitivity that make Mediators truly exceptional also make them a bit vulnerable. They can be hurt easily by unkind or dishonest people, and although this doesn't necessarily damage their personal ideals, it can drive Mediators to temporarily lose their bright outlook, depressing their energy and thoughts. Maturity and experience help Mediators develop tools to deal with a rough world, insensitive people, and risky situations, but it can occasionally be difficult to maintain their balance as they learn.

Fortunately, Mediators have a wonderfully enduring sense of hope that keeps them going and looking up, even when the world lets them down. They have a marvelous ability to find inspiration in new things, and though this can occasionally distract them from responsibilities, it also gives them the resilience to continue to see potential around every corner and in everyone they meet.

To Mediators, authenticity, understanding, and harmony are often more important than materialistic rewards. They aren't afraid to chase the things they truly believe in, and finding deep, rewarding human relationships is one of their consistent goals.

Academic and Professional Development

Mediators tend to be highly idealistic, feeling disappointed by injustice, ignorance, and intolerance in the world – and they can apply this view in the workplace and the

classroom. They love to discover truth, and often study many diverse subjects and possibly try many different jobs before finding their true calling. People with this personality type usually see things with a questioning, hopeful perspective rather than pure logic, and they try to achieve academic and professional goals through that open-minded lens. They respond to creativity, morality, and kindness more than utility or tradition, always seeking to uncover something grander than the mundane. Mediators often forgo pragmatism in favor of idealism, which can make them highly innovative in school and on the job. This style may conflict with some types, yet inspire others.

Luckily, Mediators often excel at sharing their perspective through their speech and written communication, with distinctively humanistic, warm language that expresses their hearts, minds, and ideas. They have a talent for creating and interpreting symbolism, and their rich imaginations often make them seem supernaturally inspired – few other personality types use metaphors with such finesse. Mediators connect with others through ideas, and their heartfelt communication style can help them overcome barriers and move forward in professional and academic environments alike.

Good communication also allows Mediators to seek knowledge, though they don't feel limited by the rules of logical examination. In their opinion, simple facts aren't always the fullest form of truth, especially if they disregard human complexity and need. They're curious learners and often avid readers, and although they love to discuss inspired plans and ideas with others, they aren't fond of debates, preferring to learn through genuine personal connections rather than intellectual sparring. They seek mutual understanding with their peers rather than competition – sharing more than showing off.

People with this personality type are sensitive and vulnerable to conflicts, and even the most calmly confident Mediators tend to take criticism personally. This is one of their weaknesses, especially in diverse social environments such as work or school where they often encounter starkly contrasting views. If they cannot escape a conflict, they may experience unbalanced emotions, and even irritable, irrational behavior. When battered by social stress in the workplace or classroom, Mediators may simply retreat from the world, getting lost in their own deep thoughts. At times, colleagues or peers may need to try to energize and “awaken” Mediators with positive, gentle opportunities to connect to help these sensitive individuals restore their balance and move forward.

On That Note ...

This introduction has provided only a brief outline of Mediators’ potential strengths and weaknesses. In the following chapters, we will discuss these areas in much greater detail and provide suggestions for improvement. Understanding one’s personality type is incredibly valuable, and the following information can prove useful to advance Mediators in all areas of their lives. But before we dig in too much there, we’ll do a brief overview of our theory. For a full explanation of the theory and its history, skip to the end – [The Puzzle of Personality](#).

Theory Overview

Five Personality Aspects

Introverted (I) vs. Extraverted (E)

People have long noted that some among them are more outgoing and comfortable interacting with their surroundings, and others are more at ease remaining in quiet solitude with their thoughts. You can see the two types in almost any home, office, or classroom. In our first scale, we focus on the difference between Introversion and Extraversion, which we call the Energy scale.

The Energy scale describes how we see and approach the outside world, including people, objects, and activities within it. There are significant links between this scale and things like willingness to volunteer, boredom, thrill seeking, motivation, and romantic assertiveness, to name just a few. The links may not prove one causes the other. However, it does hint at a relationship.

Introverted People: Attuned Inwards

More Internal: Introverts ground themselves more easily in solitude and derive energy from their own thoughts.

More Selective: Introverts are careful when choosing the people with whom they spend time and prefer a quieter environment when they have a choice.

Slow to Offer Opinions: Within reason, Introverts like a little time to process their thoughts and ideas and are slow to offer opinions, fearing they may be too rash.

Extraverted People: Outwardly Engaged

More Outgoing: Extraverts tend to be outgoing both socially and in their willingness to interact with new and interesting environments.

Energetic: Extraverts have an energy that is almost replenished by its expression. They are energized by being energetic and putting themselves in stimulating situations.

Quick with Opinions: Extraverts are generally more comfortable with a flurry of opinions that typically are a part of casual conversations. It's almost like brainstorming ideas on the spot while saving the editing for later.

Mediators: Introverted (I) Trait

Mediators are Introverted. This is why they enjoy being self-sufficient, prefer working with ideas rather than people, and don't need great numbers of friends. They may even be able to tune out what is happening around them. Socializing depletes Mediators' internal energy reserves quite quickly, even as their other traits pull them to connect with others. When that happens, they need to return to their home base to recharge.

Again, these are just tendencies and not predestined, unchangeable traits. For instance, Mediators are perfectly capable of honing their social skills and becoming experts in negotiation or small talk. Mediators would develop these skills out of necessity, however, and not due to particular enthusiasm or interest.

Intuitive (N) vs. Observant (S)

The second scale in our model is called Mind and addresses Intuitive and Observant styles. Each trait determines what kind of information we focus on and how it is used. It's the foundation on which all the other approaches are built.

All personality types include either those who favor the Intuitive style or those who prefer the Observant style. But before we start, it's important to say that this has nothing to do with how they take in information. The word "Observant" might suggest it does. But Intuitive and Observant types use their five senses in the same way. Rather than how they absorb information, these qualities show how each of these traits manages it once it's received.

Intuitive People: Living in the World of Ideas

Focus on Ideas: Intuitive people are fascinated by the world of ideas and love to discover the connections between various concepts and realities.

Deeply Curious: Within the realm of ideas, Intuitive individuals have a strong curiosity that leads them to somewhat adventurous discoveries.

Highly Imaginative: Those who prefer this trait typically stretch concepts to include possibilities beyond the obvious. "What if this not only means... but what if it could also mean..."

Observant People: Feet On the Ground

A Practical Focus: Observant people are more in touch with the concrete world and work within it. They favor consistent actions and measurable results.

Facts Over Theory: These individuals leave theorizing and brainstorming to others, preferring to effectively apply established facts.

More in the Moment: While Observant individuals have a respect for the past and the future, they see them through the lens of what they can do now. The task at hand is always the most important.

Mediators: Intuitive (N) Trait

Mediators are Intuitive individuals. This is why they are so good at seeing possibilities and honoring different points of view. People with this personality type spend more time engaging in various internal discussions than observing things around them. Mediators are not that concerned about what is happening; instead, they focus on what might happen or why something has happened. Mediators hone this focus throughout their lives, which makes them passionate and insightful thinkers.

Of course, every stick has two ends, and focus on novelty and change comes at a cost. By directing their mental resources toward possibilities and the future, Mediators inevitably lose sight of what is happening around them. They may have difficulties dealing with practical matters or data. If they aren't paying attention, they may even miss something right under their nose. Because the majority of the population has the Observant trait, Mediators may feel like they're connecting things at a different level.

Thinking (T) vs. Feeling (F)

The Thinking and Feeling traits determine how we decide matters and cope with emotions. While we all have feelings, there are significant differences in how we react to them and what role those feelings play in our lives. This then influences several

other areas, mostly related to our interactions with other people. This is what our third trait, Nature, focuses on.

Thinking People: Where Reason Rules

Rational and Objective: Thinking individuals are most comfortable dealing with things that come from rational thought and involve proven principles.

Logic Over Feelings: While these types often feel quite deeply, they typically place their rationality and logic above any emotional responses.

Constantly Assessing: Thinking people constantly scan ideas and actions to decide whether they make sense or not. They can be valuable in any process that requires any level of critical thinking.

Feeling People: Those Who Follow Their Feelings

Lead from the Heart: Feeling types listen to their feelings, care about how others feel, and are unafraid of sharing this perspective.

Focus on Morals and Ethics: People and their welfare are usually prioritized above any other consideration with the individuals who exhibit the Feeling trait.

A Different Kind of Rationality: While the Feeling type's way of choosing a direction may not always be totally objective, that doesn't mean that they lack rationality. There is practical wisdom in including feelings and consideration for the well-being of oneself and others in the decisions one makes.

Mediators: Feeling (F) Trait

Mediators have the Feeling trait – they trust and prioritize feelings, relying on moral and ethical arguments, and doing everything they can to stay true to their deeply held principles. People with this personality type are kind and sensitive, always able to find something positive regardless of the circumstances.

The Intuitive and Feeling traits form the core of the Mediators personality, making them very insightful, idealistic and open-minded individuals. They are capable of amazing feats, especially in fields related to morality, philosophy, or diplomacy. However, they also push Mediators away from the majority of the population, sometimes making it difficult for them to relate to other people, especially when it comes to accepting what they see as egoism and self-interest.

Judging (J) vs. Prospecting (P)

The Tactics scale – Judging and Prospecting – is about how people plan and deal with the options they have. But this definition doesn't just concern what individuals write in their day planners. It's much broader. These traits answer questions like, "Do you prefer spontaneity or certainty?" "Do you feel more comfortable acting only with all your ducks lined neatly in a row? Or does a certain amount of flexibility or chaos excite you and prove motivating?" "Do you need more choices or fewer?"

At its core, this scale determines our attitude toward certainty and structure in our lives, both at mental and physical levels.

Judging People: A Steady Hand

Predictability Rules: Judging types are most at home when there is a clear-cut, well-considered plan that provides sure steps and promotes certain outcomes.

Work Hard: Judging individuals tend to work hard, perhaps seeing strong effort as a way of ensuring predictability.

By the Book: Individuals with this trait usually like to do things by the book and respect reasonable protocols, established techniques, and duties. They sometimes see doing things any other way as “reinventing the wheel.”

Prospecting People: Possibilities in the Moment

Relaxed Spontaneity: Prospecting types tend to deal with life and all its opportunities as it comes at them.

Creative: This trait can promote “coloring outside the lines.” This can lead to discovering new creative solutions.

Serial Passions: Prospecting individuals may find themselves passing quickly through many interests in their lives. Because of these experiences, they can possess a broad array of knowledge and ideas.

Mediators: Prospecting (P) Trait

Mediators are Prospecting individuals, meaning they tend to look for different ways to complete tasks or accomplish goals. Mediators’ vast range of interests may lead to unfinished projects or missed deadlines, but these types would rather risk disappointing others than lock themselves into a position where existing commitments would limit their freedom.

Partly because of their Prospecting trait, Mediators tend to be removed from the real world, often paying far more attention to their latest mental exercise than to clutter around the house or dishes piled in the sink. Prospecting types tend to be more relaxed about their work or studies, refusing to get stressed about deadlines, templates, or rules when they still have free time.

Assertive (-A) vs. Turbulent (-T)

Assertive and Turbulent – the Identity scale – measures how confident one is and how that confidence influences all other traits. The degree that people move more boldly or more timidly affects the way they make choices. It determines how they express their skills. Whether one is too confident to accept criticism or puts too much weight on the criticism of others because they lack self-confidence can make a major difference. The caution or lack of caution people apply to the things they do can color everything.

Assertive People: A Confident Approach

Confident Style: People with the Assertive identity are self-confident and resist stress.

Often Success-Oriented: Because these individuals don't spend hours fretting, it might be assumed they aren't interested in results. For many of them, nothing could be further from the truth.

Responsive and Proactive: Assertive people may jump into a task quickly, not being as burdened with the need to think endlessly about what may go wrong.

Turbulent People: Always Improving

Useful Worry: Turbulent people often worry and engage in self-doubt. While that might sound negative, the flipside of the coin is that it fuels much of their drive and productivity.

Driven to Succeed and Improve: Turbulent individuals are constantly seeking to do better and be better. This pushes them to put great effort into life.

Problem Spotters: Because of their cautious nature and tendency to worry, those with the Turbulent trait often spot problems early and are able to contain them quickly.

Type Groups

Now you know what each type consists of. But how do they fit together?

In our system, we group personality types in two different ways:

- **Roles** determine our goals, interests, and preferred activities.
- **Strategies** reflect our preferred ways of doing things and achieving our goals.

You can think of Roles and Strategies as two ways of organizing personality types into categories. These two categorization methods each highlight different facets of the types. For examples, Roles can show us why certain types share similar interests, and Strategies can explain why certain types approach socializing the way they do.

We discuss Strategies in depth at the end of this e-book, in *The Puzzle of Personality*. With that in mind, let's explore the importance of Roles.

Roles

There are four Roles, each of which groups together four personality types.

- The **Analyst Role** includes Architects (INTJ), Logicians (INTP), Commanders (ENTJ), and Debaters (ENTP).
- The **Diplomat Role** includes Advocates (INFJ), Mediators (INFP), Protagonists (ENFJ), and Campaigners (ENFP).
- The **Sentinel Role** includes Logisticians (ISTJ), Defenders (ISFJ), Executives (ESTJ), and Consuls (ESFJ).
- The **Explorer Role** includes Virtuosos (ISTP), Adventurers (ISFP), Entrepreneurs (ESTP), and Entertainers (ESFP).

So, why do we organize the types in this way? To put it simply, Roles help us to recognize important common ground between personality types.

The types within each Role all share the same Mind trait – either Intuitive or Observant. As you might remember, this trait is incredibly important because it determines how we view the world. As a result, the types within a given Role are alike in a very important respect: they share similar ways of understanding the world and their place within it.

In addition to the Mind trait, the types within a given Role also share the same Nature trait (Thinking or Feeling) or the same Tactics trait (Judging or Prospecting).

Does this seem like information overload? If so, don't worry. To help you get a better grasp of the Roles, let's go through them one by one and find out what makes them tick.

Analysts: Intuitive (N) and Thinking (T)

The personality types in the Analyst Role – Architects, Logicians, Commanders, and Debaters – are known for their irreverent curiosity. Thanks to the Intuitive trait, these types are rarely satisfied with the status quo. Instead, they'll go deep in their search for ways to make things better, more efficient, and more effective. Meanwhile, the Thinking trait means that they value rationality over emotionality.

Analysts' greatest strengths include:

Driven to learn. Analysts want to know how the world works. In their quest for knowledge, they push the boundaries of their understanding. The result? Their expertise in certain areas can be remarkable.

Questioning natures. Analysts rarely accept things at face value. Ever questioning, they look beyond superficial appearances. This enables them to come up with deep, unexpected insights.

Intellectual energy. Full of fresh, counterintuitive ideas, Analysts know how to spark a lively debate. Conversations with these candid, sharp-witted types can be a breath of fresh air.

Born to improve. Analysts are relentless self-improvers. Once they've recognized a flaw, they apply all their rationality, imagination, and ambition to make it right.

Analysts' forceful imaginations, when trained and focused, enable them to achieve incredible results. But, like anyone, these types can have their Achilles heels, such as:

Lost in thought. Thinking up great ideas gives Analysts a rush. As a result, they're at risk of staying in the realm of thought, never acting out their ideas.

Ever the critic. In the same vein, some Analysts are more comfortable thinking about and critiquing other people's work than jumping into the fray themselves. In time, these types may be frustrated to find themselves outpaced by people with real-world experience.

Hunting for flaws. If taken too far, Analysts desire for improvement can have them hunting down the flaws in everything. As a result, they may undervalue the people and opportunities they encounter.

Emoti-what? Analysts feel more comfortable in the realm of thought than the messy world of emotions. But like anyone, they need to develop emotional literacy in order to deepen their relationships and fully understand themselves.

Fortunately, Analysts have enough creativity and ambition to move beyond these stumbling blocks. When they take action, look for the positive, and train their curiosity on the realm of emotions, these types can grow into their full potential.

Diplomats: Intuitive (N) and Feeling (F)

Diplomats – Advocates, Mediators, Protagonists, and Campaigners – tend to be warm, caring, and generous. Bringing together the Intuitive and Feeling traits, they shine in their understanding of emotions – both their own and other people's. This ability helps them shine when it comes to diplomacy, counseling others, and communication in general.

Diplomats' gifts and talents include:

Emotional literacy. Even when it's far from obvious, Diplomats can often perceive how others are feeling. From the outside, this might look like mind-reading. But in

truth, it's a combination of self-reflection and radical compassion that helps Diplomats understand others' emotional states.

Only connect. Diplomats don't use their people skills to manipulate others. Instead, they aim to nurture genuine connections with the people they encounter. Moreover, many Diplomats feel called to serve others however they can.

Do no harm. Deep down, Diplomats want what's best for everyone. For them, causing someone else distress would feel like a wound to their own psyche. As a result, these types aim to promote cooperation and harmony rather than conflict.

Creators at work. Profoundly creative, Diplomats are always on the hunt for inspiration. Whether or not they take up artistic pursuits, these types tend to enjoy self-exploration and self-expression.

Diplomats have high ideals. For them, kindness and altruism burn as brightly as a fire on a chilly winter's night. But if left unchecked, this idealism can have its downsides, including:

Impractical magic. Tempering passion with cold practicality is a challenge for Diplomats. These types are often reluctant to make tough decisions – especially if those decisions require them to compromise on their ideals or hurt someone's feelings.

Beautiful ideas. Diplomats have the best of intentions, and they have countless ideas about ways to help people. They're at risk, however, of staying stuck in the realm of ideas instead of taking action and sticking to a plan.

Taking on too much. In their efforts to make a difference, Diplomats may overcommit themselves – emotionally, physically, or even financially. If they don't

deliver everything they'd hoped, they may feel overwhelmed or disappointed in themselves.

Easily hurt. Sensitive to criticism and rejection, these types may react strongly if other people question the value of their ideals. Disagreement and conflict can leave Diplomats feeling discouraged and hurt.

In all their actions, Diplomats crave a sense of meaning and purpose. Specifically, they feel called to cultivate positive change and gentle beauty in the world around them. Motivated by intangible rewards felt in the heart and soul, these types have a conviction to serve the greater good.

Sentinels: Observant (S) and Judging (J)

Sentinels – Logisticians, Defenders, Executives, and Consuls – are cooperative and practical. This grounded approach helps them feel comfortable with themselves just as they are. Steadfast and hardworking, these types pride themselves on their character and competence.

Here are some of the ways that Sentinels contribute to their homes, workplaces, social circles, and beyond:

Loving duty. These types feel a deep responsibility for those they care about. Specifically, Sentinels feel duty-bound to keep their loved ones safe and to help them lead good lives.

Always on time. Sure, Sentinels might occasionally fall behind schedule. But most of the time, they pride themselves on being unfailingly reliable. As a result, friends, loved ones, and coworkers can trust that Sentinels won't flake on their commitments.

Keepers of tradition. Sentinels work hard to maintain the ways things are done. In their home life, this means they love to continue family traditions. At the workplace, these types keep track of and defend best practices.

Unwavering diligence. Sentinels aren't afraid of hard work. On a daily basis, they practice their virtues of consistency and persistence, refusing to take shortcuts or stop before their work is done. And in situations where someone needs to step up and take responsibility, Sentinels can be counted on to come through.

Sentinels feel bolstered by having reliable people in their lives, and they make it a priority to hold up their end of the bargain. But even these dependable types can have their challenges, including:

Resistance to change. For Sentinels, trying new ways of doing things can feel wrong – almost like breaking an unwritten set of rules. These types can be skeptical of change, and they may stick with suboptimal choices on the grounds of “that’s how it’s always been done.”

Stubbornness toward others. Similarly, Sentinels may feel personally affronted when other people upset the status quo. What someone else might describe as “experimenting with new ideas” may seem reckless or disrespectful to Sentinels. As a result, these types might dig in their heels, even if that means forestalling progress.

Imposing their values. Sentinels love to give advice and shepherd people toward better lives – at least, what Sentinels consider better lives. It may be hard for these types to accept that not everyone holds stability, tradition, and respectability among their core values. And when other people don't follow their advice, Sentinels may want to judge them harshly.

Sentinels' loyalty and steadfastness shine in many situations. When they balance their firm convictions with curiosity and openness, these types can become nothing short of inspirations to the people in their lives.

Explorers: Observant (S) and Prospecting (P)

Explorers – Virtuosos, Adventurers, Entrepreneurs, and Entertainers – are self-reliant and quick-thinking. They're always ready to tackle a challenge or act on the spur of the moment. This spontaneity doesn't only help them solve problems – it also enables them to find opportunities for enjoyment in their everyday lives.

Here are a few of Explorers' notable strengths:

Surfing the waves. Many people struggle with change, but not Explorers. These types can adapt to new situations with minimal regret or second-guessing. In fact, they often enjoy change and appreciate breaks from routine.

Socially dynamic. Because of their openness, many Explorers enjoy meeting new people and trying out new social experiences. This helps them to build a network of diverse and interesting friends and acquaintances.

Getting things done. Explorers don't overthink things. Instead, they leap into action and get the job done. These types spend their energy on taking concrete steps, only pausing to consider abstract ideas or nitty-gritty details when it's absolutely necessary.

Picking up techniques. Utilitarian in their way, Explorers love to master new tools and techniques. Whatever their hobbies and passions, these types enjoy the challenge of building their skills and picking up new ways of doing things.

Explorers enjoy being free of obligations, where they can indulge themselves or their interests on their own time. Like most traits, this has its upsides and its downsides. Here are some tendencies that Explorers may need to counteract:

Losing interest. We all lose interest in our activities from time to time. But Explorers often run out of motivation as soon as a project no longer feels fun, novel, or exciting.

What planning? Explorers prefer to deal with challenges on the fly rather than plan ahead. Alas, sometimes an ounce of planning really is worth a pound of cure.

Risky business. Explorers are drawn to pleasure, risk, and – sometimes – risky pleasures. As they grow and mature, however, they often learn that some risks simply aren't worth taking.

Explorers connect with the world in a way that's almost childlike in its wonder and sheer fun. It can be a challenge for them to work for things with a distant or unexciting payoff, but when they harness their passion and administer just enough self-discipline, they can move heaven and earth.

Now, let's talk about you.

Personal Growth



Few other types are as mysterious as Mediators. Calm on the outside but brimming with passion on the inside, people with this personality type effortlessly blend earnestness, caution, and a certain airy wisdom. Always seeking peace and understanding, the dreams of harmony and the influence of empathy that make Mediators exceptional also can make them vulnerable and sensitive. Maturity and personal growth are essential pursuits for Mediators, and few people are more eager to deepen their understanding of themselves.

The most important goals for Mediators are achieving a sense of identity and finding a comfortable and productive balance between their emotions and their intellect. These dreamers strive to find the answers to questions such as, “Who am I?” “What is my purpose?” and “How can I make this world a better place?” However, these questions, as well as Mediators’ tendency toward constant inner reflection, can produce more questions than answers and more insight than action.

In a way, personal growth means becoming a hero and fulfilling a hero’s quest in one’s own life. Everyone has an image of what their lives should be, and growth is

about finding a path to fulfillment while overcoming obstacles that get in the way. For Mediators, it means, at least partly, opening their excessively inward natures while remaining introspective enough to gain insights that help them craft their vision for making their world a gentler place.

The Mediator motto might well be: “I thrive to serve, and I serve to thrive.” But that can’t be done from within a tightly cloistered existence. This is their challenge: to step beyond mere dreams of good intentions and turn them into reality.

Mediators’ emotions can be a positive force. Unchecked, tumultuous emotions can leave people feeling lost and confused, and without a steady foundation, they may feel perpetually shaken. Mediators develop personally when they learn to balance their emotions and their fertile imaginations with more objectively founded, larger truths.

Facets of Personal Growth

As part of a comprehensive view of personal growth for Mediators, we’ve separated the necessary components down into distinct facets. The first three facets of personal growth are motivational, and fulfilling them helps Mediators identify a more satisfying life. The latter two are more tactical, and require a more proactive approach. When questioning the role personal growth plays in a Mediator’s life, the first three facets are more likely to answer “Why?”, while the final two focus more on “How?”

The following reflective qualities hinge on self-awareness, an essential source of motivation for Mediators. In order to be happy, productive, and fulfilled, they must nurture these facets.

- **Self-esteem** speaks to Mediators' sense of their worth.
- **Self-respect** speaks to how much they like themselves.
- **Self-confidence** is where Mediators find the energy that moves them forward in life.

The following developmental strategies speak to the more active aspects of personal growth. Attending to the first three facets of personal growth often facilitates further development through these facets.

- **Self-evolution** describes a path of development that Mediators must follow to more fully reach their potential.
- **Self-responsibility** is Mediators' ability to take charge of their decisions and accept the consequences for doing so.

Much of Mediators' rationale for their thoughts, attitudes, and actions comes from trying to satisfy these needs and successfully meet their potential. An imbalance in any of the five facets, and particularly the first three, can become a source of overwhelming difficulty.

Mediators gain energy and personal power from discovering deep truths about themselves. Those who feel they fall short on self-esteem, self-respect, or self-confidence may turn to endless rumination in search of self-discovery, forgetting that many of those truths arise from engaging other people and living in the material world. Personal reflection is a strength, but when Mediators immerse themselves too much in introspection, problems occur.

In the following sections, we'll first explore balanced Mediators, who successfully use their strengths and adjust for their weaknesses while satisfying the three reflective qualities and employing self-evolution and self-responsibility. Then we'll consider

some possible challenges Mediators can face should they decide they aren't meeting their potential or engaging properly with their core personalities – in other words, if they become unbalanced.

Imbalance often occurs when individuals lose their sense of self-esteem, self-respect, or self-confidence, and it can lead Mediators to either inflate the importance of a characteristic or underutilize a strength. It can also involve not fully understanding the course they need to take to lead a more satisfying life. Such situations can be the product of conscious choices they make or subconscious impulses – so, finally, we'll suggest activities to start Mediators on the path to restoring balance.

Self-Esteem

Mediators get their self-esteem – their sense of worth – from their belief in their beliefs. They revere their beliefs and find a purpose in holding onto them. To them, their inner world is real, and nurturing it is important.

Balanced Self-Esteem

The Quality of Inspiration

On the surface, Mediators appear mild and temperate, and in many ways, they are – which leads many people to underestimate the passion of Mediators. Within these gentle souls, their dedication to justice, peace, and equality churn like a storm. The self-worth of these types comes from a powerful sense of connection to these thoughts, and they often wonder why the rest of the world doesn't feel the same. Mediators believe the planet would be a better place if others were more introspective. To people with this personality type, deep insights gained through self-

exploration are a precious commodity – the more they feel they possess these deep insights, the more worth they see in themselves.

Mediators serve meaning on a platter, first to themselves, and then, less so, to others – not as a matter of selfishness, but as a product of their sensitivity. This tendency leaves them guarded and private. Given the cultural bias in favor of the Extraverted, some may believe this means that Mediators offer little to the world, yet their insular, dreamy natures foster independent thought and being. When they share their perspectives, they often strike others as quite unique and creative – it's no accident these types find their worth in their rich inner musings.

Mediators may boost their own self-esteem by contributing to a cause or even joining a movement, but they're less social warriors than philosophers and visionaries with lessons to share, preferably in emotionally safe and inviting settings. They often work in helping or teaching professions, where they can more readily use their empathy and share their insights to small groups or individuals. They're likely to listen intently and internalize what others say: Sometimes, these types fulfill their purpose best with silence. Listening and understanding are enough to give them meaning. They're the people in the workplace who lend support to others, which may be more emotional than practical. Nonetheless, they provide an attentive ear or a shoulder to cry on. Mediators regard positive human connection as an affirmation of their own value, so they seek out ways to be attentive and encouraging in their quiet way.

Belief Without Dogma

Beyond their insight and idealism, Mediators have open minds and nonjudgmental attitudes when they have everything in perspective. Their ideals and beliefs are

essential to their self-esteem, and they would never rob others of their beliefs and ideals, however drastically they may differ from their own.

In true Mediator form, they often support the rights of others to live and believe as they wish just as passionately as they would defend their own choices. If they break the Mediator mold and follow an activist's lifestyle, they may become involved in organizations that support the rights of others to live as they choose. Because most prefer individual connections outside organized causes, their tolerance is most obvious in their daily lives. For them, affording others the same freedom of thought and behavior they enjoy themselves is an encouraging act. Doing so allows Mediators to feel as though they have contributed to an individual's or a culture's quality of life.

Unbalanced Self-Esteem

Things go off-kilter with self-esteem when Mediators are too protective of that which gives them a sense of worth, or when they feel they must prove to themselves (and perhaps others) that they're open-minded and supportive people. Either way, they may act in maladaptive ways to guard their self-esteem against assault.

When Connections Hurt

Mediators often hide their sensitivity. Those who aren't close to them may never see how easily people of this type can be hurt. They may even trick themselves into believing they aren't as sensitive as they are. Mediators who haven't acknowledged and understood their sensitivities may experience a veiled undercurrent of reactivity that affects everything in their lives.

People with this personality type are protective of the qualities that make them unique. Because their worth is bundled with their ideas and ponderings, when those

ideas are dismissed or attacked, they take it personally, and tend to nestle deeper into the safety of their inner lives. Consequently, Mediators are slow to share any of their inspired thoughts, and slow to let all but the most trusted people into their lives.

Mediators who haven't yet gained perspective on their sensitivity often detest conflict and criticism. No matter how objective or impersonal, criticism may strike these types as a misreading of their good intentions. Mediators who are already questioning their self-worth may be especially fragile in such instances: Because of their sensitivity, they may interpret the flaws others observe as an undermining of their whole purpose. For example, if a Mediator handed in a report with one section missing crucial data, they might feel like the error renders the entire report flawed and worthless. Mediators should avoid overgeneralizing when it comes to criticism.

Tolerance Becoming a Lack of Conviction

Mediators who keep a balanced perspective temper their open-mindedness and tolerance with an appreciation for the "big picture." They aren't likely to tolerate, for example, an extreme hate group: Realizing the pervasive damage such a group could potentially inflict on society, Mediators are likely to reject them or criticize them. However, when they lack the big picture, or when they cannot adequately respond for whatever reason, they may overcompensate, relying on a strength – in this case, tolerance – until it becomes a weakness. When an incident or event exceeds what they can tolerate, instead of passionate outrage, their reaction may be no more than an utterance: "Oh, my." These may find themselves allowing for behaviors that, from a more objective and balanced place, would feel inappropriate to them.

Mediators trying to restore a flagging sense of self-esteem may become so tolerant that they lose critical judgment in favor of an "everything goes" attitude. They so

desperately want acceptance that they no longer allow negative possibilities to inform their opinions, or they miss critical specifics that could alter their reactions or opinions. Mediators typically don't allow harm, so they're likely to find their own stances confusing or contradictory at times. But they won't find much help for their self-esteem in holding ill-chosen positions. Others may confuse such exaggerated Mediator acceptance with apathy about people doing harm to themselves or others.

Rebalancing Self-Esteem

All Mediators can benefit from tempering their emotions and instincts with a dose of rationality. As these types mature, they learn to manage their emotional instincts and judge criticism more objectively. This gives them greater emotional stability. Nevertheless, it isn't an easy approach, as they largely allow their feelings to inform their decisions and actions.

Objectivity can help Mediators when they fear that criticism is eroding their sense of worth – their insights and opinions. They often need a perspective that allows them to see that criticism is often limited in its meaning and scope. Healthy Mediators recognized that criticism may not be personal, and even if it is personal, it may not be meaningful: Critics sometimes harbor agendas that are at best unhelpful and at worst detrimental to the growth and progress of others. Learning to objectively assess criticism, while recognizing their sensitivities' influence on their reactions, can help Mediators handle critical comments more effectively. Once they banish the assumption that criticism inherently denounces their very being, they can then deal with feedback in a more constructive, less defensive manner.

Being too sensitive to criticism or conflict is often the product of Mediators indulging in assumptions. This is likely to occur if they elevate transitory emotions above their

stable, long-term convictions or the reality of their environment. These types aren't alone in assuming more than they can prove, but it can create unique problems for them. One way for them to avoid toppling the tower of self-esteem is to fortify the foundation. One way to fortify self-esteem is with a game of "Test the Assumption":

- Write down a few assumptions you have: about your life, your work, your friends, your family...
- Every day you want to play the game, choose one assumption as the "Assumption of the Day." For that day, you are focused on this assumption.
- Look for a way to test the assumption. In many cases, the best way is simply asking the right people the right questions.
 - For example, if the assumption is that a report is without any merit simply because a manager criticized one of the graphs, ask the manager to clarify what the criticism meant.
- Was your assumption correct? Great! You understand the world a little better than you might have thought.
- Was your assumption wrong? Great! You know with certainty that you had wrongly assumed, and now you can change that assumption.

Make it a point to spot assumptions throughout the day, and test them as soon as possible. Even if they're hard to find, accept the challenge to look for them. Keep it on a game level and have a little fun.

Open-Minded, Yet Discerning

Mediators know well that not everything in life is good or worth supporting. Nonetheless, should they decide they need to prove their value by showing how strong their empathy is, they may fail to judge when judging is desirable. This can

eventually backfire because they define their worth by compassionate connection to others, and an “anything goes” attitude counters that impulse in the long run. There is a difference between using judgment and being judgmental.

Shoring up their values and their sense of mission, no matter how often they change, is the best way to keep Mediators on track and judging wisely. The following exercise is one way to organize internal thoughts and ideas so that they can inform Mediators’ outer actions and opinions in a consistent manner:

- Write three statements which quintessentially describe deeply-held values. You can write physical notes on post-its or notecards, or use a digital note-keeping method.
- Post these value notes somewhere that you’ll see them a lot: around the house, at the office, in your car. If you’re keeping track digitally, add these notes to your phone or desktop background, or any other place you can’t miss them.
- Throughout the day, consider these three values and how you apply them, if at all.
 - If they aren’t being applied, consider ways to act on them. Consider discussing the subject with a close friend.
- After one week of posting up your values, consider all three statements. It isn’t unusual to discover that some values come from external sources, and aren’t values you genuinely embrace. Acknowledging this, and adjusting accordingly, is simply another form of growth. Revise any inconsistent values, and continue as desired.

Mediators’ positive self-esteem comes from the sense they understand others in a significant and constructive way. Built into this are tolerance and a need to support

the growth and well-being of others without judging or forcing them to walk a specific path. When Mediators' self-esteem serves them well, those qualities shine in their pure form without any defensive or hidden motives.

Self-Respect

People who have positive self-respect are, simply, people who like themselves. When self-respect is strong, they have no fear of looking in their mental mirrors because they like what they see. People who like themselves are obviously happier and more satisfied with their lives. Beyond that, they're likely to care for themselves better and make better choices. People do more for those they like, and therefore treat them better. The same principle applies to liking oneself.

Balanced Self-Respect

Mediators respect themselves most when they believe they help victims of evil and injustice, especially when they simultaneously discover more about themselves. They want to see themselves as a humane force in the world, but not necessarily through big acts – just big ideas. Doing good may be personal or global, and their altruistic efforts can be as simple as boosting a single child's self-esteem or as ambitious as working to solve world hunger. These heroes are likely to be more inspirational than hands-on, and they benefit from others organizing the rescue while they gently provide the emotional and motivational support.

To the (Emotional) Rescue

Concern for others consumes Mediators, and they dream of ways they can help make the world a better place. They value integrity above all else. They have little patience for political movements or agendas, preferring to find individual ways to make a

difference and support others. Making sure that those around them feel comfortable, providing them a shoulder to cry on, listening attentively to their concerns – these are just some of the ways that Mediators show respect to others. They feel they're at their best when they help people they care about gain insight and a richer understanding of themselves. As a bonus, they end up liking themselves as well.

Embracing Something Bigger

The blocks that build Mediators' self-respect are more than simple good deeds. They live in a world of ideas and theories, and their notions always have a central human element. Their emotions sway their understanding, as if they possess a kind of ethical DNA that influences their attitudes and outcomes. Although their code may evolve, Mediators do good for others based on more high-minded purposes than simple, practical need.

People with this personality type remind the world to think beyond petty and self-centered concerns. They may not be on street corners shouting about the ways humankind should live, but quietly, and in everyday ways, Mediators live with an eye toward moral standards. This doesn't mean their actions always align with their ideals; nobody is perfect. However, when they take the moral high ground – mostly in their thoughts and occasionally in the things they do – Mediators can look at themselves with respect.

Unbalanced Self-Respect

Unfulfilled Idealism

Mediators' extreme idealism, paired with their occasional journeys deep into their own imaginations, can lead to impossible expectations. They often care so much about an idea that they struggle to accept the reality that its execution may not be perfect. A winnowing process is required to separate a good idea or two from the many others that can end up creating an overwhelming flood of unfulfilled intentions. If Mediators need to realize their ideals fully before they can like themselves, they'll always suffer from poor self-respect.

Should they attempt to bring about the ideal by doing good works, perfectionistic Mediators are likely to notice only the aspects that are "not quite perfect." It becomes obvious they can't do good to the degree their idealism demands, potentially resulting in frustration and surrender to a deep sense of failure and ineffectiveness.

Talking Down to Themselves

Some Mediators have trouble creating or preserving positive self-respect because their intentions often go unrealized. They sincerely want to help improve the lives of others, and they have strong convictions about how that should happen. But they don't always have the focus needed to pull together a working plan. If their inability to turn a constellation of emotions into effective actions becomes too troubling, their self-talk may hone in on their own perceived hypocrisies and failures.

In such instances, Mediators may take a more dogmatic approach to the causes they value, trying to convince themselves and others of their fervent belief in helping people. Such uncharacteristically passionate displays can overshadow the

observable fact that they aren't acting on their convictions. If their goals and intentions are stated loudly and persistently enough, everyone might forget the sparseness of the results – or so unbalanced Mediators may believe, for a time.

Rebalancing Self-Respect

Setting Realistic Goals

Idealism can be noble, but when taken too far, it masks reality. Mediators are among the most idealistic personality types, apt to rely on their hearts instead of their heads when making decisions. Their imaginations are so fertile and filled with principles that organizing them into action – and even finding a place to begin – can be a challenge.

Being rational isn't the same as being heartless, however, and injecting pragmatism into a plan doesn't have to water down compassion. Mediators may see rationality and compassion as incompatible entities. This is a false dichotomy; in fact, being sensible is necessary to making a difference in the world. Filtering principles, beliefs, and visions through rationality while still honoring their emotional decision-making preference allows these types to create goals that lead to more intentional results.

Although they aren't naturally goal-oriented, Mediators may need to work toward goals to know whether they're being effective. Good planning takes concepts beyond dreams and visions and turns them into action. Some research has found a correlation between individuals with anxiety and depression and people whose goals are vague. While this is by no means the case for all Mediators, it suggests that, with crisp and concrete goals, these types may feel better about themselves.

Here are some steps to facilitate specific goal-setting:

- Decide on a goal, and create a short list of statements. Avoid words such as “feeling” and “being.” Use measurable action words, such as “provide,” “build,” “promote,” “expand,” “develop,” “deliver,” and “streamline.” Make these statements so precise that the physical movement fills the mind’s eye.
- Use numbers to define success. For example, “Expand the food bank’s program to distribute 300 lunches to the homeless around town every Saturday.”
- Consider whether the goal, as established, is achievable. This entails knowing deeper information about the absolute statements and numbers you’ve already set.
 - In the above example, this means asking, “Can we gather the ingredients, assemble the lunches, and find 300 people to feed on a Saturday afternoon? Will we have enough food, enough workers, and enough clients to make this a viable venture?” Approached in this manner, the achievement of the goal is quantifiable.

Overcoming Negativity

When they’re overwhelmed by their idealistic and perfectionistic tendencies, Mediators may find themselves resorting to negativity, becoming judgmental, and even isolating themselves – a dangerous habit for this sensitive personality type. As their self-respect comes from helping others find their potential, vision, and happiness, they’re unlikely to satisfy it if they isolate themselves either physically or emotionally.

Once these types realize they can accept or even celebrate their imperfections, they’re likely to ease up on themselves, and they can begin to appreciate things about

themselves they'd never noticed or had even seen as flaws. A sense of humor can help a lot with this.

Here are some steps to begin a journey to a more positive sense of self – normal, human blemishes and all:

- Choose an activity that is challenging but not overwhelming, such as participating in a sport or artistic activity, or doing a small home repair. (Pay attention to all safety issues, and keep in mind that a good challenge is difficult but not impossible.)
- Engage in the activity knowing that good enough is sometimes good enough.
- When finished, assess the activity. Was it perfect? Even if it wasn't, was it a worthy effort? Celebrate the flaws with a good laugh.
- Ponder what the exercise says about being perfect.

When Mediators have a negative perspective, it's often the result of unrealistic expectations and an inability to fulfill their imagined ideals. For these types, embracing optimism can seem overwhelming, especially during difficult times, and yet the easiest way is to counter perfectionism with forgiveness – the same forgiveness Mediators give so easily to others.

Self-Confidence

Self-confidence reflects the energy channeled when individuals trust in their thoughts, feelings, and abilities. The greater the self-confidence, the more energy goes into moving forward in life. Although many elements influence how confidently people live, members of each personality type have distinctive traits that affect their self-confidence levels.

Balanced Self-Confidence

Who They Hope to Be

Mediators get their confidence from feeling connected to their own identity and aspirations. Anything these types regard as phony disappoints them; Mediators they try to be as “real” as possible, and masks, lies, and insincerity cause them great uneasiness and disappointment. However, living according to their ideals can be a tall order. Their rich imagination always entertains thoughts of how the world, and all its inhabitants, should operate.

Going through life with such aims can provide Mediators with an optimistic outlook they can use to encourage themselves and others to be better people. When Mediators lend an ear to others, as they often do, they advise with a sense of self-assurance because their advice is heartfelt and feels honest. Grounded Mediators find confidence not so much in what they do, but in what they dream. Whenever they can connect even a part of such dreams to the world around them, it bolsters their confidence and helps them move forward with a sense of purpose.

Maintaining Confidence in a Material World

Although they're focused inward, Mediators still live in the physical world and must find enough confidence to persevere in that realm. When motivated, they adopt positive characteristics that bring sufficient measure of outward success or, at the very least, survival. (After all, even these gentle dreamers cannot dream up their next meal, so they must attend to the practical business of living.) Even when adapting to the outer world, Mediators never wander far from their imaginative inner lives.

Those seeking guidance are unlikely to spend much time leafing through self-help books, which they tend to see as superficial and mercenary. These types more often seek help in psychology, philosophy, religion, or “New Age” texts – disciplines that speak to their hearts as well as minds, and ground them in their unique way.

Unbalanced Self-Confidence

Honestly Inflexible

Mediators in a crisis of confidence may overcompensate by pushing their own agendas. Insecure people are often the loudest voices in the room. These types are usually very subdued, gentle people, and rarely the loudest voice, but if intent on restoring their confidence they can abandon their characteristic open-mindedness to serve themselves. Although rigidity and dogmatic behavior is clearly atypical for them, these are natural reactions for Mediators who doubt their connection to their core selves and feel compelled to reinforce it.

This tendency will backfire as Mediators impede the growth and well-being of others – and their own – with their new behaviors. To re-align themselves with their principles, they may, paradoxically, lose sight of one of their overarching values: protecting the welfare of others. Being true to themselves doesn’t necessarily entail centering their own preferences, but Mediators who doubt themselves and try to artificially inflate their confidence risk making this very mistake.

Deep Introspection

Those who are unsure of themselves may look even further inward than usual, in search of further clues to their own identities and ways to fit that identity into their lives. This misses a crucial fact: people sometimes learn more about themselves by

their responses to other people, and by other people's response to them. Although letting others define them certainly isn't the standard path to personal growth for Mediators, navel-gazing isolation brought about by insecurity may rob them of an opportunity for more comprehensive self-discovery. These types can learn a lot about themselves from other people, if they take the chance.

Mediators who cloister themselves to protect their true natures might well preserve a sense of integrity: A trip outside the metaphorical walls of their own isolation may allow other peoples to challenge, criticize, and perhaps even painfully reject them for simply being who they are. For rare, Introverted types, isolation can be tempting. However, too much time worrying about what is "real" and "genuine" about themselves may, against their intentions, siphon away energy from expressing their realness and genuineness. Instead of securing their self-confidence as intended, too much inward focus can erode it. For real confidence, Mediators may need to break free of introspection long enough to practice what they ponder.

Rebalancing Self-Confidence

Restoring Open-Minded Confidence

True confidence allows people to act with the right measure of assuredness. Too little confidence means no energy. But Mediators artificially inflating confidence by stubbornly insisting that their reality is superior to any other isn't a good option either. In the end, many Mediators find that lacking energy is easier to contend with than repelling the people they want to help. Better yet, these types should reconnect with that which gives them genuine confidence.

One way to rebalance self-confidence involves consciously connecting purpose and principles to the actions the Mediators take:

- List your ideals, purposes, and intentions. This list doesn't have to be complete or comprehensive, and it should be realistic and actionable.
- Support other peoples throughout your day in ways that are consistent with the values on the list. It can be as simple as encouraging a grocery clerk for carefully bagging groceries.
- Keep a tally of the people you've supported. Accountability, even to yourself, promotes a greater level of action.

Mediators develop and preserve self-confidence by approaching life with integrity and genuineness, such that their lives reflect their values and purpose. The above exercise can help them review what's important to them while encouraging outreach to others in small and large ways. Activities like this one promote connection between subjective values and objective actions – essential for restoring balance.

Testing Their Truths

To fulfill their identity needs, Mediators must cultivate their inner qualities in Introverted solitude and express them in the outer world. There is no “either/or” – both are necessary components for nurturing growth. Should these types find themselves concealing their genuine selves from the world, they may want to pursue tests of their identity in safe yet challenging ways. When solitude becomes isolation, Mediators should make a conscious effort to counteract unhelpful seclusion. An easy technique for nurturing connectedness is to share a meal:

- Choose a day within the next month to invite someone to lunch or dinner, someone who isn't a regular guest: An old friend or acquaintance, or a trustworthy person you've recently met.

- Don't cook? Eat out or order take-out. It's about the time together, not the food.
- Make sure to allow plenty of time so that this casual meeting isn't rushed. Relax and enjoy yourself.
- Whether it was a satisfying event or not, it was the opposite of isolation. If it wasn't satisfying, try another person. If it was, consider a follow-up meeting.

Self-Evolution

Self-evolution is the process of taking a more purposeful role in growth, understanding oneself better, and learning how to effect change in the world. For Mediators, this must include finding ways to act. Although they're often viewed as merely well-intentioned, people with this personality type can be so much more, and they're well-equipped with the imagination needed to breathe life into their dreams and visions.

Balanced Self-Evolution

Meeting Real Challenges

Mediators are very interested in growth, but self-evolution goes beyond the organic style of development many of them imagine. Self-evolution is a more deliberate scheme that allows people with this personality type to transform their lives for the better. Self-esteem, self-respect, and self-confidence fuel the self-evolution engine. Self-evolution returns the favor by organizing Mediators' responses to the three. When they're all working together, they create a powerful engine that propels their life toward fulfillment.

Mediators can take many paths to evolve. They might take a route created by someone else – maybe following spiritual, philosophical, or religious direction. Or, they might develop their own growth practices from various other sources and life experiences. Whatever their process for growth, it likely involves empathy, altruism, imaginative perspectives, and open-mindedness. Mediators distinguish between self-help as a utilitarian approach that brings them physical or emotional gains and self-growth as the natural result of living “correctly.” Generally, if they happen to pursue such practices, they’re likely more aligned with meditation, which raises awareness, than with self-hypnosis, which pursues goals.

However, genuine growth for Mediators means they have evolved to harness their dreams and extend them into the real world, translating vision into practice. Evolved Mediators have met the challenge this task represents, and in so doing they’ve unlocked their incredible potential.

Growth Without End

Those who successfully advance in their self-evolution are aware of their strengths and weaknesses, and they develop life goals around them. However, that’s only part of the story. As with all types, finding and utilizing their strengths alone isn’t sufficient: Becoming well-rounded and expanding beyond one’s comfort zone are part of the formula for growth. For Mediators, this means attaching meaningful actions to their otherwise contemplative lives.

The famous saying, “Life is a journey, not a destination,” rings true for most Mediators. Self-evolution is a continuing, lifelong course of digging deep into their beliefs and worldviews. More than most, Mediators see themselves in a state of perpetual transformation. Between their constantly shifting focus and their

expansive imaginations, everything remains fluid. For them, no milestone along the way marks the completion of their developmental work because, in their view, they never finish. That may sound exhausting to some, but not knowing what “finished” looks like often excites Mediators.

Unbalanced Self-Evolution

Inflated Expectations

One of the difficulties Mediators find with self-evolution is that their ideals are so utopian that it would be impossible to match them in real life. Excessively high expectations can become discouraging when trying to make those expectations happen. To make things more difficult, Mediators’ thoughts resemble a web rather than a straight line: One notion veers off to three others, which veers off to nine more. It can be intimidating to untangle all those thoughts into something resembling a goal. It can be daunting to even find a starting place, much less a successful conclusion.

The unbalanced response to Mediators’ gloriously tangled webs and lofty ideals is to treat them as ends in themselves. Trying to sort disparate strands into action plans often leads to frustration and can eventually result in a loss of confidence. Eventually, those who haven’t found a way to pull all their thoughts into some reasonable, organized formation may become discouraged. One of their developmental challenges involves acting despite their own disorganization and staying hopeful about progress. For Mediators struggling with this imbalance, negative self-talk is likely to become the prominent voice in their heads.

A Mesmerizing Path

People with the Mediator personality type not only become fascinated by the ideas their imaginations create, and experience awe at the wonders of the world around them. However, indulging their inner poets can entangle Mediators, who may even confuse their focus on beauty and wonder with genuine growth. The steps needed for practical development are unlikely to be found in an unending appreciation for abstract ideas and perpetual awe over the beauty of existence. On a practical level, a dream will never beat a plan.

As Lewis Carroll wrote, “If you don’t know where you are going, any road will get you there.” Mesmerized by the intangible and lacking any measurable goals, Mediators may find themselves on a road to nowhere. Life may start to feel empty for them, as they, like everyone else, must exist in a material world where the common measure of success is the practical impact of an individual’s life. Life may be a journey, but if that journey involves only meandering, then serious questions about purpose are likely to arise in the minds of the wanderers.

Rebalancing Self-Evolution

Embracing Growth Responsibly

When it comes to Self-Evolution, Mediators need to mind their tendency towards unrealistic expectations. Even more than this, they may want to address things they tell themselves that suggest they can’t find a moderate and more practical path to growth. If they *believe* they can sort out their web of beliefs and intentions and find a path that works, they’re more likely to do just that. Fortunately, Mediators’ imaginations, when martialled and organized, are just the tools they need to nurture positive beliefs that lead to strategies that work well for them.

For Mediators, true growth comes from granting themselves the same compassion and empathy they give to others. This can include developing self-talk that encourages progress rather than paralysis. To that end, they can try role-playing. The following “Be Your Own Best Friend” exercise is well within the scope of their imaginations:

- List the negative things you tell yourself about your life or actions. Try to come up with five or more.
- Put two chairs face-to-face.
- When you sit in one chair, you are simply you. When you sit in the other chair, you are your own best friend.
- Sit in “your” chair and describe one of your negatives you wrote down, as if talking to your best friend.
- Switch chairs. As “your own best friend,” reassure yourself, as you would any friend. Explore any negative self-talk from a more compassionate perspective and search for balance and realistic implications.
- Do this until you have given yourself a good, positive talking-to about everything on your list.
- If this seems silly or awkward, try it alone or with a trusted and willing friend.

Accepting a little help, especially from themselves, can help Mediators balance their needs and move their ideas forward.

Reconnecting

Human life and growth depend on insights and natural evolution. But the cosmos expresses life through action, and although it’s impossible for humans to avoid all exertion of effort, it’s possible to suppress the tendency. Some Mediators, at times,

may avoid taking action by encapsulating themselves in their world of ideas and beliefs: endlessly searching for meaning means never settling, and without the stability of definition, the foundation for building is shaky. However, those who self-evolve ask not only, “What I am about?” but also, “What is it I do?”

Mediators interested in genuine self-development must break the cycle typical of the type: rumination punctuated by hypnotic effects of inspirational moments. Self-evolution doesn’t require abandoning the search for insight, or ignoring moments filled with profound, self-actualizing experiences: it requires harnessing some of that energy to create something concrete. For these types, finding ways to do so can be a lifelong challenge, but one worth accepting and well within their abilities.

The following exercise can give Mediators a small taste of transforming a more emotional response into a concrete action:

- Find the most beautiful object available in the vicinity.
- Get a plain piece of paper and a pencil. A regular pencil is fine, but a colored pencil may make the exercise more interesting.
- Draw the object, trying to get as close to photographic accuracy as possible. This is a private exercise, so simply do your best.
- Should your mind drift toward more symbolic or abstract considerations, return to thoughts of lines, shadows, and shades. Be a camera more than an artist.
- Consider posting the picture or saving it as reminder to view things exactly as they are, rather than through a subjective filter.

Connecting to physical things can help Mediators balance their rich internal experience. Much like mindfulness mediation, the only goal is to notice the world as

it is – rather than the way it should be. Mediators who manage such a balance create a paradigm in which they can enjoy the best of both realms.

Self-Responsibility

Self-responsibility sounds simple, but it can be difficult to practice. People who grasp a sense of self-responsibility decide matters for themselves, act independently, and follow interests without being excessively reliant on the opinions or permission of others.

Balanced Self-Responsibility

Morally Independent

Mediators test responsibility by running relevant issues through their ethical filters – filters which don't necessarily align with what society considers moral. Morals are the product of personal insight for these types, more so than the product of a cultural code, but the individual nature of their values doesn't make Mediators any less beholden to them.

As an example, Mediators are often sympathetic to those whom others may consider outcasts on moral or religious grounds. On some level, these types may feel a responsibility to at least ponder issues of fairness for those who are different, perhaps even staking out a radical position. As people with this type are so rare and often regarded as almost eccentric, it may be easy for them to identify with such groups. More importantly, however, their moral decisions come from within rather than from the masses.

In other words, Mediators' sense of responsibility is moral and independent in nature. Although they may benefit from the lessons of teachers and gurus and take them seriously, they aren't likely to let their final decisions rest on any teachings. This control from within matches the many other internal aspects of what it means to be Mediators.

Unbalanced Self-Responsibility

Becoming Helpless

The disconnect some Mediators experience between their aspirations and their accomplishments can feel like constant failure in the face of constant effort. They may acquire a sense that no matter what they do, they'll never gain traction, and eventually they start asking themselves and people around them, "Why bother?" Because Mediators are so idealistic, their failures may be as innocuous as the everyday disappointments that come with perfectionism – with such a mentality, anything less than perfection is inadequate. Such frustrations can strip these types of their sense of control, leading them to conclude they're helpless and powerless.

If Mediators believe they have no control and that nothing is effective, they may conclude there's no point in trying to do anything. Because of the moral overtones of their lives and their sensitivity, abdication of responsibility may result in a full-blown moral crisis. They may start to think of themselves as not just helpless people but as moral failures, and negative self-talk can once again gain a foothold.

Loss of Serenity

People often feel they don't have control not because it doesn't exist, but because they convince themselves it's absent. Others may lose it because they confuse the

things they can control with the things they can't. For Mediators, who live so much in their imaginations, sorting out what is and isn't their responsibility can be more difficult because they're able to create so many varied scenarios in their minds. The dilemma can worsen when they have an abundance of principles and a sense of responsibility but no practical idea of how to use these assets.

Rebalancing Self-Responsibility

Helpless to Helpful

The best and most obvious way to beat an acquired sense of helplessness is success – which usually requires clear intentions and an action plan. Intention may come easily to Mediators, and they can learn to develop clarity and a plan of attack. Although they can certainly gain planning skills independently, they can also consider partnering with others who have already developed them, or those who have a natural knack for getting things done. One of the best ways to learn is by doing, and such partnerships are likely to encourage participation, which leads to picking up helpful habits.

The following exercise requires some thought, a little planning, and a measure of action:

- Set a two-minute timer. Think of the nicest thing that can be done for a specific person.
- Set a 10-minute timer, and list the following things:
 - What actions is needed to fulfill the nice thing?
 - What resources will be needed, if any?
 - By what date and time will the nice thing be done?
- Follow the dictum, "Plan your work and work your plan."

- On completing the plan, celebrate by doing something nice for yourself.
- Repeat this exercise once a week for a month or more.

Discerning Control

Deciding what they can change and then making concrete, measurable plans to change it can help Mediators restore their sense of responsibility – but, first things first. Organize the lush variety of ideas that constitute their consciousness into areas they can and cannot influence themselves may help them determine, “What am I responsible for, and what am I not responsible for?”

However, sorting presents Mediators with choices. They may need to let go of things they cannot control, or allow themselves to go with the flow. Regarding the things they can control, they may need to determine whether the situation needs controlling, whether the responsibility belongs to them, and how they should address their responsibility.

This exercise can help Mediators recognize and reflect upon their level of control:

- Wear a visually distinct or noticeable item, one you wouldn’t typically wear. This can be as simple as a rubber band or a piece of string, and as bold or obvious as you dare.
- Each time you or someone else takes notice of this accessory, ask yourself as a reflex, “What do I control in this situation? What is out of my control?”
- What reaction, if any, did this exercise elicit from other people? Were there any surprises?

It’s hard to take responsibility without focus. Mediators need to connect to their values to discover the right motivations, focus on the things they can control, and

then commit to decisive and specific actions. When they manage their goals in this way, focus is likely to accompany them throughout their efforts.

Conclusion

When you talk about personal growth in Mediators, you can't get far without some reference to spirituality. Some define this as a person being part of something bigger than themselves. For some, this may feel like connecting to some sort of higher consciousness. Even Mediators without a spiritual practice or religion explore ideas that are bigger than they are. Such ideas involve their own growth and the growth and well-being of others, and much of their development depends on responding to what they discover.

Those who use their strengths while expanding their comfort zones often find that growth is a balance between staying true to themselves while adapting to the world around them. By understanding their moral foundations and acting in ways that honor them, Mediators can create fulfillment and live purposefully. Learning when to stand resolute, and when to be flexible and open to feedback, helps these types discover a path toward evolution and development. When they do, they become heroes in their own lives.

Each Mediator has their own spin on life, having adapted to their unique worlds in different ways. Some skillfully navigate the process of personal growth, and others struggle to make any headway, but everyone fluctuates between days filled with wonderful growth and times that lack such improvement: No one lives the perfect life of their imagination. Nonetheless, growth and learning are always choices for those who are willing. Hopefully, we've provided some guidance and inspiration to bolster that willingness.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your personal growth? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

Locus of Control Test

Dig deeper into who or what you feel is responsible for your life satisfaction, happiness, and level of fulfillment.

Emotional Intelligence Test

Find out how good you are at understanding your own emotions as well as paying attention to the emotions of others with this test.

Confidence Test

How much do you believe in your competence and ability to successfully follow through on the choices you make? Let's find out.

Dark and Light Side Test

Your moral choices may not be as simple as you think. This test asks you to go deep and take an honest look at your attitudes.

Resilience and Grit Test

Some people are hard to knock down; some find it easy to get back up; and some are both or neither. Which group do you belong to?

Coping Styles Test

There are four primary ways to cope with crisis. This test explores the dominant and secondary techniques you're likely to turn to.

Optimism and Pessimism Test

This simple test measures your levels of both optimism and pessimism in a novel way. Find out where you fall in each of these areas.

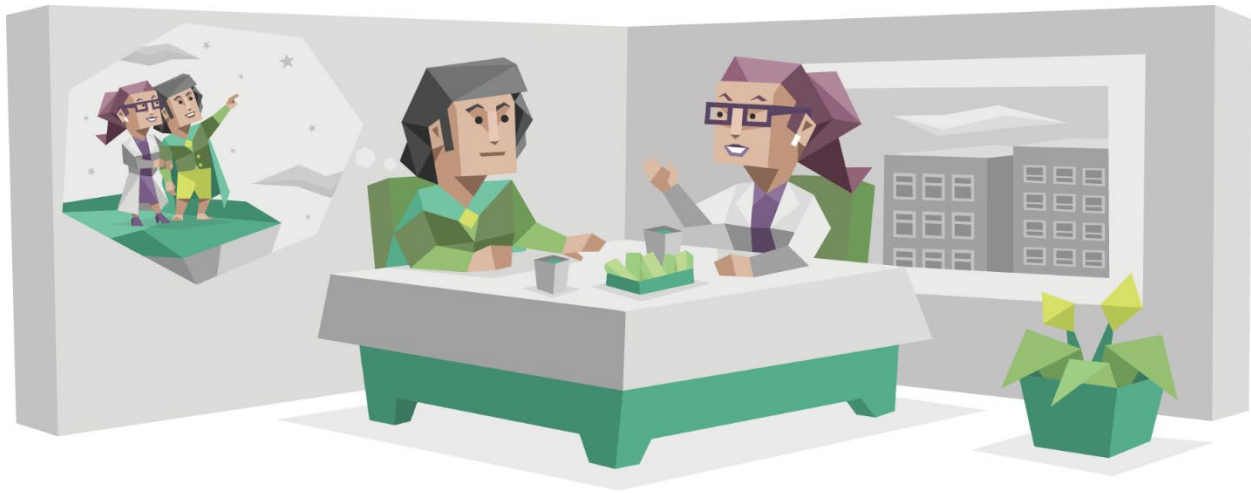
Imagination and Magic Beliefs Test

How does your imagination work? What is your belief about magic? Explore the role of imagination, magic, and belief in your life.

Traveling Preferences Test

This simple test delves into your preferred choices during those times when you leave home to explore the world.

Romantic Relationships



Seeking a Deep Connection

Mediators are starry-eyed, romantic idealists who often daydream about perfect relationships abundant in harmony and warmth – a union of souls communicating their deepest truths and feelings. For these types, looking for partners or nurturing existing relationships are often essential goals. This idealism is among their most appealing romantic qualities, even if they sometimes set them up for disappointment when others can't match their pure, open-hearted love.

These types offer their partners bright enthusiasm and joy, using their vivid imaginations to come up with insightful ways to keep their romantic relationships lively. This is a particularly endearing quality in early dating: the fun never stops with Mediators. Many of the other personality types thrill at the novelty that Mediators bring to dates, while others struggle to keep up with brilliance, whimsy, and spontaneity, especially amidst the uncertainty and unfamiliarity of early dating.

Mediators engage deeply with ideas, beliefs, and dreams, which can challenge partners of personality types that think mainly in routine and live by a plan. When

partners don't share their fondness for the fantastical, abstract dimensions of things, Mediators may lose interest – they want lovers to at least listen to their imaginings. Moreover, these types want to share in their partners' dreams, and to participate with gentle encouragement and excitement. It's only natural that they want their partners to reciprocate.

Embracing Change

Mediators possess a quiet lightness of being, and can be very optimistic and accepting even in the face of unforeseen events. They appreciate moving into new experiences. However, their energy can swing like a pendulum: They may be warmly social with close friends and lovers sometimes, and contemplative and solitary at other times, with these same people. These types embrace the transitions, and those who love them face a lot of unexpected changes.

Mediators' views on romantic relationships may often be poetic, but they're not always realistic. Their tendency to idealize their lovers can sometimes create confusion as both partners react to changing expectations. However, if Mediators are mature enough to recognize and address these tendencies, they reap great rewards in their efforts toward personal growth. Even if their imaginations get carried away now and then, Mediators treat their romantic partners to deep, caring warmth that transcends many problems.

A Need for Harmony

While they adapt wonderfully to many aspects of love, Mediators' desire for harmony with their partners means that they typically avoid criticism and conflict. While this can contribute to the stability of their relationships, it can also cause subtle problems: These types may find it hard to speak up for their own interests, often allowing their

needs to become secondary to those of their lovers. This lack of communication has the potential to disrupt the balance in a relationship, and it can be a hard habit to break.

Even when they make their voices heard, Mediators may struggle to receive criticism or hear contradictory ideas without interpreting them as faults in themselves – they're highly sensitive, and may respond with anger or simply feel wounded. They almost reflexively subliminate themselves in favor of those they love, and while this is wonderful with romantic partners who are equally caring and perceptive, it's not always fair with those less sensitive than they are.

Adapting to Love

While the potential exists for these types to lose touch with their own needs amidst their devotion to their partners, they also find great joy in adapting to other people's unique presence in their lives. Love gives Mediators a chance to experience new perspectives, and a balanced version of "losing themselves" in their partners can be magical, as if they enter another world by engaging their partners' desires. When they maintain their own perceptions and preferences as well, such discovery together can be exciting and healthy.

Another wonderful facet of Mediators' ability to explore and adapt is that they open the minds of stubborn or tradition-bound partners. Highly empathetic, people with this personality type aren't likely to judge their loved ones. However, through gentle coaxing, they can easily make people think twice about their habits, opening them to new ideas. Mediators' imaginative curiosity can be inspiring, and partners immersed in their own daily routine can find their sweet influence as freeing as a vacation.

Potential Role Pairings

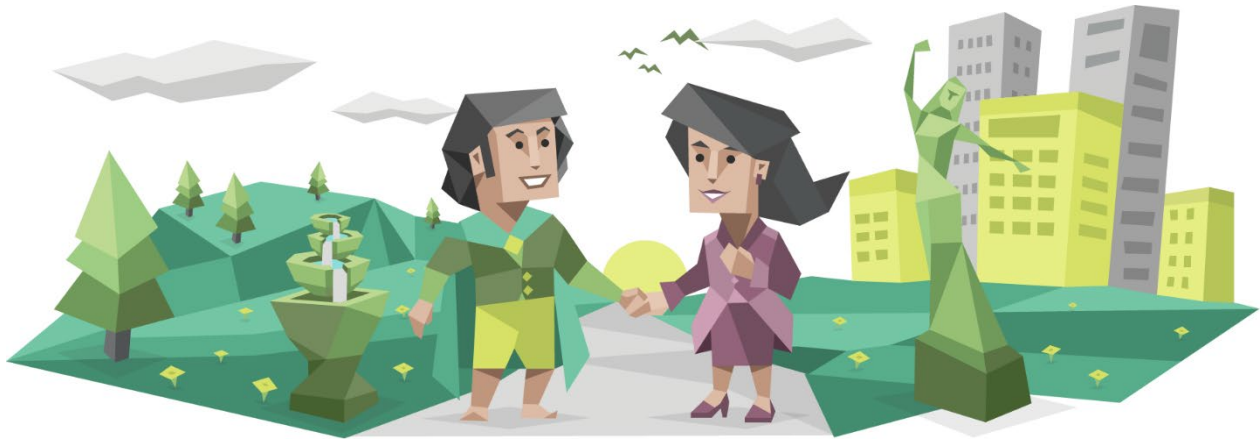
Unique Opportunities

Every personality type brings different things to their romantic relationships, and knowing a little about what to expect from different Role groups helps Mediators get to know potential partners and build solid relationships. However, it's important to remember that people are unique, regardless of their type, and while a perfect romance can exist in novels and television shows, the real world is not so perfect. Any people who fall in love may get along wonderfully and may have a few problems; in healthy relationships, they're likely to experience both.

In this section, we lay out guidance on how Mediators and other types can better understand each other, including some of the more likely areas of conflict between them. Warm, empathetic, and adaptable, Mediators can truly find balanced love with any other type, so long as the individuals involved demonstrate qualities that enable fair and loving connections.

Mediators should consider that the issues raised in the Personal Growth chapter may relate to their approach to love. Romantic relationships provide good context for self-evolution, and ensure that unproductive or destructive habits aren't present. Self-love and self-respect build people who are ultimately able to be happier romantic partners.

Mediator-Analyst Relationships



Love between Mediators and Analysts often grows from the way they balance each other's weaknesses and learn from each other's strengths. Linked by the Intuitive trait, both types can see the wonderful possibilities that the other brings into their lives, and find such potential intriguing. Mediators think in terms of human connection and Analysts in terms of rational processes, and, in each other, these imaginative lovers find not only a whole new way of thinking, but also new dimensions of themselves.

Balanced Mediator-Analyst Relationships

Shared Imagination

Mediators' imagination can provide great ways to get to know Analyst partners. Both thrive on creative discussions, from sharing ideas about a product they're developing to explaining the intricacies of a book they're writing. Analyst partners find it easy to keep up with imaginative processes, and delight in assisting with brainstorming on any front. Complex and abstract ideas enthrall these pairs, and they can spend endless hours together discussing philosophical topics or coming up with ideas.

Relationships between Mediators and Analysts can be incredibly rewarding, as these individuals look at things from a different yet somehow familiar perspective. When Mediators are interested in complex topics, they spend a significant amount of time not just studying the concrete details, but also contemplating the intangible side of the topic. Analysts are often impressed by the depth of understanding that Mediators gain by using their hearts as well as their minds.

Mediators are no less impressed by Analysts' ability to make decisions through rational processes. Those who maintain open-mindedness see the value in Analysts' ability to remain objective, a detachment that Mediators sometimes find personally challenging. They appreciate Analyst partners who anchor their fantastical take on life with blunt intellectualism. In turn, their Analyst lovers value Mediators' ability to take any imagined subject to the next level.

Discovering New Abilities

Besides sharing complementary imaginations, these couples can be profoundly helpful to each other's growth. They can learn a lot from each other in how they express emotion differently. Analysts have plenty of emotion, but rarely place emphasis on expressing or understanding their feelings, and may even deride such efforts, often seeming distant and clumsy with such matters. Mediators are perfectly suited to helping Analysts understand this side of themselves, providing an example of being in touch with their feelings.

This learning goes the other way as well. To be frank, Mediators are a type likely to become lost in emotion, especially during upsetting events. There are many moments in life where they'd be wise to step back, detach, and think about what's happening instead of being swept along by their feelings. The cool-headed example

of thoughtful Analyst partners helps them practice such skills during moments of heightened emotion. Having them by their side as an example is a powerful reminder to Mediators of the self-control they can develop if they choose.

The balance these two can bring each other translates directly into daily life, not just abstract concepts of growth. Mediators are pulled to share wondrous personal expressions of creativity with the world, but the logistics of how to successfully do so may be hard for them to master. Analyst partners can help them fit all the little logical pieces together to reach those goals. Likewise, Analysts are likely to struggle with friction in the social world, as they often lack tact and sensitivity. When they bring their social problems to Mediator partners, they receive invaluable human insights that enable them to improve their relationships.

Unbalanced Mediator-Analyst Relationships

Silent Damage

Romantic gestures typically send messages of interest, but the differences in how these two types express themselves can lead to hurt feelings or missed connections. Unaccustomed as they usually are to an emotional approach, Analysts may not understand the importance of sweet little romantic steps, or perform them with forced sincerity as they try and match expectations. Mediators – who read much depth into even minor actions – are easily disappointed by such half-hearted efforts, so even gestures that represent sincere interest may seem shallow to them. Initial connections can be tough when these two types don't take a balanced, understanding approach to each other's different ways of expressing romance.

Analysts invest a lot of effort in deciding their priorities, but intimate emotional relations are rarely high on their list unless they're made aware of a need. Even the

most caring Analysts are unlikely to proffer the kind of lush, emotional interaction their Mediator lovers crave. Instead, they prioritize what they see as functional contributions to their romantic relationships. Their practical efforts may not satisfy Mediators' need for intimate connection, however, and real problems can occur when Mediators remain silent about what they really want. Analysts can certainly learn to meet their partners' needs, but rarely do so without prompting and steady guidance. Without it, this deficit can grow intolerable until Mediators explode with emotion – simply confusing Analysts further.

Out of Sync Priorities

These two types might learn to balance their expressions of emotion, but when Mediators and Analysts don't respect each other's priorities, ongoing and increasing friction can result. There's no specific subject where these two always differ: different criteria for decision-making and different preferences on where they want to put their energy mean these two can find a lot to disagree about. It's likely neither type is wrong, but this may still become a problem when they don't fairly balance their right to their own pursuits with their responsibility to mutual needs and concern for each other's goals.

Mediators often model their priorities in life around exploring the intangible, including emotional connections, and they love to share this exploration with their partners. They may not understand why Analysts don't share their values, however, and can easily become hurt and resentful. Analysts focus on systems, tactics, and rational processes; when they take this perspective too far, they may dismiss Mediators' lofty ideas, and consequently miss opportunities to expand their imaginations.

In romantic relationships, some level of mutual effort toward the common good is needed. When these types disagree on how to proceed, however, it's hard to get anything done. Over time, they may lose their sense of balance, leading them to resent each other for the time, energy, and money they spend on "unimportant" things. If they don't find ways to address life's everyday responsibilities together, everything from debt to dirty laundry can start to pile up in their lives.

Rebalancing Mediator-Analyst Relationships

Improving Communication

Working to understand their emotional differences can smooth over potential conflicts for Mediator-Analyst couples, especially early in their relationships. There's little in the way of an adequate substitute for understanding, which takes time and effort. However, when these partners are respectful and encouraging, this process brings them closer together. Mediators can help their Analyst lovers to reveal more of their feelings by setting a positive example of openness, asking them to share, and being encouraging when they do. Though Analysts may express some cynical thoughts, discussing feelings together is a huge step toward balance for these couples. Mediators can also avoid asking for too much, too fast – Analysts have a right to privacy in their own heads, just like anyone else.

An important step for both types is listening: simply taking in what their partners are saying without immediate comment. Since Analysts are unlikely to naturally respond with empathy, this deliberate reflection allows them to develop appropriate responses that support their partners' needs and feelings. In turn, Mediators can use such contemplation to moderate the emotion in their responses. When these couples practice being emotionally perceptive, they achieve a more complete form

of intelligence that enhances their relationships. These partners can use the following to help them navigate this area of personal growth together:

- Scheduling more in-depth “sharing time” at the end of each week.
 - Planning sharing around an unrelated but pleasant activity can make an uncomfortable talk easier. Consider a fancier-than-normal dinner, shared bath, or a walk outside – something each person enjoys.
- Use this time to talk about the highlights of each other’s week, including emotional difficulties and personal triumphs.
- Asking about each other’s thoughts and feelings daily, sharing honestly, but doing so *simply* – avoiding overloading each other with words, and asking for emotional support whenever needed.
- Validate each other’s feelings with the occasional show of approval.
- Focusing on creating an aura of relaxation and interest.
- Hold back complaints about each other at another time. Keep this time as a free space where partners are comfortable and respected.

In balanced relationships, verbal affirmations of understanding and appreciation are needed from both types of partners. Mediators can take the lead by demonstrating and encouraging non-judgmental, emotional openness with their Analyst lovers. Even if one partner chooses not to share everything all the time, they’ll love knowing that the other is always ready to listen with love.

Accepting Each Other’s Priorities

Mediators and Analysts don’t need to fully understand or agree with each other’s priorities in life, but in balanced relationships, they do respect and actively support those distinct pursuits. However, for their lives together to be functional and

enjoyable, they must also agree on certain realities that affect them daily, such as household chores, shared bills, and social or work obligations. It's important that these couples handle these sorts of priorities before they pour their hearts into more personal pursuits. Otherwise, they may find their freedom threatened by unfinished, mounting responsibilities. Cooperation can make quick work of such things: they just need to sit down, plan, and then act – together.

When Mediator–Analyst couples see their mutual priorities accomplished, they find it a lot easier to support each other's personal pursuits. It's also a wonderful demonstration of love to participate in things that are important to their significant others, if they want the company. Directly experiencing each other's personal passions goes a long way toward rebalancing differences, and each may find it unexpectedly interesting.

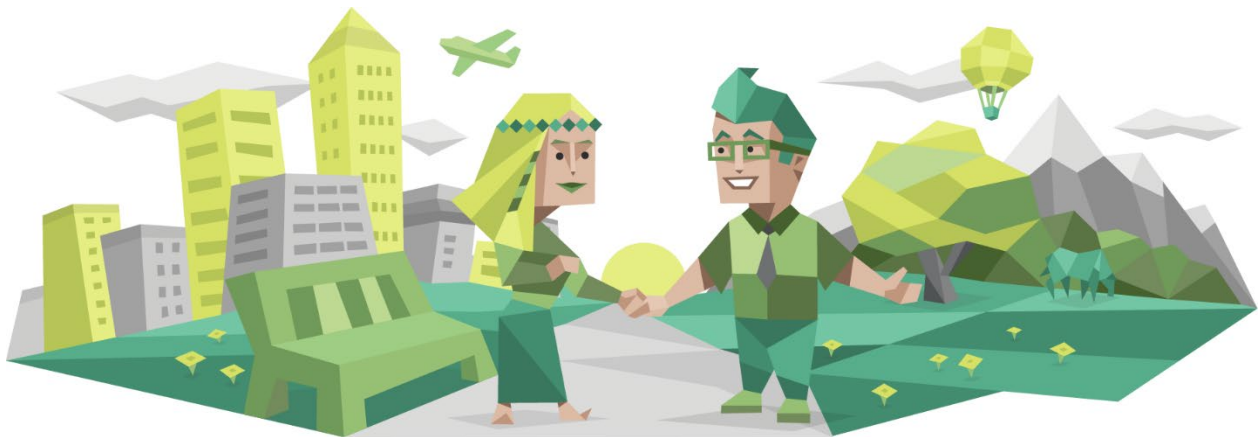
If Analysts are obsessed with some technology, they're likely thrilled at the chance to explain it to Mediators, who in turn may appreciate seeing its inner workings more clearly, tapping into their natural curiosity. Likewise, Mediators may have personal hobbies to share that Analysts may find interesting, from art, literature, and music to their favorite games. Neither type should feel obligated or pressured to spend their personal time on the other's interests, but they can benefit greatly by at least trying them out by:

- Discussing daily and weekly priorities with each other.
- Identifying and agree on matters that are of mutual benefit, and sharing the work.
- Making things interesting by trying out different, new ideas to see what works best.

- Ensuring each partner is free to jump in if they have an inspiration on how to get it done best, and that the other partner can join in.
- Completing routine matters before moving on to individual pursuits.
- Inviting each other into personal pursuits and positively demonstrating their appeal in front of each other.
- Devoting some time and energy to supporting each other's personal projects and goals, especially if they focus on development and accomplishment.

The core appreciation that Mediators and Analysts feel for each other as individuals can be a source of motivation to balance their perspectives. Analysts may not care about painting, and Mediators might find engines boring, but if that's their partners' taste, they can cheerfully support them.

Mediator-Diplomat Relationships



Mediators find a good sense of connection with fellow Diplomats, often growing close with them quickly – which isn't always easy for these sensitive types. While they have some notable differences within their Role group, Mediators and other Diplomats together as romantic couples have core commonalities that form the basis of both wonderful strengths and a few weaknesses. If they have a fault, it can be

caring too much, and the attendant emotional drama that may sometimes bring. But, because they connect so well at the heart, Mediators and Diplomats in love have an unsurpassed capacity to sustain each other for a lifetime.

Balanced Mediator-Diplomat Relationships

Emotional Resonance

Thanks to their similar emotional filters for viewing life, harmony develops organically between these types, with partners expressing their thoughts and feelings in open and empathetic ways. While this dynamic doesn't always contribute to objective thought, these lovers do become deeply attuned to each other's desires and needs, and are usually quite enthusiastic about making each other happy. When such people feel each other's emotions so strongly, it's only natural that they want to share as much joy together as possible.

In relationships with Diplomats, Mediators may feel that someone finally understands them – their strong emotional connection acts as a foundation to enable other forms of communication. These partners can share ideas, opinions, and problems together, counting on this underlying bond to help them navigate their differences and difficulties. Sensitive, emotional people may indeed be prone to some fiery fights, but when real love is present, they can make it up to each other and be stronger for it. Despite perfectly normal rocky spots now and then, Mediator-Diplomat couples who invest in long-term relationships find they become essential parts of each other's happiness.

A Pair of Dreamers

The resonant bonds these couples form can support more than just their happiness when they're together – it also strengthens them as individuals following their own paths. People of similar (or even identical) personality types might have different interests, passions, and life goals, but something Mediators and Diplomats do share is highly active imaginations. These two find their collaborative ideas marvelous, and while they might not share equal interest in everything, they become fans and supporters of each other's dreams.

This is a personality type that often struggles to act, even when they're inspired, so having a supportive partner is an excellent way for Mediators to realize their own goals. Sometimes the push they need to move themselves forward comes from a Diplomat partner contributing their happy energy. These types might even end up sharing some goals as a couple, and when they complement their dreaming with a dose of effort, they become partners in achievement as well as love. Whether it's saving up to go on a trip, founding a charity, or redesigning an apartment, these couples can achieve anything when they cooperate.

Unbalanced Mediator-Diplomat Relationships

Emotional Burnout

As wonderful as strong, bonded emotions can be, maintaining such a deep connection and constantly catering to each other's feelings can exhaust even the most emotionally attuned types. Mediator-Diplomat couples who become too interdependent may not only lose their individual emotional stability, they may stifle each other. Passionate desire for each other's attention, reassurance, and company becomes unbalanced when it approaches addictive need – risky on its own, and

potentially overwhelming for overburdened partners with their own needs. When these wonderfully interconnected partners take their emotional exchanges too far, they can become codependent in all the wrong ways.

One of the biggest problems with this codependence is that it assumes too much: everyone has limits. When Mediators or Diplomats take their adoration too far and idealistically view their partners as their primary sources for emotional validation, even minor flaws or missteps on the part of their lovers may seem shockingly disappointing. Idolization of each other may be hard to avoid, especially when new love is forming with truly remarkable individuals, but if it isn't balanced with a little realism, it can set up an overreaction. Mediators and Diplomats tend to be vulnerable to having their high hopes dashed by reality, but when the source of their disappointment are the people they love, the damage can be unpleasant. Blame is often the result when codependent relationships begin to show their inevitable weaknesses.

Lofty Distractions

Mediator–Diplomat couples have a troubling tendency to distract each other from everyday realities. They often get lost in their shared world of ideas and possibilities, drifting from one grand concept to another while ignoring immediate concerns. While this can produce wonderful creativity and insight, it might not result in a stable life. Without taking the time to enjoy the present and focus on simple realities, practical sensibility can be lacking in these relationships. Setting unrealistic goals isn't always conducive to success, but these two types might never notice because they're so enthusiastically chasing potentials together. These couples can suffer very unpleasant consequences when distraction leads to neglecting practical matters.

Mediator-Diplomat romantic relationships risk more than just daily upkeep, however. They can develop grandiose plans that continually drain their resources, never quite work out how they wanted, and eclipse much-needed pragmatic planning. While mere striving may be satisfying, at some point, these couples can feel a lack of realism in very basic ways. Lives spent painting or fighting injustice may have tremendous spiritual payoffs, but even the most idealistic couples need a roof over their heads and enough money to take care of themselves in retirement – and time to slow down and just enjoy life.

Rebalancing Mediator-Diplomat Relationships

Individual Emotional Strength

Before seeking emotional fulfillment in each other, these partners can work to develop their independence. One excellent way to do this is for Mediator-Diplomats couples to do fun things apart from each other, as well as together. Whether indulging in solitude or time spent with friends and family, these partners become better sources of strength for each other when they're strong on their own. Stepping back now and then doesn't in any way diminish their powerful connection, but it can ensure that they stay in touch with themselves. Space is essential for authentic, personal thoughts and feelings to be affirmed without anyone else's energy in the mix, and to rebalance their relationships, loving partners can respect the need for this space.

This approach can also help rebalance one of the most unpleasant aspects of emotional interdependence between Mediators and Diplomats: the tendency to reflect each other's negative emotional states. When feelings like joy or physical arousal resonate between these two types, it can be a divine fire, indeed. But when

one is stressed, tired, or irritable, the other may just as strongly amplify those feelings. Sensitivity has its downside, and bad moods can be contagious. Avoiding this pitfall requires conscious corrective action, and it isn't always easy.

When confronted by something negative, it's important to manage internal reactions: These lovers must refuse each other's negativity before it works its way into the heart of the relationship. If one partner is upset by something external to their relationship, the other can help by expressing sympathy *without* sharing their outrage – and they can go further with a positive gesture, like a brief shoulder rub while their partner is venting. In a relationship, these types can help each other by:

- Taking time alone to focus on personal thoughts and emotions.
- Balancing time spent together and socializing with others.
- Gently declining to participate in each other's negative emotions.
- Projecting supportive, positive feelings in the face of each other's upset.

There's no magic bullet to prevent or resolve strong negative emotions, but putting their underlying care for each other into practice can see these couples through conflicts. Emotional individuality during good times can bolster these partners when the going gets rough.

Balancing Dreams with Responsibility

To achieve balance between grand hopes and necessary realities, Mediator-Diplomat couples must learn to engage in the present while still honoring their expansive, creative tendencies. One way to do this is by regularly participating in hands-on activities together. Working on home improvement projects, shopping together, and being social with others are great ways for these couples to enjoy the moment yet still enjoy each other's inspired company. Having grand dreams is good,

but putting energy into practical activities together ensures that they don't end up living with their heads constantly in the clouds. This balance helps prepare them for dealing realistically with more serious matters as well.

When less-pleasant responsibilities come knocking, Mediators and Diplomats can roll up their sleeves, put on some music, and try to make the work as fun as possible. Whether it's fixing a leak, cleaning a room, or saving enough money for bills, both these types benefit from companionship and help – working together with a cheerful attitude creates momentum. No instruction can instill the needed will to accomplish responsibilities, but these steps can bolster these couples' commitment to get things done:

- Make time every week to complete minor, in-the-moment pursuits together.
- Pick a chore day and make it a permanent part of the weekly schedule.
- Ask each other what daily chores are being overlooked, and cooperate to get them done.
- Keep a list of needed chores and errands, share execution of list items.
- Avoid putting things off: Do chores and errands as soon as possible, together or independently.

For types so likely to get lost in their own imaginations, it's very important to take action. From simple camping trips, designing and building gardens, or sweeping the floors, these couples can push themselves to move past the hoping and dreaming phase and get to work on their goals.

Mediator-Sentinel Relationships



These relationships often bring about a kind of warm support that makes both types feel secure and very well cared for. Mediators' deep value of harmony with those close to them combines with Sentinels' sense of stability to create a love that fulfills each partners' needs very well. They may have radically different approaches to life and internal motivations, but both place tremendous emphasis on having genuine, trusting love in their lives, and this appreciation opens them up to learning from each other's differences.

Balanced Mediator-Sentinel Relationships

A Foundation of Mutual Benefit

Sentinels and Mediators share outlooks that can enable great relationships. Both types sincerely want what's best for people – Sentinels create stability and continuity, and Mediators foster kindness and emotional support. These couples place great emphasis on their values, and while they may have different approaches to promoting their ideals, their underlying desire for harmony is a lifelong practice. Balanced Sentinel-Mediator romantic partnerships combine their somewhat distinct

values, and are based on mutual support, something that love easily brings out in both types.

One of the best things about Mediator-Sentinel relationships is how they compensate for each other's behaviors. Sentinels can be a grounding influence on sometimes-flighty Mediators by providing them with a stable perspective. Mediators can provide their Sentinel lovers with deep understanding and empathy, as well as a needed dose of inspiration. Their rich fantasy lives and gentle adventurousness can help Sentinels break out of their reserved shells and realize their own potential. When willing to appreciate each other's strengths, these two types can learn much about who they are, and who they can become.

Building a Rich Life Together

Mediators aren't known for their pursuit of stability, but as they grow and experience life, they realize the difference between freedom and chaos. Just as painters need easels and musicians need their instruments, Mediators need the tools, knowledge, and resources to achieve their idealistic, creative visions. Sentinel partners are perfectly suited to helping them establish the underlying structure needed to pursue their ideas and goals. Sentinels are known for being practical, industrious, and sensible, and Mediators often need this kind of influence to move their lives forward.

Sentinels thrive on predictability, but even the most sensible goals can feel hollow without warmth and companionship. Mediators offer their partners heartfelt devotion unsurpassed by any other type. Sentinels' efforts to keep their lives in order are enhanced with deeper meaning when Mediators' love enters their lives like rays of sunshine – they can depend on having love at their side. Though they don't each bring the same things to a shared life, these two types build a more complete

existence by embracing each other's differences and giving generously of their own virtues.

Unbalanced Mediator-Sentinel Relationships

Frustration with Follow-Through

Between these two types, partnerships don't always go as planned. Sentinels may at first be impressed by Mediators' idealism, as their focus on social values likely appeals to Sentinels' sense of what is right and fair. However, once that first impression fades, Sentinels may begin to question – at times justifiably – how practical Mediators' ideas are, and whether they'll ever act on those ideas. Mediators who don't balance their imaginations with action may find their Sentinel lovers dismissing their flexible, optimistic vision as impractical. When Sentinels let their frustration get out of hand, they'll very likely hurt Mediators with their criticism, especially because there is often some truth behind it.

This frustration cuts both ways, though. Stabilizing is always on Sentinels' minds, and Mediators may initially appreciate the order their partners create – it likely represents something they lack in their lives. However, with their attention to tradition, Sentinels can seem rigid to Mediators, as though suffering from a lack of vision or an inability to change. If Sentinels cling to predictability, Mediators can become bored with the nuts and bolts of living in the present. Even worse, Sentinels who place too much emphasis on consistency can make Mediators partners feel trapped or suppressed, as though they can't fully exercise their curiosity and creativity – and to Mediators, these qualities are essential to a joyous life.

Different Timetables for Living

Mediators and Sentinels have potentially incompatible ways of scheduling their lives. Typical Sentinels come up with a composed and detailed schedule that they stick to dutifully, with everything in its place and on time. In contrast, Mediators prefer making things up as they go along, and are comfortable abandoning something once their interest wanes. They take a very relaxed and flexible approach to engagement in the first place – things can happen whenever. Clearly, these two types can easily get on each other's nerves, especially since these different approaches affect so many common aspects of life, like meeting for dates.

Misunderstandings and irritation abound when these two types feel their needs or perspectives are being overlooked. Mediators may feel controlled when their Sentinel partners pressure them to solidify or stick to their timetables, while Sentinels can feel that Mediators are unreliable when they refuse. There's obviously great value in balancing planning with adaptation, but when these types refuse to move toward such a combination, disagreements about which approach is correct may turn toxic.

Rebalancing Mediator-Sentinel Relationships

Accomplishing Things Together

If both partners are open and willing to compromise, they can create balance. When they feel appreciated, and appreciate their partner in turn, both will thrive. Mediators can accomplish things that matter to both them and their partners by acting with the same creative spirit that drives their imaginations. Sentinels, too, can keep an eye on practical matters that Mediators might normally let slide, while also being more flexible and open to trying fresh ideas and pursuits together. This doesn't mean that

Mediators expect Sentinels to keep things in order by themselves, or that Sentinels can abandon themselves to the whims of Mediators – rather, they both balance unconventional ideas with sensible action.

Sentinels respect those who follow through on their intentions, and are impressed when Mediators show a willingness to roll up their sleeves and get to work. This respect extends beyond practical or routine matters into personal interests as well. Just as Sentinels appreciate Mediators' participation in everyday responsibilities, Sentinels can also recognize the value Mediators derive from working on their creative dreams – and the truly dedicated Sentinels offer their help. Laundry and finances are important, but for Mediators, life is pointless without being able to dream their dreams, and Sentinels who want to create balanced, full relationships support their partners' personal priorities. Some basic steps that can help these two share priorities include:

- Be patient with each other's limits and needs.
- Give time and energy to each other's goals, whether mundane or zany.
- Decide priorities together, including completion times.
- Set aside time every week for a session of work together.
- Work together, and try to make it fun – without losing sight of goals.

A strong, loving commitment to each other can serve as an underlying reason for these partners to be supportive – creative imagination and stable convention need not be at odds if each type is willing to share their time and energy on what matters to the other.

The Best of Both

In real terms of everyday shared lives, rebalancing these couples' scheduling differences means compromising so that both types have what they want some of the time. Sentinel partners can learn to be more spontaneous, even if it means occasionally relaxing a schedule (or even going without). They can also recognize the importance of respecting Mediators' freedom and their right to change their minds. Experiencing love and joy together gives Sentinels motivation to be patient and accepting, and given how sensitive and concerned Mediators are, they're unlikely to push their partners too far out of their comfort zones.

In fact, Mediators can use their "go with the flow" attitude to their partners' benefit, letting Sentinels organize and direct plans and activities that are important to them, especially those that are time-sensitive. Although overactive imaginations can conjure plenty of arguments otherwise, tidy schedules rarely cause conflict, and most Mediators benefit from increased structure in their lives. They can simply relax and let Sentinels handle their schedule, ensuring that they're ready to participate when needed, and knowing that just as they revel in – and deserve – their wild and free moments, Sentinels also deserve the satisfaction of things being on time. Here are some steps that can enable workable compromises:

- The Mediator comes up with fun ideas, and Sentinel partner plans these experiences so that both can find enjoyment.
- When timeliness is needed, like when arriving at the airport for a flight, agree on plans together, and include a little extra time just in case.
- Ensure that each type's part of the plan is completed on time. Gently remind each other of approaching deadlines.

- Engage in unscheduled time together to explore in a moment-to-moment context. Fairs, farmer's markets, and other free-form events of mutual interest fit the bill.

Each type in this coupling has certain strengths, and both types can take a step into each other's timeframes now and then. When it comes to recreation, Sentinels may find it an unexpected relief to let go of rigid control, and Mediators can appreciate the benefits of staying on schedule when it comes to important matters.

Mediator-Explorer Relationships



These pairings offer partners many adventures as their differences combine in interesting and exciting ways. Mediators have heads full of creative dreams, and Explorers tend to like hands-on activities – they may either baffle or inspire each other at times. Mediators' imaginations might not leap at the more material challenges that appeal to Explorers, who, in turn, may become bored by imaginative talk of the intangible, but love itself expands the horizons of both types as they introduce each other to new things.

Balanced Mediator-Explorer Relationships

Exploring Reality Together

Mediators tend to get lost in dreams on their own, but with Explorers by their sides, they quickly find themselves drawn out of their heads and into experiences. Unusual concepts appeal to both these types, and when deep imagination becomes the launchpad for engagement, both can uncover new dimensions. When it comes to creativity and ingenuity, these couples serve as uniquely different sources of inspiration for each other, with Mediators providing a principled, highly imaginative perspective, and Explorers excited to put ideas into a real-world context to see how they work.

Together, these types are interested in exploring everything, always looking for what's new and exciting, and appreciating each other's styles of engagement. Explorer partners share Mediators' wonderful sense of curiosity, and they also carry that curiosity forward into action, trying to understand new things not just in theory, but in practice. It's very likely that these pairings result in lots of fun and adventure together, not only making initial dating easier, but keeping things fresh as they progress deeper into loving relationships.

Freedom Together

Another quality that both Mediators and Explorers share is a love of freedom. To be happy, Mediators need to feel as though they can dream and create without restraint, and likewise, Explorers want to walk their own path by engaging pursuits that are important to them. While they may have different focuses and approaches, these lovers share an essential desire to follow their hearts and minds wherever they may lead. When love grows between them, they support each other's liberty and

passion. Because they know the importance of their own freedom, it makes sense to both these types that their partners also want the freedom to explore; it's normal to them. Whereas some types might feel compelled to impose structure or restrictions, these two types likely just say, "Go for it, babe!"

If loving something means setting it free, then Mediator–Explorer couples can truly find empowerment in loving each other as they embrace their dreams and goals. When a solid emotional connection ties them together, Mediators can happily grant their Explorer partners the time and space they need to master whatever they set their sights on, and, in turn, Explorers are unlikely to deny Mediators their grandest hopes and ideas – though they might encourage them to do more than just dream. These couples don't hold each other to rigid standards or convention by any means, as both are willing to adapt to new things all the time, and even seek them out. When balanced in their support of each other's interests, they can find endless happy adventures together.

Unbalanced Mediator–Explorer Relationships

Why Don't You Understand Me?

Despite their shared curiosity and adaptability, Mediators and Explorers have some significant differences when it comes to imagination versus practicality. Mediators who take their imagination too far can essentially end up living in a world of self-affirmed realities, where what's correct is based mainly on their own internal vision. An unending obsession with concepts that never reach the real world can make even the most flexible and permissive Explorers shake their heads in vexed wonderment. These types may lose patience with Mediators who can't bring themselves to face

realities they don't like, and, in turn, Mediators may see Explorers as sadly limited by their inability to accept intangible truths.

Explorers specialize in real-world experimentation – they actively practice fitting things together, with their ingenuity based heavily on adapting to feedback from their environment. When something doesn't turn out the way they hoped, they try a different approach. Mediators, on the other hand, think about how purely conceptual or intangible things *might* fit together, and can become blinkered by possibility. When something doesn't go as they hoped, these types often adapt to preserve the vision in their heads: by fixing theoretical discrepancies in their minds, Mediators avoid having to test their more outlandish ideas in the real world.

Shifting Sands

These lovers usually share enthusiasm for all that's new and unknown, but their willingness to dive headlong into change may result in shared risk. While they might not lack for love and joy, even those things can be threatened if their lives become too chaotic or fail to meet their basic needs. Prosperity, long-term success, and the achievement of dreams often requires steady commitment and effort in ways that don't immediately pay off. These couples' love of newness and change may distract them from less thrilling, but no less important and rewarding, investments in themselves and their future, as they're often gleefully willing to shirk responsibilities.

Whether it's failing to decide on an area of study, switching jobs too often, or simply frittering away their time and resources on pleasure together, Mediators and Explorers are by their very natures in danger of building their futures together on shifting sands rather than worthy foundations. Most people don't possess great wealth, and so this can be a pernicious problem. If these types let their novelty-

seeking get out of hand, they may not stick to the same goals for very long, and while this may be fine in discretionary personal pursuits, it can retard them in matters of long-term development which are important to creating happy, successful lives.

Rebalancing Mediator-Explorer Relationships

Flexible with Each Other

Reconciling differences between airy, conceptual idealism and hands-on practicality is a much-needed step for these couples to achieve balance. Luckily, their mutual willingness to try new things offers them a clear path to accepting, if not always understanding, each other's styles. With a little tolerance, these two types see the value in their different methods: Mediators see how well Explorers figure things out through direct engagement, and Explorers see how insightful Mediators can be using only their minds. The combination of unbound imagination and practical experimentation is probably a superior approach to either method alone, and with open minds, these couples can find a balance that allows them to operate together with amazing results.

One of the biggest steps is for these couples to acknowledge individual priorities in an affirmative way. Mediators can work to respect Explorers' focus on tangible accomplishments – they have every right to work on what matters to them. For their part in rebalancing, Explorers might consider turning their masterful abilities to helping their Mediator partners evolve some of their high-minded ideas into reality – at least, the ones that can be translated into reality. Of course, Explorers can't be expected to merely occupy an intangible realm, so when Mediators ask their partners to join in, they must also be ready for action. Here are some steps to creating balance in this area:

- Give each other the respect and space to do personal things in unique ways.
- Explain their approach and why it's important to them, including how it makes them feel.
- Show personal and individual methods to each other and explain how they work.
- Try out the other's approach, preferably within an activity that's of interest to both, and done together, as experience creates understanding.

These types can tap into their love of novelty and explore each other's methods. The simplest way is just to join each other in personal pursuits with open hearts and minds – neither type needs to convert, but they can both experiment with different perspectives and methods.

Building a Foundation

Communication and cooperation are very important to rebalancing these couples' potential to meander through life. If they want to achieve meaningful long-term goals, they'll have to willingly take care of responsibilities together. Learning to regularly communicate about topics that are difficult or uninteresting is a sign of both personal maturity and mature relationships. Even if these partners are happily tolerant of disorder, or prefer keeping their options open, talking through a budget, social schedule, housekeeping, and meal planning are essential steps to keeping their homes and relationships running smoothly.

Mediator-Explorer couples tend to dislike boring responsibilities, and this poses great challenges. While they may find happiness living outside convention, they do need responsibility enough to recognize what they'll need to remain content and secure in the long term. This may mean different things to different couples, but typically entails more work, saving, or daily chores – and in any case, it requires a

serious attitude from both partners. In realistic terms, this means they dedicate time every week to attend their responsibilities together. These types may find it easier to maintain discipline when they view it as an expansion of their desires; these goals are for their own benefit. Steps they can take to help with goal-setting and engagement include:

- Discuss and decide on a few long-term goals that are important to both.
 - What are they? Why are they important? What resources will they require?
- Defining for each other what success would look like, and how completion will be measured.
- When considering whether these goals are achievable, ask trustworthy people with related experience for their opinions and advice.
- Set a realistic timeframe for these goals, considering probable limits and other obligations.
- Commit to a schedule for working on these goals together.
- As you work, prioritize a positive attitude and encouragement.
- Sticking to the plan as much as possible. Adjust only if necessary – an ideal plan accounts for variations and contingencies.

With a shared focus, these couples can translate their desires into real world results that keep them happy – not just in the moment, but for years to come. By working together, they can create enjoy the benefits of stability as they lead spontaneous, light-hearted lives.

Conclusion

Staying True to Their Hearts

Mediators have a sensitive core that often makes it challenging for them to be bold, especially when it comes to critical social endeavors like romance. No other type is more sweet, thoughtful, and responsive to other people's influence, and it's this very receptiveness that grants them many advantages in love. Deeply empathetic and open-hearted, when Mediators love someone, they not only welcome them into their lives, they're willing to accept and revere them as they are. They can forge rewarding relationships with any type, and when they meet others who truly appreciate and respect them in return, balanced love knows no limits.

If there's any cautionary theme for Mediators in love, it's not to lose themselves completely in their adoration of their partners. These types so readily give of themselves that they may forego their happiness as individuals. Loving partners can give them what they need, either supporting them actively or just giving them time for themselves, but Mediators must remember to communicate these needs. Conforming to partners can create great closeness, but love only grows so much in an echo chamber – those who truly love Mediators want to see them honestly, and revel in their uniqueness.

When Mediators share themselves without shame, they may be surprised at how attractive they are to other people. Their ability to care for others on an emotional level, combined with their insightful imaginations and love of novelty and spontaneity, make Mediators appealing partners to all types of people. As Introverts, putting themselves forward socially comes with great effort, but they nonetheless benefit from doing so. Accepting themselves as wonderful and cherished can be a

powerful step toward meeting their goals of personal growth, as well as finding true love.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your romantic relationships? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

[Get to Know Your Partner](#)

Would you like to get to know your partner a little better? Try this simple, but very fun and effective, game.

[Couple Analysis](#)

A great tool for couples. Learn how your personalities are likely to interact, and how you can connect on an even deeper level.

[Type Guesser \(Romance\)](#)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your partner belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

[Romantic Fulfillment Test](#)

Grasp the roles that confidence and optimism play in your relationships, as well as what makes someone a good match for you.

[Intertype Test](#)

Do you have a partner? Do you want to understand your relationship better? Learn more about it with our easy Intertype Test.

Loyalty Test

With this test, you will find out how you build relationships and loyalty in four major areas: Romance, Work, Friendships, and Family.

Friendships



Private and Mysterious

Mediators are one of the most private personality types, a quality which comes through in all their relationships, including friendships. Despite this, they quickly “get” both their current and potential friends, as they possess incredible insight when it comes to other people. Even though they’re adept at reading others, these types usually keep to themselves when it comes to their own thoughts and feelings. Mediators would rather direct a conversation toward universal ideas than reveal anything about their inner lives, at least until they can be sure that the potential confidant is receptive. They maintain this mysterious aura even with their dearest friends, and they require a profound sense of trust to let others in. This can make things interesting, albeit lopsided; in friendships with Mediators, the central task for both people is to create that trust. Nonetheless, if they want the friendship to work, they need to take that risk: There is no real friendship between two strangers, however appealing the notion.

The first step to having friends is meeting people, which Mediators find difficult. When they're younger, their sensitivity may cause them to choose solitude rather than face the stressors and emotionally charged situations that often come with even simple social engagements. This tendency may linger in older Mediators as well. Being alone may not bother them most of the time, but when they do yearn for supportive and stimulating relationships, they need to set aside their self-protection and reach out. For these types, isolation is more reflexive than intentional.

Sincerity and Authenticity

For their friendship, all Mediators ask in return is sincerity. Genuine behavior is vital to them, and they won't let people they see as inauthentic into their lives unnecessarily. These types possess a powerful filter that helps them determine who is genuine and who is not, so insincere candidates for friendship are usually revealed and left alone long before they get too close.

Mediators' preference for deep conversation over small talk helps them sort the potentials from the pretenders, and they're unlikely to form real friendships with mere acquaintances. The fact that individuals share the same spot in time and space isn't enough to warrant their commitment to a closer connection. Nor will they seek friendships based on everyday activities where chit-chat is the chief form of communication. Passionate in their idealism, Mediators search for those willing to imaginatively climb to the greatest heights with them.

Supportive, Loyal, and Deep

Once Mediators establish a degree of trust and begin to develop genuine friendships, they're fiercely loyal, supporting their hard-won friends with singular devotion. Because of all the "trust work" leading up to their bonding, these types are usually

unwilling to let something so meaningful slip away. Mediators show extraordinary levels of caring and compassion to keep their friends safe and happy.

Supporting and caring for others are integral to Mediators' identity – and they have hope that even those with the most abhorrent behaviors can be redeemed by love. Their personal view of support sometimes informs their opinion of how others should be with them. Mediators keep their circle of friends small, relying far more on depth than breadth. However, if they need lots of support, they have only a few kindred souls to lean on. This alone isn't problematic, but they may become needy or even overbearing in their friendships. Their chosen few friends receive the full weight of Mediators' needs, and it takes a special sort to balance it.

All friendships need some measure of trust, loyalty, support, and authenticity, but Mediators need these to be the defining elements. Add idealism to the mix, and the depths of their relationships become quite profound. Because Mediators go to so much trouble to build friendships, they treasure them greatly and are likely to keep such friends for life. Even though they're not always the most consistent people, friendship is one area where they're steadfast.

"I'm Going on an Adventure"

Invitations to Mediators' life journeys may come with some significant barriers. Finding friends willing to suspend their approaches to life long enough to share in Mediators' unique way of thinking and feeling is challenging. If they don't have substantial common ground to cement their relationships, it can be near impossible.

At the same time, Intuitive types can find it exhausting to convert their imaginings into something tangible, and Introverts can exaggerate their concerns about relationships, seeing other people as something to "deal with." For Prospecting types,

there can even be a sense of apprehension about entering what might be perceived as a commitment from which they may need to extract themselves. For Mediators, a social life might seem like a burden.

To work through this, these types can reframe social interactions to appeal to their adventurousness, open-mindedness, and creativity – the parts of themselves that dream up grand stories and long to explore. Rather than “dealing with” people, they can try to see friendships as quests of discovery. In classic tales of adventure and fantasy, the occasional dragons do crop up – but that’s what makes a quest so darn exciting!

There may be confusion and chaos along the way, little embarrassments and miscommunications, but these setbacks emerge within a healthy friendship as part of a shared adventure. So much depends on the mindset with which Mediators build their social worlds. Will they be haunted by obligation and embarrassment – or inspired by quests filled with adventure?

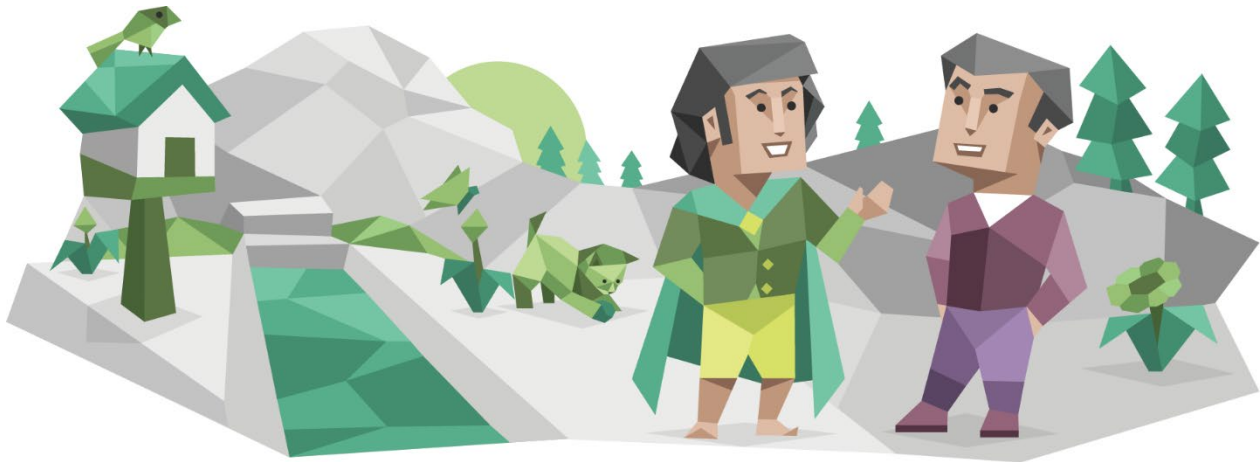
Mediators and Friends from Other Roles

Friendship isn’t simply about Mediators and some other generic person. Each Role – Analysts, Diplomats, Sentinels, and Explorers – brings something unique to their friendships. How their distinct traits interact with Mediators’ tendencies creates unique synergies and challenges.

The next four sections explore how Mediators and people from each Role relate to each other as friends. First, we look at what a balanced friendship looks like, when companions understand each other, lift each other up, cover each other’s weaknesses, and enable each other’s strengths. Then, we discuss an unbalanced

friendship, one in which friends exaggerate each other's weaknesses or disregard each other's needs. Finally, we explore rebalancing friendships. Just because things hit a rough patch doesn't mean they can't find a way back to positivity and mutual growth, and this book works to help friends do just that.

Mediator-Analyst Friendships



If a cartoonish archetype were created to represent an association between Analysts and Mediators, it might involve a scientist (the Analyst) and a poet (the Mediator). The scientist would explain things with unrelenting rationality and far more detail than was perhaps needed. The poet would rhapsodize in free verse, converting a clinical analysis into something almost beautiful. Although the caricatures represent a contrasting undercurrent that certainly exists, the two types aren't so distant – Mediators and Analysts can become great friends.

Balanced Mediator–Analyst Friendships

Unlimited Potential

Their interests usually differ, but Mediators and Analysts both share the Intuitive trait, which bestows a fondness for abstract ideas and “what if” scenarios, with Mediators offering the softer side of reality. They certainly come from different perspectives, but their creative approaches and open minds come together beautifully. Mediators put heart and soul into their ideas, incorporating a sense of humanity and morality – even spirituality. Analysts put a rational spin on these ideas, always in pursuit of efficient, elegant solutions. Also, Mediators have grand visions for the future, but they struggle to work toward those goals in any tangible way. At times, they have trouble finding a realistic direction or deciding which of many paths is viable. Analysts can help Mediators bridge the gap between their dreams and reality. Their differences have the potential for conflict, but mature, accepting friends can complement each other wonderfully.

Mediators’ plans change or evolve frequently, but for their dreams to come to fruition, they need enough stability to see ideas to completion. Analysts can be hit-and-miss on stability, but they add a dose of criticism that, although sometimes hard to hear (and not just because Mediators are sensitive – Analysts are notoriously blunt), can help shape a dream into something achievable. Analysts focus on rational plans that deconstruct concepts and systems to find their flaws and make them work better. This clarity can anchor Mediators’ goals and dreams to make them feasible.

Finding Their Center

In a sense, Mediators and their Analyst friends act as interpreters and guides for each other. Mediators translate the world of humanistic concerns for their Analyst friends,

while Analysts open the door to rational options for their Mediator friends. Mediators bring a soft-hearted approach to the world, choosing to believe in hope and kindness. In a friendship, this may rebalance Analysts' sometimes cynical outlook on the world.

Mediators serve Analyst friends as trusted guides on their journeys as well. Analysts are geared to consider logic before emotion. Some Analysts might even fear emotions, including their own, as a loss of self-control, a common misunderstanding about emotional expression. When Mediators help Analysts navigate this sea of feelings and understand themselves, it can add tremendous depth to both of their lives and to their friendships.

Unbalanced Mediator-Analyst Friendships

If either person leans on their core traits in an unbalanced way, there can be ample pitfalls in Mediator-Analyst friendships. This is primarily due to how they reach decisions. Rational, efficient Analysts and dreamy, empathic Mediators can certainly complement each other and hold each other accountable, but they can engage in some serious clashes as well.

Criticism as Support

Mediators and Analysts may have occasional tension in their friendships, especially if they aren't comfortable enough with themselves to be able to accept others as they are, which is a matter of personal growth. Tension can arise from the distinct filters they tend to use to make decisions: emotional humanism versus detached rationalism. It's all too easy for these friends to forget at times just how differently they think. If forthright individuals feel strongly about an issue, they can easily upset each other.

Mediators are sensitive to criticism and tension, and Analysts are often gleefully provocative. When Analysts forget their Mediator friends' feelings, their behavior can become an unbalanced type of debate that can seem more like an attack. When Mediators forget that ideological arguments are akin to an intellectual game to Analysts, they can overreact with raw emotion, fleeing from the situation instead of playing along. Although their emotions may not be as near the surface, Analysts nonetheless feel such accusations very deeply when they come from a friend.

Profundity and Play

Mediators tend to take their ideas seriously, and they wish desperately that they could follow through with most of them. Applying their earnestness to their Analyst friends' sometimes bizarre plans could be disturbing. Meanwhile, Analysts may mistakenly interpret Mediators' ideals as being just as fanciful as their own. Mediators seriously wonder whether they should sell everything they own to pursue their dreams – change their lives so they might change the lives of others. Analysts treat Mediators' thoughts as they do their own; consequently, they may trivialize what is most important to Mediators, hurting them in the process.

Analysts often brainstorm and come up with outrageous plans and ideas simply as an exercise in rationality. These types have no intention of their schemes leading to anything, even as they take a raw idea and refine it to the detail of a manual. For example, Analysts may talk at length about how to execute the perfect bank robbery, with surprisingly detailed knowledge of security and money-laundering practices seemingly conjured from nowhere – but local banks are probably safe. However, Mediators equate thought with action on a certain level, judging themselves harshly for any slips into the sort of amoral thoughts Analysts can contemplate with relative

dispassion. Seeing that their friends have no qualms with this can undermine Mediators' trust.

They can find each other intriguing at first, but if they don't work to understand each other, Analysts will keep trying to get their Mediator friends to take a break from fanciful dreams, and Mediators will begin to feel sadness for their Analyst friends, who seem to see nothing as sacred.

Rebalancing Mediator-Analyst Friendships

Mediators and Analysts always have one thing in common: They share the Intuitive trait. This characteristic allows them to see the world with a broader perspective. With their mental flexibility, Intuitive types are the best-equipped to find the understanding needed to rebalance a friendship, as well as appreciate each other's strengths and weaknesses.

Friendships should make each companion intellectually and spiritually larger, not smaller. Each personality type should temper their thinking and appreciate the unique perspectives their friends bring to the table. Friendships between Mediators and Analysts provide opportunities to do just that – but first, they need to acknowledge and set aside any intolerance of their differences, just long enough to get to the people underneath.

A Teachable Moment

Mediators know well the strength that comes from emotional honesty and understanding. One of Analysts' greatest weaknesses is their underdeveloped emotional intelligence – or, more accurately, their dismissal of emotional intelligence as valuable or even valid. Mediators have the patience and the skill with words (not

to mention the emotional understanding needed to relate to others) to open this perspective up to their Analyst friends. There is an entire half of the world that Analysts just factor out of their calculations – those who rely on sensitivity and emotional context to make decisions.

There can be no better guides into this new world than Mediator friends. They prompt their Analyst friends to consider how others might feel, then help them adjust their plans and ideas. Of course, for proper balance, Mediators need to open themselves to similar teachable moments based on Analysts' more rational perspective. The following tips can help:

- Understand that Analysts initially use logic in situations.
 - They're exceptionally precise people, which is why any emotional response they have will usually be a delayed one. Just as Mediators would have an issue stepping away from their feelings, Analysts would have issue stepping away from rationality.
- When pondering on a seemingly emotionless response from an Analyst, try to:
 - Not immediately take it personally.
 - Take a step back from the response and consider whether it was intended to hurt.
 - If is unsure, ask the Analyst as plainly as possible.

Appreciating Limits

Mediators hold their emotions very dear, and Analysts are notoriously insensitive to emotional cues. Mediators who'd like to balance out their Analyst friendships can start by letting their friends know that certain topics aren't game for criticism. This is hardly the ideal way to start friendships, but for friends trying to repair damage,

letting each other know that something is problematic is a sign of honest communication, something valuable in any relationship.

It's also an opportunity for Mediators' personal growth. These types sacrifice themselves for others' benefit, so standing up for their feelings can be a tremendous boost to self-confidence – Analysts respect such clear statements, and they're usually happy to oblige. Setting aside known flashpoints for conflict is straightforward and efficient as well. Having some informal rules when there are subjects that prove too contentious may help keep the peace, as well as keep these friendships from falling apart.

Here are some ways Mediators can work on appreciating their own and their friends' limits:

- Consider a recent situation where you felt hurt or angered by a friend.
- Identify the specific issue and why it hurt.
 - For example, an Analyst friend telling you to “suck it up” during a time of great emotional distress. Such a statement can hurt, making you feel as though you can't talk to them when you need someone to turn to.
- Once you have the issue clearly defined, sit your Analyst friend down and:
 - Use “I feel” statements. (“I feel really hurt that my emotions were ignored yesterday,” rather than an accusatory, “You're incredibly insensitive.”)
 - Avoid any emotional flourishes or poetic language. Analysts do well with precise language, and they can understand an emotional dilemma better if it's delivered this way.
 - Be as straight to the point as possible, but also clear. This is important because Analysts may have a harder time relating to Mediators' poetic

descriptions of their feelings. If they're hurt, Mediators should simply say, "I was hurt."

Mediator-Diplomat Friendships



Mediators find a natural home with their fellow Diplomats. They come together easily, as their interactions are based on a common interest in humanistic topics, a strong concern for society and those adversely affected by it, and good intentions to make the world a better place. Considering all of this, it isn't unsurprising that Mediators and other Diplomats make for amazing friends.

Balanced Mediator-Diplomat Friendships

For Mediators, close friendships with fellow Diplomats can feel like befriending themselves. The common interests and shared temperament among Diplomats make for powerful influences. Diplomats live more internally than most types and exercise their imaginations extravagantly. This enables Mediators to sit quietly and comfortably with their friends without saying much at all. When they do talk, however, these types are unlikely to run out of things to say.

Because they're rare in a constellation of personality types, Diplomat friends work to maintain such precious friendships, regardless of any difficulties they might encounter along the way. When they see all they have in common, they strive to create lifelong bonds.

A Mental and Emotional Extension

Mediators who form genuine friendships with other Diplomats have the wonderful experience of gaining a kind of mental extension of themselves, as they magnify their potential for joy and learning. Although Mediators are often overly private in their relationships, Diplomats can help Mediators express themselves in an emotionally safe environment. Should Mediators overcome their caution and share with Diplomat friends, they'll enjoy relatable insights and gain the benefit and wisdom of each other's tests and triumphs. "I had the most amazing idea the other day ..." is a common refrain in these friendships. In a sense, their honest and profound relationships offer each partner a chance to live two lives at once.

Likewise, Mediators and Diplomats are ideally suited to provide care for each other in times of trouble. An in-depth personal knowledge of each other's way of thinking, combined with their nurturing nature, make them ideal confidants and emotional resources for each other. Each knows what the other needs, or has the patience and understanding to find out. Sometimes they offer comfort, encouragement, and sympathy. At other times, they provide a firm metaphorical kick to snap friends out of a funk. The mutual understanding these types share may reach an almost mystical synchronicity.

A Creative Bond

When it comes to pursuing creativity and ideas together, Mediators find that other Diplomats make willing and helpful partners. In fact, mutual interests often bring these types together in the first place. They might build their friendships around reading a favorite genre of fiction, pursuing social causes, or even forming a band. Diplomats don't just "hang out." For these types, exploring life via deep conversations is relaxing. Mediators look for personal ways to express and understand such insights, often in very creative ways, and other Diplomats make ideal partners in such endeavors.

When Mediators and their Diplomat friends have mutual creative interests, they inspire each other to go deeper, spurring significant accomplishments and understanding. This supportive energy comes from core similarities tied to broad human and moral themes. However, they don't always think about things the same way. Differences between friends who feel they know each other so well can be unsettling but aren't to be feared. They even hold special benefits. By weaving together their harmonious but independent paths, these companions can glimpse a different point of view that stirs up deep feelings because they're so similar and yet unique.

Advocate and Protagonist friends, who bear the Judging trait, bring a special gift to their friendships with Mediators. They help to ground Mediators in their creative endeavors, encouraging depth and follow-through. Mediators' approach to life is a lot more inspiration-oriented than that of Judging Diplomats. Although Mediators' flexibility and lack of conformity can certainly lead to something beautiful when their creative juices are flowing, it's just as likely they'll only hint at that beauty before

moving on. Judging Diplomats may be able to help their Mediator friends focus on their goals, and perhaps even meet them.

Unbalanced Mediator–Diplomat Friendships

Isolated and Insulated

Adding varied thoughts to the mix can make ideas stronger. However, Mediator–Diplomat friendships sometimes build a psychological “bubble” that keeps them insulated from the critical input of outsiders. This is magnified if the friends are also Introverts. A bubble is a cozy place for private Mediators, and it’s tempting to take advantage of relationships that promote such isolation.

The key challenge for Mediator and Diplomat friends comes from the same source that fuels their friendships – their similarity. Having friends who think the same way is reassuring and comfortable. However, when they’re isolated from diverse opinions and rely only on each other, these types can find themselves lacking useful feedback and perspective. This creates the risk that they’ll support each other’s ways of thinking despite critical flaws that more objective types would quickly notice.

Subconscious Manipulation

Similarity might also lead Mediator and Diplomat friends to manipulate each other subconsciously. Mediators don’t consciously seek power over others, especially through manipulation, and they aren’t likely to try to pull the wool over another’s eyes. Their empathy and their quest for genuineness stifle such impulses. Nonetheless, they do know what makes other Diplomats tick. If their friends have an agenda that doesn’t quite match theirs, Mediators may find themselves bending the rules and subtly discouraging their friends from certain paths by showing a little extra

disappointment. They know what kind of doubts resonate, and manipulation can become accidentally effortless.

Mediators' deep trust allows them to be manipulated by people they care about, too. These types are "harmonizers," often willing to quickly set aside their own needs in favor of their friends' needs. This can lead to a sort of manipulation if friends use Mediators' need for harmony to their own benefits. Despite the empathic gifts typical to Diplomats, trust can run so deep between these friends that they neglect deeper concerns about fair and humane treatment. People sometimes aren't even aware of these unhealthy influences existing in their friendships.

It's important to keep in mind, however, that manipulation and compromise are two different things. The thing to ask is, "Does one of us *always* get our way?" Compromise goes two ways, while manipulation tends to work for only one.

Rebalancing Mediator–Diplomat Friendships

Rediscovering the Tangible

Balancing their inner, imaginative lives with some real-world experiences is a huge benefit to Mediators and their Diplomat friends. Instead of only encouraging each other to live internally, these types can make it a point to get out and experience the world. Such an effort at balancing their lives – with local fairs, the arts, or live music – can only make their friendships richer. There's nothing wrong with watching and discussing a film, but perhaps a few frames of bowling or a spontaneous hike would expand their lives through novelty and variety. For a pair that otherwise lives through the imagination, a little interaction with the material world usually feels great.

Part of getting out into the world is meeting other people and including them in discussion and activities. This might be a challenge for Mediators alone, but with help and encouragement from Diplomat friends, they may be able to achieve it (finding events of mutual interest that allow for groups might be a good plan). Here are a few suggestions:

- Make time to do things to learn real-life skills together (e.g., woodworking, cooking classes).
- Focus on things both enjoy that require attendance or active participation.
- Try and pick things that exercise basic skills in a hands-on way, such as painting or tennis.
- Spend time with other types of friends to avoid isolation.

Thinking Critically

Mediators and Diplomat friends can rebalance subtle manipulations by focusing on sharing their own feelings, thoughts, and ideas. These friends carry a certain gravity with each other because of the trust inherent in the relationship, but there is a difference between subtle pressure and honest, gentle sharing. That may be a difference that Mediators want to fine-tune, especially in friendships with Diplomats, where emotions abound, and harmony is prized over all else. Mediator–Diplomat friends likely don’t want to reject each other’s criticisms or concerns when they come from a good place, but realizing that manipulation can also take this form will raise awareness when it’s happening.

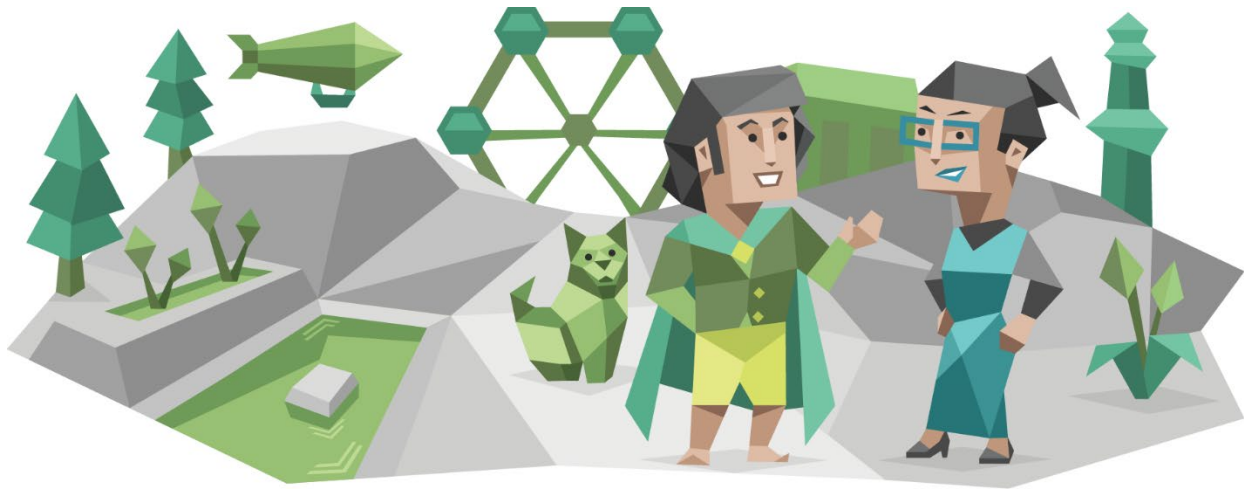
Words like “manipulation” may sound harsh or unlikely, but it’s important to understand that we’re talking about subconscious thinking, not deliberate machinations. In fact, conscious manipulation is a betrayal of trust that these

sensitive friends find repugnant, and in that, we can see the key to rebalancing. Because these friends care so genuinely for each other's well-being, merely mentioning the appearance of any unfair pressure will hit home and likely halt it. When one of these friends takes the time to gently express their concerns, the other will quickly look at their own behavior anew, then do whatever it takes to restore balance. Here's a few pieces of advice that can help restore balance:

- Express criticism as constructive concern, openly and without emotional pressure.
- Don't be afraid to respectfully consider but reject each other's advice.
- Make appreciation clear to each other while staying firmly on a personal path.
- Try not to get too caught up in each other's emotions. A little distance can enable better objectivity and, ultimately, better care for each other.

It's important for these friends to be supportive, not controlling. It's enough to honestly make their opinions known and offer their help to each other; they don't need to feel responsible for each other's decisions, nor take each other's independence as rejection. Instead of trying to push each other subtly, they can give their support to the directions each chooses for themselves.

Mediator-Sentinel Friendships



Mediators and Sentinels may seem like opposites – the hopeful dreamers and the keepers of society don’t seem like they would be a natural fit. However, their opposing traits can be balanced out if both are willing to work together to create a strong and everlasting friendship.

Balanced Mediator-Sentinel Friendships

A Study in Contrasts

Sentinels, as the most common personality types by far, likely make up some if not most of Mediators’ circles of friends. This is despite some marked trait differences between these types. The closest Sentinel match to Mediators are Defenders, who share the Introversion and Feeling traits. Executives, however, differ on every core attribute. Nonetheless, they have a common interest in caring about others. For Mediators, this comes from a kind of dreamy, romantic sense of altruism. For Sentinels, it originates from a more practical place, rooted in everyday concerns, common sense, and loyalty.

In the right spirit, Mediator–Sentinel friends can use their differences to share the best of two worlds. While Mediators explore the vast reaches of their imaginations to discover how the planet might be a better place, their Sentinel friends work on it in detail with steady, measurable progress. When Mediators reveal far-flung utopian ideas to their Sentinel friends, Sentinels temper the concepts with practical considerations. When Sentinels embrace the more pedestrian aspects of life, Mediators can pull them toward more interesting ways of considering their existence and possibilities for society. A dialectical push and pull between such friends evens out extremes, and stretching in these ways promotes growth for both.

Feet on the Ground, Heads in the Clouds

Mediators balance their Sentinel friends' perspectives by taking them on tours of profound thoughts and unusual perspectives. Their influence can help Sentinel friends to mitigate boredom, breaking them out a bit when life becomes confining. Mediators can help Sentinels relax their tendency to be adamantly purposeful, providing them with relief from their abundant responsibilities. Mediators help their Sentinel friends balance their approach to spontaneity, flexibility, and fancy. “We don’t need a plan,” might be the Mediator’s rallying cry to their regimented Sentinel friends.

Mediators see life creatively and hopefully by way of their imagination, whereas Sentinels focus on far more concrete matters. When Mediators wrap themselves up in thoughts and theories, they can expect Sentinel friends to draw them out of their reverie and into the material world. After chatting about the nature of humanity or watching thought-provoking movies, Sentinels may get their Mediator friends to the park or out for a day of shopping, at least occasionally. Sentinel friends can help Mediators appreciate and enjoy life in more tangible, fun ways.

Such friendships involve companions sharing their distinct views of life. Mediators peer through a looking glass that whisks them away from the here and now, and Sentinels use a magnifying glass to appreciate the controllable details that are within reach. Both can be interesting perspectives. Such friends might suggest to each other, “Here, try looking at things through mine for a minute.”

Unbalanced Mediator-Sentinel Friendships

Stubborn Misunderstanding

Trouble can begin in Mediator-Sentinel friendships when either insists that their way is the better way. Mediators may have more patience with Sentinels who possess the Feeling trait (Defenders and Consuls), but they may hit a brick wall with Thinking Sentinels (Executives and Logisticians). When Sentinels hold on to their established patterns and Mediators hold onto their ideals, it can be an unstoppable force meeting an immovable object.

Instead of relying on the steadying influences of their Sentinel friends, Mediators may be tempted to think of themselves as deeper and more substantial. These types can be very intensely involved with their own thoughts and feelings, which is why they sometimes make the mistake of believing that others cannot possibly feel or see life as they do. Mediators disregard the everyday details that Sentinels often painstakingly attend to: Mediators will discard tradition, community, and the status quo if they’re not in line with their personal ideals. Sentinels can feel frustrated by this disregard, and when they insist on their own values, Mediators may condescend, and in the eyes of Sentinel friends that comes across as out-of-touch elitism.

The Concept Versus the Details

These friends can balance each other's lives, but if they criticize each other's methods, such behavior can lead to conflict and tension. Both types tend to have an idea of what they want to achieve, but they may go about it in very different ways. Mediators organize their worlds around opportunity and inspiration, whereas Sentinels organize their worlds around details and stability. This can become an issue when they try to work together toward a common goal, such as a social endeavor or shared outing.

Mediators' focus on the intangible becomes unbalanced when it leads to indifference or irresponsibility, such as the details of executing mutual activities. They may act based on unrealistic expectation more than sensible assessment, causing plans to falter or go awry in ways that frustrate Sentinels, who think they can see how problems could have been avoided. Sentinels, on the other hand, might insist too rigidly on details, hanging their own – and others' – happiness on procedural matters instead of a broader outcome of fun and enjoyment. Although neither intends to be intolerant of the other's style, it can turn out that way when these friends make plans together.

Rebalancing Mediator-Sentinel Friendships

Appreciating Fundamental Differences

For these types, having fun together requires an understanding that they may have divergent definitions of fun. One of the first steps to closing the gap between Mediators' conceptual focus and Sentinels' pragmatic view is simply to acknowledge that difference. Although there may never be a full meeting of the minds, there can be a meeting of the hearts and a sense of acceptance and mutual respect. With

patience, each can work to understand that the other is coming from a good place, which creates common ground for enjoying each other's company.

It's a fool's errand to ask Mediators to be less passionate, or Sentinels to relax their need to maintain practical control. However, the best way forward is to experience each other's worlds, at least a little – they needn't lose who they are or cease counterbalancing each other. Sentinels can still ask their Mediator friends to take a deep breath when they're too distracted with new ideas or passions, and Mediators can still ask their Sentinel friends to lighten up a bit when they're obsessed with serious responsibilities. The mere intent to accept and explore each other's ways a little at a time will be enough to rebalance this caring friendship. To achieve this, both friends can do the following:

- Respect each other's differences.
- Ask questions about how each other's differences are applied in daily life.
 - When they have differences in opinion, Mediators can gently inquire why Sentinels do things the way they do.
- Try and glimpse things from each other's point of view.
- Make time to do things together that appeal mainly to one friend, then alternate fairly.

Whether it's a movie or politics, these two will likely always have to make room for each other's different styles. However, belief that their approaches are just fine for themselves also means they must give each other the respect to do things their way – treating each other as they wish to be treated.

Understanding Is Caring

Mediators should recognize that it's no small thing to disrupt Sentinels' best-laid plans. Sentinels take their responsibilities seriously, and they can harbor hurt feelings over disruptions of their code, even those that seem minor. Mediators can rebalance such missteps not only by letting their compassion open the door to compromise, but also by taking time to appreciate what Sentinels contribute to shared plans. It's great to have a grand concept of a fun shared activity, but ensuring that things are planned – and executed well enough to meet those lofty expectations – can lead to even more fun. Recognizing the value of Sentinels' realistic logistics not only demonstrates respect, but it also helps Mediators learn a skill that will help them accomplish their enthusiastic hopes.

For their part, Sentinels should try not to control every little detail; making something happen in a successful and fun way doesn't require absolute predictability. Sentinels are unlikely to allow themselves to be carried away by abstract concepts or stretched profundity, but they can open themselves up to being flexible and enjoying the moment. They can rebalance their rigidity by realizing that sometimes tight control of an endeavor severely limits its potential. Indeed, Mediators' seemingly "unrealistic" hopes may be the first step toward unexpected, amazing experiences together. Here are some tips that can help these friends rebalance their differing ideas of how to have fun:

- Join in things that matter to each other.
- Appreciate being with friends, even if the activity isn't very engaging.
- Try to respect the specificity of friends' needs, even if it makes no sense to you.
- Ask each other what to do to support each other's goals of fun.

Ultimately, friends are friends. Even though Mediators and Sentinels are sometimes caught off-guard by the distinct ways they approach activities, they can have even more fun together when they focus on each other's unique contributions.

Mediator-Explorer Friendships



When Mediators and Explorers come together, there is no limit to the joy that can be had. Both have the Prospecting trait, leading them to venture the world as their will commands – just in different ways. Though some work is required, with ample understanding these two types can become the best of friends.

Balanced Mediator-Explorer Friendships

Two Kinds of Explorers

Mediators have much in common with Explorers. In a sense, Mediators are explorers (small “e”) themselves. Like Explorers, they often go in non-conformist directions and approach life as something flexible and laden with possibility. Mediators and Explorers enjoy novelty, adding new elements to their personal worlds. Although

Mediators usually focus on ideas and philosophies, Explorers hone in on skills and experiences. They may show it in different ways, but they're both free spirits.

Mediators act as a stabilizing moral compass. Woven into their philosophical exploration, there is always a sense of empathy, compassion, concern for well-being and fairness, and a broad philosophy of humanism. This helps Explorer friends weigh the impact of their choices on others and themselves. Explorers help their Mediator friends realize that wondering and pondering are well and good, but sometimes, they just need to *do*. This can be especially potent in travel – bringing philosophical wanderlust together with, well, wanderlust, can open a literal world of adventure for these friends.

Discovering Beauty

These types help each other make many incredible discoveries they'd never find alone. Explorers can coax their Mediator friends from their worlds of dreams and ideas and help them discover the sensual side of life. Mediators certainly enjoy the artisanal qualities of beauty and craftsmanship that Explorers all possess on some level, and they might even enjoy helping to build a fence or plant a garden, however much Explorers may claim that these are merely chores. Mediators may appreciate the novelty of working with their hands for once, to build something practical. Also, time with their friends is always nice regardless of activity.

Mediators possess their own artisanal craft: the art of feeling and expression. Poetry shared with friends can be an outlet for the intimacy Mediators seek in friendship. With Explorers in mind, Mediators can shift their verse toward something more colorful, something exciting and hopeful for what life and the future can bring. They can even use their friends' moment-to-moment outlook as inspiration for a more

immediate acknowledgment of beauty, perhaps in the form of a haiku, capturing the timelessness of the moment as the “Gold-green light filters / Through the trees on a shared hike / With a dear old friend.”

Unbalanced Mediator-Explorer Friendships

Contrasting Approaches

Unfortunately, the potential for these types to bond is equaled by the potential to clash. One example is their lifestyle: Mediators are inspired by intangible values born from their imaginations and beliefs, whereas Explorers find inspiration by connecting to the world around them, engaging in practices rather than rumination. When either of these types takes their own perspective too far, Mediators can become alarmed or Explorers can become annoyed with such unbalanced behavior – or worse, they can unfairly criticize each other’s differences.

When this happens, Mediators can be quick to judge how Explorers should feel about things, especially in conceptual and social areas. They may think their Explorer friends are being selfish by focusing on accomplishing their own more tangible interests instead of sharing broader societal concerns. Explorers’ concerns and activities often fail to contribute to societal growth, and sometimes even undermine it. An environmentally conscious and generally considerate Mediator may fail to appreciate the technical gains to performance their Explorer friend achieves by removing the catalytic converter and muffler from their car – creating added pollution and exceptional car noise in the process. In turn, Explorers who lose their balanced perspective may get annoyed at Mediator friends for expressing high-minded opinions, yet failing to follow through with any realistic ideas or practical

action. Explorers have a great focus on personal accomplishment, and little respect for what they may see as endless talk.

This isn't nearly so simple as a case of altruism versus selfishness, though. Explorers often maintain a "live and let live" attitude which at its core is highly respectful of others. Mediators pour their energy into their ideas and creativity, but that drive can easily become sanctimonious or guilt-based manipulation. The issue here isn't that one of these friends has an inferior approach, but that they can fail to respect how well their differing approaches work. When in sync, these two balance each other wonderfully, but if they allow their perspectives to become self-obsessed or narrow, their differences make for a slippery slope into judgment and resentment.

Mutual Disdain for the Mundane

Fun is just what Mediators need to pull them out of the clouds, but even with the best of intentions, these two types might step into an irresponsible dynamic. When things go too far out of balance, they enable each other to disregard consequences.

Explorer friends are likely to encourage Mediators to set aside some of life's obligations, pushing them to blow off a homework assignment or loosen a budget for a night out. For their part, Mediators easily get caught up in shared moments of joy with friends, happily ignoring rational concerns in favor of feeling good. These types may do little to moderate each other's compulsions.

This may not always play out in friendships the same way it would with roommates, families, or spouses. Nonetheless, friends can be a highly unbalanced influence on each other when they become each other's refuge from reality. While Mediators can maintain priorities, those priorities can easily become unrealistic, and too much fun indulgence with spontaneous Explorers only makes matters worse. Being supportive

of each other can do unintentional harm when these friends don't discriminate what they support; inspiring shared experiences can enrich the soul, while leaving bank accounts dangerously impoverished.

Rebalancing Mediator-Explorer Friendships

Respecting Interests

Good friends often find interest in subjects they don't care about simply because a friend cares so much. When it comes to their different approaches to life, Mediators and Explorers may need to be willing not only to overlook differences but also go along for the ride occasionally. Friendship is participatory. If either type is rigid and refuses to pay any attention to the things that excite the other, their relationship won't have much of a foundation.

Of course, in addition to adapting to each other's needs, Mediators and Explorers can have great friendships while maintaining separate interests, too. In fact, they probably should. Friends of Explorers must appreciate their need to do their own thing. Mediators also have their preferences, and they may need to pursue certain things without the company of Explorers. On some level, such friendships may require sufficient distance and flexibility to allow the individuals room to be themselves. True friends don't need to share everything; they can give each other space and then rejoin to focus on making plans that are rewarding to both. These steps can help keep both friends satisfied:

- Try to understand each other by discussing differences.
- Allow each other's differences without judgment.
 - Mediators could pause after their initial emotional reactions to Explorers' actions and step away from the situation.

- They can give themselves time to meditate on the situation, perhaps a night to sleep on the issue, until they're ready to consider the situation again.
- When friction occurs, take time apart to engage individual interests.
- Come back together often for things that mutually enjoyable activities.

For Mediator–Explorer friendships to ultimately work, these individuals should have enough in common, rather than simply tolerating each other's unique pursuits. Friendship should be a life-enhancing state filled with good times together. Sometimes this may require friends to take an unselfish step outside of their comfort zone or area of interest, even as they hold on to the values and interests that make them who they are.

Looking Out for the Little Things

Mediator–Explorer friends may both want to ignore their boring responsibilities, but because they care for each other, they should avoid becoming enablers and try to keep a caring, watchful eye on each other's well-being. Mutual support is a great benefit of friendship, even if friends share similar flaws.

This can be as simple as taking a moment to ask not only what would make their friends happy, but also what would serve them best in the long run. When facing shared decisions about anything from life choices to recreational plans, these friends can add a layer of respect for each other by considering each other's welfare. Mediators are especially good at this, and likewise deeply appreciate such efforts from Explorer friends. These friends can run headlong into indulgence together, if they want – they just need to avoid overshooting the target, or failing to cover their basic duties. These friends can help each other by taking these steps:

- Try not to distract each other from life responsibilities.
- Keep each other's well-being in mind when planning things together.
- Inquire about each other's availability based on consideration for other priorities: "After you're finished doing [blank], want to hang out?"

If these friends take time to observe what's going on in each other's lives, they'll see when it is or isn't a good time to engage in fun together. Prying each other away from stress is great, but it's important to recognize when to let each other focus on important things.

Accepting Non-Commitment

Explorers may be uncomfortable committing to things – not because they can't follow through, but because it transforms activities from joyful opportunities into obligations. This is quite the stretch for Mediators, who value commitment. Predictability never was the charm of these pairings, though, nor is it needed for Mediators to feel value in their relationships. Rather, that sense of unexpected inspiration makes Explorer friends important to Mediators who seek personal balance. Explorers pull them into the moment, where they can see the deeper dimensions of authenticity they seek in life.

The key is for Explorers to find a balance between surprising Mediator friends and jerking the carpet out from under them. Mediators need consideration for their feelings, and frankly, a little hand-holding goes a long way when leading Mediators into changes and the unknown. Explorers can make it clear that while their interests and direction may be subject to sudden change, their support will always be there. Instead of turning away to follow their own path, they can offer a friendly hand and

the option to join, as this helps Mediators feel valued and respected whether they choose to participate or not.

Mediators care about their friends, and to create balanced friendships with Explorers, they can work to accept their unique qualities and needs: The stricter the arrangement, the less likely Explorers are to be comfortable. Any efforts to control or direct them – something Mediators may want to do in reaction to Explorers' spontaneity – is likely to push them away. Mediators can moderate their desire for promises and commitment with appreciation for Explorers' spontaneity and how it can benefit them. Such friends will be ready to drop what they're doing and join them at a moment's notice. Here are some steps these friends can take to ensure their relationship is balanced:

- Be gently honest with each other when something isn't fun anymore.
- Be understanding when one of you wants a change.
- Try to manage expectations internally, and be flexible.
- When something's important, ask for – and give – the best effort to stick with it together.

Early and frequent communication can help Mediators and Explorers manage changing preferences between them. There's no better method than staying kind and considerate toward each other, yet honest about changing individual needs.

Conclusion

Mediators are known for their never-ending quest to put things together in wonderful ways, and when it comes to friendship, this dance takes on a new dimension by incorporating the unique qualities and needs of other personality

types. Mediators want to forge lasting relationships with people who share their values and perspectives. When these types open themselves to people that aren't immediately compatible, or who challenge a Mediator's typical way of think, they'll find ways to grow through their friendship.

Mediators' combination of traits makes them passionately progressive, but not always open-minded; they have deep values and a tendency to see the world in a hopeful light that can fail to account for a sometimes unfortunate or unfair reality. Friendships with people who don't completely share their perspective might not provide obvious reassurance, but ultimately, they may present even greater insights. Personal growth is about creating new understanding, and it can't always be comfortable: similar-minded people may not give Mediators the chance to achieve their greatest potential.

On the other hand, friendship shouldn't feel like a lesson to be learned, always challenging the mind to expand. Everyone craves the comfort of trustworthy friends with whom they can share their deepest secrets, people who will stick with them through thick and thin. Yet it's important that at least some friends are simply fun and relaxing.

Fortunately for Mediators, personality types who are very different from their own can provide such comforts. Regardless of people's differing methods and perspectives, Mediators can almost always find something to appreciate and admire about other types. These types want to see the best in people. When Mediators follow their desire for connection into unexpected friendships, the rewards often exceed expectations.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your friendships? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

Type Guesser (Friendships)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your friend belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

Personal Authenticity Test

Can you be your true self with your friends and family? Let's explore how you feel about your authenticity in those circumstances.

Parenthood



Few challenges in life are so exhausting, yet so rewarding, as parenting, and Mediators are undoubtedly up for the challenge. These types bring the same amount of enthusiasm to their roles as parents as they do to their most passionate ideals. Mediators strike an impressive balance of gentle authority and inspirational companionship with their kids.

Mediator parents have several qualities that make them ideal guides, especially in how they relate to and encourage their kids. Their ability to both articulate their values and demonstrate the importance of developing a personal belief system is inspiring to wide-eyed, idealistic youth. These types often relate to their children in a magical, child-like way. This chapter describes strengths that can be embraced, and areas that can be focused on, to help Mediator parents maintain or regain balance as they help their children grow.

Compassionate and Supportive

Where others are quick to dismiss the complaints of their tiny progeny, Mediator parents take pains to make sure their children feel heard. Whether talking their

toddlers through their first boo-boos in need of a Band-Aid, or helping teenagers overcome their first broken hearts, they've a steady supply of shoulders to cry on. Whatever their children's temperament and circumstance, these types meet them as they are with open hearts. Not that their sons and daughters are the only beneficiaries of Mediators' kindness – these parents care for all creatures great and small, a quality that's sure to make an impact on any impressionable minds in their homes. Weaving respect for all life and all minds into their children's growing psyches, Mediators extend their compassion and kindness into their children's fundamental worldview, creating empathic, understanding adults who carry these values forward.

In addition to being compassionate, these types are patiently supportive of their children. Rather than pushing their kids in the directions they choose for them or chastising them for having unrealistic goals, Mediator parents are the strong, steady wind at their children's backs, and are quick to shift if their kids decide they'd like to take a different route. Where some adults become frustrated at their children's stubbornness, Mediators understand that kids often act out in frustration at their inability to meet their needs, or even communicate these needs to those around them. The extra time their children might need to overcome obstacles is time that Mediator parents grant with gentle patience.

Moral and Modest

Like all Diplomat parents, Mediators focus intently on morality. Rather than emphasizing rigid rules of etiquette to abide by, however, Mediators prefer to sincerely convey, through stories and meaningful conversations, the moral behavior they wish to pass on. These parents encourage their kids to listen to their emotions when making decisions, and not to be afraid of being sensitive and kind wherever possible. Having their children grow up as empathetic yet principled individuals is a

key goal for parents with the Mediator personality type. At the same time, they respect the uniqueness of each individual and don't necessarily believe that any way of thinking is more "correct" than any other. As passionate as they are about their personal beliefs, they're equally respectful of other people's beliefs, so long as they benefit humanity.

Promoting morality is important, but in the minds of Mediators, there isn't one specific way that it must be done. Their modesty and open-mindedness prevent these parents from enforcing a strictly dogmatic method of moral behavior, leaving their children the option to find a system of embracing and promoting their morals and ideals that works best for them. This approach has the added benefit of encouraging kids to respect and appreciate the diverse methods that others use to develop their own morality, rather than viewing these differences as "right or wrong."

Unstructured

While they can be downright transcendent when engaging with their children in the emotional, moral, and spiritual realms, Mediators often find themselves struggling in the earthly dimension that includes life's day-to-day mundanities. Structure doesn't come easily to these parents, who have a hard time understanding the values of consistency, details, and routine, prizing instead openness and possibility. However, for young children who are only beginning to grasp the complexities of the world around them, rules and schedules provide a comforting predictability to life's otherwise unfamiliar chaos. They also ensure they're on time for the things they care about, and that small promises are kept.

Though freedom-loving Mediator parents may feel that open bedtimes and early sovereignty are ways of freeing their children from the artificial restrictions they rebel

against, they'd do well to remember that kids don't understand how to use such freedom responsibly. Some mistakes can only be made once, and children depend on the wisdom of others. It can be helpful for Mediators who struggle with structure to have parenting partners who balance them out in this regard, but this isn't always possible. Without an effort to mitigate this – with calendars, sticky notes, or whatever else they need to do to keep track of responsibilities – their kids can struggle to develop necessary responsible behaviors.

Overly Sensitive

Their sensitivity and focus on morality mean that things other personality types would probably shrug off may hurt emotionally vulnerable Mediators deeply. Few things cause more anguish to these types than seeing their sincere beliefs about what is right and noble challenged or rejected by their children. In such circumstances, less confident parents can turn inwards, blaming themselves and becoming consumed with guilt for being unable to instill the right values. These types tend to be forgiving to all but themselves.

Parents with this personality type should be especially careful with their feelings during their children's adolescent years. Teenagers often rebel against their parents' authority as a natural part of their growing independence and identity development. Unlike their younger years, rebellion at this stage is much more intimidating with the addition of raw emotions, higher intellect, and aggressive desire. Mediators shouldn't immediately assume that their teens are actively fighting their beliefs, or that all their teachings were ignored. Conflict is no indication that a relationship is in jeopardy, and for many types it's a sign of trust – for kids to express their feelings to their parents is no small act. Yet Mediators who allow themselves to feel deeply hurt may

try to focus all their efforts on mitigating damage and strengthening their relationships with their teenagers, provoking even stronger pushback.

Creating Structure and Rhythm

Perhaps one of the most beneficial things that these parents can do to build meaningful balance is to incorporate structure and rhythm in their kids' daily lives. Besides reducing stress and chaos, routines have the added benefit of providing stability for children, effectively decreasing the likelihood of mood swings and emotional outbursts.

While such creative types may balk at the idea of "structure" – equating that word with boredom and conformity – the truth is, when used correctly, structure can provide *more* freedom to create and connect with their children. The adage, "In limits, there is freedom," holds true for kids of all personality types who rely on their parents to set safe boundaries they can count on.

There are several specific ways that Mediator parents can create a rhythm and accountability system that benefits both themselves and their kids. Preparing for each day the night before – laying out outfits, tidying up the kitchen, making lunches, etc. – can make mornings less chaotic. Writing things down on a calendar, planner, or online scheduling app (that can be shared with their children as they get older) is another technique that's especially beneficial for sometimes scattered Mediators. Using timers and setting reminders can help to avoid last-minute rushes or forgotten appointments. Finally, these freedom-loving parents can also benefit from leaving room for spontaneity in each day and keeping their schedules simple and balanced. If they can prevent falling prey to society's pressure to overschedule their children in a multitude of activities, both Mediators and their kids can thrive.

Practicing Self-Compassion

Creating strong, empathic parent-child relationships is one of Mediators' top priorities. Even perceived rejection or indifference from their sons and daughters can be heartbreaking for these sensitive individuals. Rejection, both real and perceived, is inevitable when raising children, and Mediators need to prepare themselves to deal with these situations in a healthy way.

Empathy can be both a blessing and a curse when dealing with stressful situations. While they can use their empathy in an outward manner, sharing in the feelings of those around them, these types can struggle with understanding their own feelings. When stressed, they may deprive themselves of personal compassion, exacerbating their feelings of rejection and isolation.

There are options for those who want to parent from a place of passion rather than one of fear of failure or rejection. Engaging walks in nature provide Mediators a much-needed respite from the negative rumination they may be caught up in. Also, writing down their unfiltered thoughts and feelings can be incredibly cathartic for these types. (It's helpful to reflect on the transience of feelings when writing – what may be hurtful or frustrating now will inevitably change.) Burning or throwing away the words they've written can also symbolically “get rid” of negative thoughts or feelings. Centering activities such as meditation, prayer, and even deep breathing can be beneficial even in short five to 15-minute durations. When they're feeling particularly confused by their emotions, Mediators should seek out trusted friends or family members to share their feelings with. What may feel like a tangled mess of thoughts and emotions can be sorted through with the help of loving confidants.

Stages of Development

Each of the stages children's growth present both unique challenges and exciting milestones. Learning how to navigate these stages can seem daunting, but the opportunity to build healthy attachment and create meaningful memories makes it worth the struggle.

Renowned psychologist Erik Erikson proposed a theory of psychosocial development that identified eight stages, five of which take place between birth and 18 years of age. It's important to remember that these stages aren't set in stone and the ages listed for each stage are *approximate*. Kids develop at their own pace and meet each milestone in their own time.

The following paragraphs discuss what to expect at each stage of development, as well as how the strengths and weaknesses of the Mediator personality type affects their parenting at each stage. We then offer suggestions on how to help Mediators turn an unbalanced approach around. Whatever the stages of development, growth never stops.

Building Bonds (From Birth to Approximately 1 ½ Years)

According to Erikson, the stages of infancy and early childhood last from birth until approximately three years of age. Children in these stages are very dependent on their parents to meet their needs. This is also when the bonds of attachment are created by meeting their children's needs, developing trusting relationships, and promoting autonomy.

The priority for infants in their journey to attachment is having their basic needs met. From being fed to receiving affection, babies need to learn to trust that their Mediator parents can provide for them. If these types are inconsistent in providing for their infants, their children can have difficulty creating positive, trusting attachment.

Attentive and affectionate Mediators – especially those who engage in consistent physical contact such as snuggling or transporting their children in baby carriers on their bodies – can develop trusting, hopeful relationships with their infants and are likely to have little difficulty building comfortable attachment.

Balanced Infant Bonding

Building Loving Bonds

Mediators who tap into their empathy and sensitivity when their babies are born have no trouble giving their infants the attention and affection needed to build loving bonds. Infants need affection that goes beyond just daily care. They crave the physical connection that their parents provide through cuddling, rocking, speaking softly, and making eye contact. Mediators' loving smiles do more than just entertain their babies – they create a primal connection that inspires the trust needed to create positive relationships.

In addition to affection and compassion, dedication is necessary for building trusting relationships with infants. Mediator parents are extraordinarily passionate individuals, and there's very little that they're more passionate about than their children. From the moment that their children are born, these types throw all their energy into making sure that their babies' needs are met, both physically and

emotionally. Building trusting, loving bonds with their infants comes naturally to individuals with this personality type.

Open to Anything

While structure and schedules are certainly important during the infancy stage, flexibility and the ability to quickly adapt to changing needs is just as important. Midnight feedings, spontaneous crying fits, and unexpected diaper disasters are just a few of the ways that babies refuse to adhere to a schedule. Thankfully, Mediators are exceptionally flexible, and find it relatively easy to readjust their expectations when situations change unexpectedly.

Caring for infants is exhausting. However, Mediator parents certainly appreciate the many new experiences that this stage provides – albeit maybe not until after they’ve recovered from their sleep deprivation. Nothing bores them more than a strict, unchanging schedule day in and day out, and they certainly won’t have to worry about that with their new babies. While not all interruptions to their schedules are pleasant, they’re enough to keep these parents on their toes and prevent boredom.

Unbalanced Infant Bonding

Neglectful of Their Own Needs

One of the less beneficial results of their passionate parenting is the tendency for Mediators to become so absorbed in caring for their infants that they forget to take care of their own basic needs. Eating and sleeping can take a back seat to engaging with their newborns. Neglecting their needs to this extent can lead to health issues, both physically and mentally, if they begin to suffer from burnout and unhealthy eating, exercise, and social habits.

This imbalance is more likely to happen when these types aren't receiving support from their partners, families, or friends, who can both assist with child care and encourage them to take some much-needed time to care for themselves. These situations can become dire when a combined lack of support and self-care cause resentment and animosity in their relationships with others. Friends and family may feel completely neglected by Mediators in this state, while their partners may bear the brunt of their frustration and exhaustion. Feeling like mere ghosts of their true selves, parents with this personality type may run out of the emotional reserves necessary to nurture their connections with others.

From Dreams to Diapers

Many Mediators have a very idealized vision of what parenting infants should be like. Visions of sweet lullaby sessions in a cozy rocking chair and cooing over a smiling baby splashing in the tub are inevitably doused by the reality of all-night crying sessions and mountains of dirty diapers. This wake-up call can be especially shocking to dreamy parents who are unprepared for the massive responsibility placed before them.

Dreams of basking in the magical moments of infancy are eventually met with reality – parents are responsible for providing for their kids in an emotional way, and they must meet their children's practical needs as well. Achieving this level of security and stability can seem elusive to any new parents, and inexperienced Mediator parents may find the adjustment especially difficult.

Rebalancing Infant Bonding

Prioritize Self-Care

Learning to balance their needs with those of their children is one of the most important things Mediators can do. Taking a thirty-minute bath while their partners put the kids to bed can help these types relax. Taking relatives up on their offers to baby-sit can provide much-needed time to meet with friends for coffee. Even engaging in deep breathing exercises for five minutes can help to clear their minds and relax their bodies.

Additionally, all the relationships Mediator have prior to bringing their infants home undoubtedly go through a period of readjustment. It's vital for these types' overall well-being to make sure that they make their connections with others, especially spouses or partners, a priority so they don't alienate their support system. One simple way Mediators can engage with their partners or other close friends and family members who play a significant role in their lives is to begin a gratitude practice. This can be done in a few minutes at any time during the day with the following steps:

- Choosing a regular time each day – first thing in the morning, at supper, before bed – when they can communicate with each other face to face.
- Taking turns listing three things that they're grateful for about their spouses, then listing three things that they're grateful for about that day.
- Discussing one thing that's bothering them that day. Avoid statements like, "My partner is the one thing bothering me" – these can easily negate all the positive things just listed.

Being vulnerable and expressing gratitude are both practices that promote intimacy between partners, which is vitally important to Mediators who crave understanding and connection. The healthier their relationships are with their partners, and the stronger their network of support, the better parents Mediators can be for their children.

Finding Beauty in the Mundane

It's easy to see the beauty in those moments where babies are sleeping peacefully or smiling lovingly at their parents. However, beauty doesn't suffice in those moments when their infants won't stop crying or when the laundry is piled up so high it resembles a geological formation. Most people would advise these types to just "deal with it," because parenthood is hard and not always lovely and magical. These types of reality checks can further frustrate already disenchanted Mediators. A more effective (and enjoyable) approach to this problem is to purposely look for the beauty even in the most mundane moments.

Wabi-sabi is a Japanese concept that can be summarized as finding beauty in imperfection. Think of a handmade coffee mug, with its lack of symmetry and minor faults – part of the appeal of this item is that it's imperfect and has its own character and uniqueness. Rather than focusing on the stresses of keeping their home clean or dealing with a crabby baby, Mediators can use this concept to embrace these difficult moments and find the beauty within them.

The following steps can help develop a meditation or gratitude practice when dealing with the mundanity of parenthood:

- Choosing a mantra that promotes peace or gratitude, such as, "I am thankful for this day," or, "Today I choose happiness."

- Repeating this mantra when doing any tasks that seem tedious or frustrating, like rocking the baby back to sleep in the middle of the night... for the third time.
- Practicing countering negative thoughts, such as, “I’m going to lose my damn mind if I have to change another dirty diaper,” into positive statements, such as, “I am grateful for this opportunity to spend time with my child.”

Parenting is hard – often the hardest part of a person’s life is raising another. And it’s often discouraging, especially during those years where children are unable (and sometimes unwilling) to express gratitude or reciprocate affection. Rather than succumbing to disappointment when their dream of parenthood doesn’t match reality, Mediators can embrace this opportunity for what it is – a chance to experience an incredibly beautiful and fulfilling relationship.

Testing Boundaries (From Approximately 1 ½ to 3 Years)

Once they’re mobile, young children become very interested in exploring their environment with their senses. Crawling, walking, grabbing items, putting things in their mouth, and verbal communication are just a few of the ways that toddlers learn about the world around them.

During this stage, Mediator parents must provide safe harbor for their toddlers while still allowing them to experience and explore their surroundings. Kids who test boundaries, yet still receive parental support and encouragement, develop a sense of autonomy. Children who are overly restricted, criticized, or made to feel guilty for their desire to test boundaries ultimately experience a sense of shame and may suffer from feelings of incompetence or low self-worth. These feelings can last

throughout their lives, and may ultimately jeopardize their ability to achieve goals and develop positive character traits such as reliability or confidence.

Balanced Toddler Bonding

Trustworthy and Compassionate

Extremely supportive, Mediators make an ideal “home base” for their sons and daughters during this stage. Their engagement and determination to meet their toddlers’ needs ensure that their little ones never feel abandoned, ignored, or unloved. Even though children at this age are incredibly independent, they still crave (and need) trustworthy caregivers, and these types don’t disappoint.

Mediators’ patient compassion is especially useful during the trying toddler years. While they can certainly be challenging, confident Mediator parents enjoy promoting their children’s curiosity and independence while still maintaining a safe environment. They take pleasure in helping their toddlers learn how to pick out their own clothes and dress themselves, and promoting their children’s natural creativity and self-expression. Helping their children learn to become creative, self-reliant, and competent are among Mediator parents’ greatest joys.

Relatable and Respectful

If Mediators relate with greater ease than most to children – toddlers included – it’s because they see the world through the same fresh eyes, and appreciate how sincerely and authentically children interact with the world around them. These parents appreciate their children’s struggles in a way that few other adults understand, with an empathetic connection that facilitates honest, open communication. Due to their quiet, unassuming nature, many Mediators experience

situations where they feel marginalized and misunderstood (flashback to feeling invisible at a restaurant or throughout *all* high school), making it easier to relate to the frustration and helplessness their kids may feel. This understanding makes these parents more likely than most to treat their children's requests – as well as grievances – with the utmost respect.

Relating to their sons and daughters in such a meaningful way is certainly nice, but is of little help when it comes to dealing with disobedience. Experienced Mediator parents work toward finding a balance between understanding the reason for their children's behavior while still enforcing the values they want their kids to uphold. They may realize their toddlers' temper tantrums are due to missing nap time, but that won't result in legitimizing unacceptable conduct – especially if it repeatedly manifests as violence or disrespectful behavior. Clearly, values and morality aren't fully developed in children at this stage. That doesn't stop Mediators from consistently and gently reinforcing the behaviors they want to pass on to their tiny progeny.

Unbalanced Toddler Bonding

Taking Things Personally

This stage can be especially challenging for Mediator parents if they take their toddlers' willful or defiant behavior personally. When the children they've so lovingly raised begin using their newly acquired favorite word ("No!") in response to their parents' questions, it can be both frustrating and discouraging. From throwing a fit every evening at bedtime to refusing to eat any form of fresh produce (or any healthy food for that matter), toddlers often seem as though they're focused on challenging what their parents have taught them at every turn.

As much as they truly want to foster their children's independence, Mediators struggle when their children's behavior doesn't match their expectations. The toddler stage is where identity development begins, and kids are rarely going to behave in a way that fits their parents' personal mold. Behaviors such as hitting their siblings or yelling at their parents – which, while not desirable, are normal for this stage – can be especially demoralizing to Mediators who feel their children's moral development should be further along at this point. When these parents are more focused on these idealized versions of their children, they may miss opportunities to promote and support what's unique about their toddlers.

Too Permissive

Toddlers are professional boundary pushers, and Mediators crave harmony. Clearly these two mentalities are diametrically opposed, which can result in overwhelmed parents and domineering children. Rather than dealing with constant battles and temper tantrums, disheartened Mediators may find themselves caving into their toddlers' demands for more screen time or extra snacks.

Harmony is certainly valuable, but it isn't what permissive parents are creating when they consistently give in to their children's demands. Rather, they're telling their toddlers that if they just hold out long enough, they'll eventually get whatever they want. In addition to giving into their demands, permissive parents often fail to consistently enforce rules or consequences for unacceptable behavior. While they may believe they're providing freedom and friendship rather than restrictive rules, Mediator parents who fail to uphold necessary boundaries are setting their children up for potential behavior issues, a lack of ambition, and poor decision-making skills.

Rebalancing Toddler Bonding

Promoting Responsible Independence

Pushing boundaries and defiant behavior are hallmarks of this stage, and while they can be extraordinarily frustrating, they're necessary parts of developing autonomy. Saying "no" is a way to establish boundaries, and developing boundaries is a fundamental component to identity development. It's easy to respond emotionally in such trying circumstances. However, that's not only unproductive, but often exacerbates the situation. Mediator parents must take time to understand their kids are establishing autonomy and aren't intentionally looking to reject them. Once they change their mindset to one of understanding over frustration, these types can have more success in setting boundaries with their children.

Just because children are learning to set their own boundaries, it doesn't mean their parents should allow them to get away with demanding behavior. Rather, understanding *why* their little ones are acting in this manner can prevent some of the Mediators' negative reactionary responses. Here are some ways Mediator parents can approach potentially frustrating experiences (such as leaving the park) in a proactive rather than reactive manner:

- Upon arriving at the park, letting toddlers know how long they'll be there.
- Starting the countdown at least 15 minutes before leaving.
- Announcing the time left in five-minute increments. ("We are leaving in 15 minutes... Ten minutes left before we leave... Ok, five minutes left.")
- Making sure toddlers hear the warnings, and making eye contact with them when possible.
- Walking calmly toward children when there's about one minute left.

- Avoiding the temptation to rush or leave quickly if possible. The more positive the experience, the more likely toddlers are to leave willingly in the future.

This process allows kids to complete any activities and ensures they understand their parents' expectations. It also gives Mediators a sense of control – a way to be proactive and prevent temper tantrums – rather than just reacting to these outbursts with their own emotional responses.

Supporting with Structure and Discipline

There's nothing inherently wrong with Mediators wanting their kids to like them, or in promoting freedom and independence from a young age. Problems arise when harmony and independence are prioritized above their children's need for structure and discipline. Toddlers are incapable of understanding the consequences of their behavior, especially when their parents fail to explain or enforce household rules. Thankfully, it's possible for Mediators to maintain a loving bond with their kids while still providing the boundaries necessary to make sure they're safe and well-behaved.

Perhaps the most important thing for these parents to understand is that restricting their children's freedom when they're young teaches them how to be responsible with higher levels of freedom when they're older. Children who have never had to regulate their behavior or be accountable for their actions are more likely to engage in risky behaviors and take advantage of their freedom. Kids who gradually earn their independence, on the other hand, have greater self-control and a much better understanding of the potential consequences of their behavior since they've been disciplined in the past. Here's several steps Mediator parents can take to provide the structure and discipline their toddlers both need and desire to set them up for the most successful future possible:

- Making sure household expectations and rules are well known to all members of the family.
- Being consistent in enforcing rules and making sure children know the consequences of breaking these rules.
- Rewarding positive behaviors with special privileges or treats.
- Enlisting spouses, partners, family members, or close friends to be accountability partners and to assist when situations are overwhelming.

Thirst for Knowledge (From Approximately 3 to 5 Years)

The preschool years, from approximately three to five years of age, are a prime time for brain development, and children at this stage accumulate knowledge at an extraordinary rate. Kids absorb information like sponges through constant activity and a seemingly infinite range of questions. Learning at this stage takes place through play (especially the unstructured kind), and lots of social interaction with family and peers. Creativity is also exercised extensively through imaginary play and make-believe games and stories.

To master this stage, preschoolers must be given the opportunity to not only make some of their own decisions, but also be allowed to initiate activities, ask questions – and receive answers – and lead others in exploration play. Children who aren't given these opportunities, or are made to feel as though their constant questions or childish make-believe games are annoying, can experience feelings of guilt, frustration, and a lack of competence. Consequently, they may suffer from poor self-control or a lack of initiative.

Balanced Preschool Relationships

Natural Teachers

As promoters of lifelong learning themselves, Mediator parents genuinely look forward to inspiring their sons and daughters to enjoy learning as well. They happily answer their preschool children's seemingly ceaseless stream of questions, and take great pleasure in finding creative ways to engage their kids in learning opportunities. From trips to the library to impromptu nature "classes" while walking to the park, these types take any chance they can to engage with and inspire their little ones.

Seeking out educational opportunities isn't the only form of teaching that Mediator parents engage in. Modeling morals and values for their children from a young age is just as important to them as any other form of learning. These parents teach their children to not only respect others, but also appreciate their differences as well. Compassion is key with these types, and they'll go out of their way, quite literally, to model this behavior for their kids – like pulling over to help a stray or hurt animal, even if they're already running late to school. Preschoolers can likely not only witness their parents' actions, but also be involved in helping (in age-appropriate ways) with caring for any plants, animals, or people that need their help.

Emotionally Engaged

Life with their preschoolers isn't only about "teachable moments" for Mediator parents. Emotional engagement is their number one priority, both in terms of building strong bonds with their children and in teaching them how to develop their emotional intelligence. Self-control, empathy, and interpersonal relationships (especially with peers) are all beginning to develop, and kids at this stage must have guidance to properly develop these skills.

Emotional intelligence is best learned through modeling, and this is where these parents can truly shine. There are few types who engage with others as authentically as Mediators. They're full of love and compassion for others and instinctually model these concepts to their children. Imaginary play is an especially useful outlet for practicing these skills. Something as simple as playing a game of "house" with their kids can be a perfect opportunity for them to both model healthy relationships and lovingly redirect less-than-desirable behaviors. Not only do they pass on their emotional wisdom, parents who engage in these types of play with their preschoolers enhance their emotional bonds as well.

Unbalanced Preschool Relationships

Prone to Burnout

The preschool years bring a new level of energy with them as children become more interested in making sense of the world around them. Kids at this stage are more mobile and opinionated than ever, which can try the patience of even the most devoted caregivers. Parenting is an exhausting endeavor, and this stage can be especially draining with kids' constant questions and need for stimulation. As an Introverted and especially private personality type, Mediators who fail to set up boundaries or find time to recharge quickly become depleted by the constant attention that their children demand.

Children aren't the only ones placing excessive expectations on parents at this stage. The preschool era ushers in an increasing number of play dates, swimming lesson, and art classes. In today's increasingly connected culture, there's an often-unrealistic expectation that parents should be shuttling their children to every enrichment opportunity available and documenting it all on social media. Mediator parents who

feel pressured to play into society's expectations can become overwhelmed, feeling the need to make every birthday party and family vacation worthy of "sharing." All this running around and attempting to be "perfect parents" can quickly take a toll on these types, who would much prefer to focus on the meaningful over the marketable.

Struggling with Schedules

The same issues that can lead to burnout for Mediator parents are often the root cause of the schedule-anxiety that they're apt to succumb to during this stage. The preschool years often bring with them an exponential increase in activities and expectations. Preschool classes, play dates, birthday parties, and community events geared toward children appear in excess as parents are expected to become more interested in educating and entertaining their children outside of the home. For Mediators, who abhor schedules and can struggle with making plans or being on time, this stage can truly test their limits.

As a Prospecting type, Mediators prefer freedom over itineraries. This laid-back mentality can spiral into irresponsible behaviors, especially for those who are less mature, resulting in their children being consistently late to classes or play dates. Tardiness, forgetting appointments and playdates, and failing to provide the funds for classes or field trips is a recipe for constant stress and frustration. While they certainly don't need to sign up to play chauffeur for every class event or bring snacks to all the soccer games, these parents shouldn't assume that they can get by with frequent unreliability. If they fail to organize their lives in a way that works for both their sanity and their preschoolers' social calendars, Mediators may find themselves living in constant chaos.

Rebalancing Preschool Relationships

Re-Adjusting Expectations

Rather than allowing their own and society's expectations to drive them to the brink of burnout, Mediator parents can learn to say "no" to the endless play dates and parties and say "yes" to taking a much-needed break whenever possible. Kids benefit more from having healthy, happy parents than they do from having birthday parties with designer cakes, pony rides, and goody bags worthy of being handed out at the Oscars. And these types benefit more from focusing on meeting both their children's and their own needs in authentic ways rather than buckling to societal expectations.

While Mediator parents may initially feel some guilt for not "living up" to these often-unrealistic expectations, they ultimately feel liberated from the unnecessary obligations. It's also important for them to find ways to take care of themselves amid parenting their preschoolers. Some ideas that can bring balance into this busy stage include:

- Determining the number of activities that feel right – one play date per week is fine and so is four, whatever works best for both parents and their children.
- Learning to say "No." While birthday parties and nature classes are nice, having a relaxing weekend or afternoon is sometimes more important.
- Knowing the signs of burnout and exhaustion for both parents and children, which can include:
 - Temper tantrums and spontaneous tears.
 - Extreme tiredness.
 - Feelings of anxiety or trepidation when certain events are on the horizon.

- Starting small – trying one class or play group for a couple of weeks to see if it feels right.
- Avoiding the temptation to try to do too many things at once.
- Avoiding letting others inflict guilty for not participating in every little thing.

Focusing on Sanity

There's nothing quite like parenthood to make Mediators aware of some of their most frustrating flaws. Scheduling, organization, and details in general can allude many of these types, and it's important for their sanity to figure out how to deal with these issues once kids enter the picture. While words like "structure" and "planning" can sound like torture to a personality type that thrives on flexibility, they can find that building a daily rhythm into their lives provides them with more freedom.

Many Mediators, especially those who are parents, fail to take the time they need to recharge their Introverted batteries. A daily rhythm can provide the structure necessary to make sure that everyone's needs are being met while also ensuring that important tasks are being attended to. This rhythm can also create a sense of control, providing these parents with a reprieve from feelings of perpetual chaos that are a constant source of stress and distraction. The following tips can help them create a daily rhythm to help find sanity amid the bedlam of parenthood:

- First, and most importantly, determining daily priorities that must be considered every day, such as alone time, family time, exercise, or time for engaging in hobbies.
- Utilizing scheduling tools to help organize these priorities, such as an online calendar, a bullet journal, a day planner, or even a large family calendar hanging in the kitchen or family room.

- When creating a schedule for the day, making sure to include periods of time with nothing scheduled – this allows for flexibility.
- Figuring out a rhythm that works best and committing to following that rhythm for at least 28 days so that it evolves into a habit.

Creating Competence (From Approximately 5 to 12 Years)

The early school years are an important period of skill development for young children. Not only are they still constantly absorbing new information, they're also working on becoming proficient in increasingly complex areas, from relationships to mathematics to athletics. Children who are both challenged and supported in these areas flourish in both their abilities as well as their self-confidence.

If they don't receive consistent support, kids at this stage can begin to feel inferior to their peers, and are less likely to develop and work toward long-term goals. On the other hand, if they aren't sufficiently challenged, they can begin to feel overly-confident in themselves and their abilities and come to lack modesty and compassion toward others. They can also have difficulty coping with the inevitable failures they'll face.

Balanced School-Age Relationships

Passionate and Encouraging

Often avid learners themselves, Mediators encourage their sons and daughters to pursue their education with passion and curiosity. Passing spelling tests and memorizing multiplication tables aren't as important to these types as having kids

who are creative and compassionate. If they feel their children aren't receiving a truly holistic education, these parents can explore alternative options such as homeschooling or charter schools to fill in the gaps.

Their empathic nature helps Mediators to quickly realize when their children may be struggling, allowing them to step in and offer their support before these situations get too serious. Their encouragement extends beyond academics, with support for their children's social and personal development as well. Knowing the challenges their children are facing, these parents provide them with the tools necessary, such as empathy and compassion, to help them deal with difficult peers or frustrating fights with friends.

Spiritual and Emotional Mentors

The school years are a time of intense learning, not just academically but emotionally, spiritually and socially as well. Mature Mediators excel at modeling the skills needed to be compassionate, considerate, and motivated individuals. Yes, children need to learn mathematics and writing, but if their education fails to incorporate human elements like spiritual and emotional needs, they ultimately end up confused and unfulfilled. Parents with this personality type go out of their way to ensure that their children find meaning in everything they do. They encourage them to pursue passions that focus on innovation and creativity over the rote memorization that's often expected at this stage.

At a stage in life when kids are constantly being told what to do and required to conform to strict schedules, innovation and creativity often become neglected or viewed as unnecessary. Imaginative Mediator parents encourage their kids to incorporate their unique ideas and perspectives into both their academic and

personal lives. They encourage their sons and daughters to integrate their passions and causes into these areas as well – from science projects focused on solving issues surrounding global warming to organizing a student council community volunteer day. Few types are as effective at inspiring and promoting passion into their children at this stage as Mediators.

Unbalanced School-Age Relationships

Struggle with Confidence

One of the most important skills for kids to develop during their school years is confidence. From persisting on a difficult school assignment to standing up for a friend who is being teased, confidence is what gives children the strength to work hard and do the right thing. Mediator parents who may have lacked support or encouragement during their formative years are especially likely to lack confidence in their own abilities. Struggling in a school setting or being belittled by domineering parents or teachers may come back to haunt these types, preventing them from developing – and therefore modeling – the confidence necessary to thrive.

If they fail to overcome these barriers themselves, Mediator parents run the risk of raising children who shut down in the face of adversity. It does little good to tell a child to, “Stand up for what they believe in,” and to “Persevere when the going gets tough,” if they fail to model these behaviors in their own lives. Their kids won’t only struggle with their own confidence, but may see their well-intentioned parents as hypocrites that fail to “walk the walk” when things become too challenging.

Overly Idealistic

Mediators' passionate idealism can cause issues for their children at this stage if it isn't properly balanced with their children's needs and abilities. School-aged kids certainly benefit from being concerned about protecting the environment and practicing compassion toward all living things. However, they also need parents who can help them address some of the practical issues they may face daily. From a school crush that isn't reciprocated to the trauma of being picked last for the kickball team, children at this age need parents who can help them deal with personal issues that deeply affect them.

If they're constantly focused on the bigger picture, Mediator parents can fail to validate their children's feelings on these "smaller issues" and find their kids are less likely to seek their help or support in the future. Sure, the world isn't going to end if their children don't make the basketball team, but it can feel catastrophic to children at that age, when everything that happens to them is a big deal. Parents who don't recognize this and don't help their children put things into perspective can ultimately struggle to maintain close relationships with them.

Rebalancing School-Age Relationships

Promote Confidence

The beauty of confidence is it's a skill that can be developed at any age – it's never too late to improve this trait. Parenthood is a very effective motivator, and Mediator parents have every desire to help their kids be successful in life. Individuals with this personality type are put off by self-promotion and any behavior they view as self-serving, and must overcome their misguided belief that being confident somehow equates as being arrogant.

Mediators can also keep in mind how important it is for their school-aged children to develop a sense of competence to effectively move through this stage. Children should be encouraged to take pride in their work and be taught to view failures as new opportunities. They thrive when their parents acknowledge their achievements and learn that their hard work can pay off. Hang spelling tests they ace on the refrigerator, and celebrate with extra desert after dinner or a (slightly) later bedtime that weekend.

When they fail, Mediator parents can help them dust themselves off and look for the light at the end of that proverbial tunnel. Didn't make the dance team? That's fine – they can join cheerleading or debate instead! Kids who realize that failure isn't the end of the road but rather the beginning of another path are likely to be more confident and successful throughout their lives. The following tips can help Mediators improve their own self-confidence to ensure that they're promoting this trait in their kids as well:

- Writing down one strength and how it helped in overcoming a specific challenge. ("My eloquent speaking helped me to nail my most recent job interview.")
- Thinking of something that causes fear or hesitation regularly – possibly a fear of failure or criticism – and writing down three things to do to overcome this fear, such as taking a class on speaking skills to overcome a fear of public speaking.
- Working toward becoming an expert in a specific skill, like mastering the guitar or becoming fluent in a second language – something that really promotes a sense of competence.
- Making a commitment to practice positive self-talk, as nothing brings down

confidence as quickly as the negative thoughts people have about themselves.

Meeting Them Where They Are

Attentive and compassionate, Mediators really do excel at supporting their kids and providing them with copious amounts of affection. When they become too caught up in the big picture, however, these parents may find themselves ignoring the details of their children's experiences. Kids at this stage want to be heard and understood, and have their experiences validated. These types are more than capable of providing the unconditional love and acceptance their sons and daughters need, and can use these skills to hone in on what their children truly crave to feel understood.

Mediators who are prone to fixating on the big picture can benefit from focusing on what their children are dealing with in the moment. Some ideas for engaging with their kids in the "here and now" can include:

- Starting a gratitude practice at bedtime (or whenever works) where both parents and children state three things they're grateful for that day, and one thing that's bothering them.
- Having a parent/child date once every week or two, with the intention of spending time listening to each other and not merely entertaining them.
- Listening, making eye contact, and expressing interest whenever children are speaking, and making sure parents aren't daydreaming or staring at a screen.
- Always acknowledging their frustrations, fears, or disappointments by using phrasing such as, "I really see how frustrated you get when..." or, "I understand your fear of..."

Find Thyself (From Approximately 12 to 18 Years)

Adolescence is the transition from childhood to adulthood where kids focus on developing their own distinct sense of identity. This transitional period centers around the individual's sense of what their roles are in their relationships with themselves, others, and society in general. To determine their roles, adolescents in this stage begin the all-important process of identifying their personal values and beliefs. Educational and future career goals are made, and relationships are developed based on how they align with these values and beliefs, making this a pivotal, foundational stage for the rest of their lives.

Balanced Adolescent Relationships

Promote Positive Values

During this stage of identity development, adolescents need the support and understanding of their parents more than ever. Mediator parents encourage their adolescent children's growth by promoting positive values, such as responsibility, compassion, and honesty, while providing them with freedom to explore these values in their own ways. As difficult as it can be, parents who have been through this process themselves understand the importance of assisting their children in their personal development, and do so to the best of their ability.

Regardless of the struggles that everyone may face during this tumultuous time, Mediator parents can remain steadfast in their devotion to their children. Their dedication to the promotion of their positive values, as well as their compassion toward their children, provide a solid foundation which allows identity-seeking teens to venture further into self-discovery while still feeling a sense of support and love.

Authentic and Committed

Adolescence is a tumultuous stage for most teenagers as they attempt to determine who they are and who they want to be. These discoveries are often made through trial and error, meaning many mistakes can be made. As one of the most authentic personality types, Mediators' honesty and unwavering commitment are indispensable during this stage. Honesty is necessary to help teens learn from their mistakes – adolescents who skip class need to know the potential consequences of this behavior before it's too late. Their parents' steadfast commitment can provide adolescents with the confidence to communicate with them, even when topics are uncomfortable.

If Mediator parents can maintain their kind understanding, minimal judgment, and authentic communication when their adolescents come to them with something truly serious – getting pregnant, getting suspended or expelled, or milder stuff like a rough breakup – they can establish themselves as a true source of stability and wisdom for life when their kids need it most. As overwhelming and terrifying as some of these situations may seem, Mediators who can tap into their confidence and empathy can confront these situations from a place of wisdom rather than one of panic. They can treat their teens with respect, but they're still the wise, understanding adults in the room.

Unbalanced Adolescent Relationships

Failing to Establish and Enforce Boundaries

The process of personal discovery is a favorite topic for many Mediators who gladly pass their passion for growth and development on to their adolescent children. This is all fine and good, until these parents prioritize the process of self-discovery over

establishing or enforcing healthy boundaries for their sons and daughters. Allowing inappropriate behavior for the sake of “finding oneself” isn’t only unwise, it’s downright dangerous.

Despite the gains that they’ve made in both intelligence and communication skills, their adolescent brains aren’t fully developed. The prefrontal cortex – the area of the brain responsible for complex planning, decision making, and regulating social behaviors – isn’t fully operational until individuals reach their mid-twenties. Children at this stage are literally incapable of fully understanding all the potential consequences of their behavior and, as a bonus, suffer from poor social and emotional regulation. Mediator parents who avoid setting and enforcing boundaries because they’re afraid of infringing on their children’s autonomy can set them up for failure.

Forgoing a curfew for teenagers out of respect for their independence can come with serious risks, as teens without supervision are more likely to engage in dangerous and illegal activities. Underage drinking, illegal drug use, vandalism, and unsafe sex can seem even more exciting. Even the most mature adolescents can make poor choices when tempting situations combine with poor boundaries and no supervision.

Difficulty Detaching

The adolescent stage requires that children become more independent, making critical life choices on their own and relying less on their parents for basic support. Mediator parents can struggle with feelings of rejection if they believe their children no longer need them or desire their affection. They may also find themselves mourning the end of their childhood, remembering those sweet kindergarten children they walked into class on the first day of school. If they become too absorbed

by a sense of loss at this stage, these types can slip into an existential crisis of sorts, pining for days gone by rather than looking forward to the opportunities that lie ahead for both them and their kids.

Additionally, for some Mediators, parenthood is their “purpose” and the most important part of their identity. If they fail to maintain or nurture other parts of their identity throughout their children’s younger years, these parents may fervently hold on to their role as primary caregivers. If parenting has prevented them from maintaining friendships, pursuing meaningful hobbies, or engaging in enjoyable work, they may feel lost and lonely as their children inevitably begin to spend more time away from home. They may begin to experience bitterness, a deep sense of loss, and even a sense of panic about the uncertainty of their own future with this defining role no longer at the center of their lives.

Rebalancing Adolescent Relationships

Creating Responsible Boundaries

Boundaries are necessary for children of all ages to gain skills and confidence in a safe, understanding environment. Mediator parents aren’t doing their adolescents any favors by sending them into the world without guidelines or discipline. The dangers of this permissive approach are much more prominent than any potential benefits. While enforcing rules and restricting behaviors goes against Mediators’ live-and-let-live nature, it’s important that they learn to appreciate and value these skills for the safety and security that they provide.

Adolescents often believe themselves to be indestructible and are unable to fully realize the potential consequences of their actions. Mediator parents are responsible for creating boundaries for their teens, from curfews to consequences for

inappropriate behaviors. Kids who are failing one of their classes may need to be restricted from social activities or screen time until their grades improve. Likewise, adolescents who have been spending time with a troublesome peer may need a strictly enforced curfew. Mediators may chafe at these types of restrictions, but they're ultimately providing structure and security that their adolescent children are unable to provide for themselves. The following tips can help Mediator parents have a productive conversation about boundaries with their children:

- Making sure these conversations take place when everyone involved is amenable. Shouting about boundaries and expectations when individuals are angry is unproductive and often prevents buy-in.
- Using humor when possible.
- Using age-appropriate language to explain how certain boundaries can benefit adolescents both in the present and future.

Promoting Responsible Independence

The adolescent stage requires that kids become increasingly independent from their parents by building their own sense of identity and personal values. This can be especially difficult for Mediators who thrive on being their children's caretakers or identify primarily as parents. Rather than viewing their children's increasing independence as the death knell to their parental role, however, they can focus on viewing this new stage in their kids' lives as both a beautiful and necessary part of their personal evolution.

Parenthood doesn't end – ever. From birth until death, parents retain bonds with their sons and daughters that are unparalleled in both influence and meaning. Each stage represents a new level of this bond, and an opportunity to pass on hard-earned

wisdom. Mediators who are struggling to let go of the current manifestation of their role as parents can benefit from pursuing their own personal growth. The following tips can help Mediators step back and focus on finding themselves while also remaining a source of advice and inspiration to their children:

- Embracing a spiritual or meditative practice.
- Taking up (or rediscovering) an artistic hobby such as writing, painting, photography, or sewing – practicing a skill and enjoy the benefits of some creative healing and inspiration.
- Taking this opportunity to engage in some self-reflection through journaling or even guided counseling, to better understand who they are and who they would like to become.

Conclusion

Parenting is one of the most challenging experiences that anyone can face, regardless of their personality type. Mediators have their own unique strengths and weaknesses they need to leverage to build positive, proactive relationships with their children. There's tremendous potential for personal development that takes place when becoming a parent, and Mediators can gain a much deeper understanding of themselves and others if they use this opportunity to do so.

The advice provided above is based on general growth stages for children and basic strengths and weaknesses that many Mediators share. Every child is different, and parents are the best judge of what their children need. The advice above should be used in a way that works best for each family without adding additional stress, frustration, or burden. For special situations, such as behavioral or medical issues,

it's best to consult with a professional pediatrician or pediatric psychologist to come up with a plan that works best for everyone involved.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your role as a parent? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

Parenting Styles Test

Whether you have children already or hope to become a parent in the future, this test offers you useful insights into your parenting style.

Type Guesser (Parent)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your parent belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

Type Guesser (Child)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your teenage child belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

Academic Path



As a rare personality type that's not always well understood, Mediators often find the psychological impact of school is especially relevant. These types stand out as unusual when compared to their fellow students, and the obligatory and objective nature of the classroom can exacerbate their naturally sensitive disposition. As such, their learning style presents distinct challenges, both for themselves and their teachers, yet Mediators who embrace their unique style while working within a structured educational program can find tremendous success. By learning more about this personality type's inherent learning style and habits, educators too can enrich the lives of their Mediator students – and their own lives in the process.

Intuitive Learners

Mediators often don't know why they know things. Ideas and vague notions of how to navigate themselves academically seem to appear out of thin air for these types – like knowing how to write a well-planned essay without any outline whatsoever. They just know, without putting much thought into the how or why. What seems like

random bursts of knowledge, however, is really that their subconscious absorbs information and connects nearly imperceptible patterns.

Known as intuitive learning, this ability to channel coherent streams-of-consciousness into their work from these oh-so-subtle patterns makes them students who can grasp abstract concepts quickly, understand the meaning of the theoretical without being told, and easily and enthusiastically learn things outside the classroom.

However, as magnificent as the gift of intuitive learning is, it actively works against these types in conventional educational systems, as students who give concrete evidence that they're learning are those who reap the rewards. It's easy to see where the issue lies for Mediators whose thought processes are hidden – even from themselves.

Humanistic Relevancy

Mediators have a natural grip on topics that deal with people and interpersonal relationships. This isn't surprising, considering how attuned these types are with their own emotions. They use their feelings as a filter to view the world through. That's why courses that deal with the humanities – philosophy, literature, religion, art, music, history, and language – frequently lure Mediators into lengthy study, but they find frequently themselves infatuated with fascinating academic topics.

These types require a strong personal connection to a topic in order feel fully invested, and they may wonder how important it is to learn material they have no personal interest in. Consequently, these types usually take issue with standardized benchmarks: They find strictly structured mandatory tests take away the spontaneous joy of learning. Their aversion to the mundane can lead Mediators to

completely avoid, and perhaps discount, things outside their immediate realm of interest.

How Mediators Learn

Mediators are capable of being amazing students who mix Intuition with inherent precociousness, but these abilities can lead them away from well-rounded academic paths they're given too much leeway. These types often find their greatest success by blending their academic resources with their own intuitions.

Balanced Learning Habits

Deconstructing the Intuitive

Mediators base their learning style in creativity, humanistic relevancy, and spontaneity. These types rarely need to dig deeply into individual details of a subject to start making deep connections. Typical learning structures measure success based on assessments over details, so Mediators can feel overwhelmed and out of place in a traditional education system. However, there's no rewiring their brain to perform otherwise – and nor should there be an attempt. A balanced approach to academics for Mediators requires a merging of existing structure with their unorthodox learning style.

The thought processes of Mediators provide them with answers first, from which they work backwards, deconstructing the larger subject into details, facts, and fundamentals. For example, these types may write an essay with little to no planning involved, and then deconstruct the final draft at length. These types are apt to note the anatomy of their essay in detail, taking stock of the outline, techniques, errors, and revisions. Through this consideration of their spontaneous answers, Mediators

clarify their own learning process and improve knowledge retention, which provides them invaluable information for learning more efficiently and thoroughly in the future.

Mixing in Practicality

Mediators, like all Diplomats, find that subjects that focus on some sort of human factor resonate more with them than subjects that don't – they would rather write a supporting essay about how myths and fairy tales reflect modern day society than solve for "x." However, some also understand that there's a need for learning "mundane" skills, like taking the time to develop long-term study habits for classes they don't enjoy. These Mediators develop this balanced approach because they understand that these skills, though not dreamy and inspiring, are necessary for everyday life.

Rather than shrugging off things they aren't inherently interested in, these types dig in their heels and attempt to master the material in front of them. They're propelled forward by the sense that the drudgery of mundane subjects is only temporary, and that the skills they're learning can support work they consider meaningful.

Unbalanced Learning Habits

Skipping the Fundamentals

While pondering interesting ideas, Mediators' thinking may be too abstract to connect to the concrete learning going on in some classrooms. While the instructor is leading a very linear lesson where variable "A" interacts with "B" resulting in "C," Mediators may be massaging concepts only vaguely related to these lettered facts. For these types, "A," "B," and "C" work as a springboard for their thinking, and their

ideas aren't dependent on any one of them. This doesn't mean they aren't learning: They might even draw their own meaningful conclusions independently. Problems arise for these types, however, when they're unwilling to retrace their steps to understand how they arrived at their conclusions.

Mediators may not feel confident reciting facts, and may find it hard to concentrate on details they're expected to mirror on assessments like quizzes or exams. Although in their own way, it may prove difficult for these types to repeat back what's expected. Many people complain that they feel competent as learners, but they "don't test well" – Mediators can be especially prone to this. A Mediator taking an unbalanced approach to learning may completely discount grades and exams. This comes at their peril: These systems of evaluation act as communication between students, instructors, and schools. Forgoing these measures also forfeits the benefits that come from such understandings, whether within institutions or among trusted friends, and ultimately creates isolation and frustration with little good to show for it.

Narrow Interests

In many ways, Mediators are generalists. Their Prospecting trait keeps them jumping from interest to interest, giving them a wide array of things on which to focus. Still, they may quickly shut out anything that lacks direct appeal to their inspirational bent. Having narrow interests is one thing, but discounting topics outside that scope is something else. When Mediators dismiss what's outside their immediate interest, they run the risk of being unprepared to take their true interest to the next level, as advanced understanding of one thing may require a small understanding of all things. Without such context, they limit their ability to advance, narrowing their perspective – a travesty for those who value universal understanding.

Most students love some courses and dislike others. Mediators may take this to the next level, feeling no connection whatsoever to subjects like algebra. They may bide their time and do the best they can to please teachers and parents while waiting to get to philosophy or history class. This superficial approach may get the job done – and by many measures it will be a job well done – but the value of the whole experience as an academic learning opportunity is thrown into question.

Rebalancing Learning Habits

Solidifying the Abstract

Communication is an important part of Mediators' learning style, and they solidify their abstract notions when verbalizing their thoughts or writing them out. While not necessarily shy, these Introverts may not be forthcoming with what they're thinking, as it's often unconventional or even fantastical. To avoid criticism, they may learn not to share their ideas. Nonetheless, the act of talking or writing about their thoughts – turning abstractions into words – can be helpful.

Mediators may feel reluctant to take on the task because it may first appear as a large mass of indecipherable information. It's like describing the shape of smoke. Before they can measure the ideas in their head, they must first contain them. This may seem difficult at first, but here are some things they can do to ease the process:

- Read over some previously written work, or write down new thoughts, for about 30 minutes.
- After reading or writing, go over the work again and pick out the most prevalent/interesting/recurring patterns.
- Write down this observation in a plain-form sentence. Describe the pattern. Why does this pattern come up? Why did it stand out?

- Apply this observation to the assignment at hand – as an outline, for example
– as proof of work.

Facts Thrive with Context

When faced with a topic that doesn't lie within their immediate realm of interest, Mediators can reframe it into a more interesting context. One way is using mnemonic devices to deal with facts, especially if they're contained within a story or put in meaningful, and perhaps even human, context. This works for all ages, but is particularly useful for younger Mediators.

There are a lot of ways to couch unrelated facts in things of interest. Where others may see memorization as an education goal, this task is more ancillary to the Mediator learning process. These types aren't "anti-facts" as much as they don't focus on them in favor of bigger ideas. Creative mnemonics may be the spoon of sugar that helps the medicine of cold facts go down for them.

The ways to attract Mediators to fact-based learning are almost endless, but some creativity may be necessary when it comes to engaging them in some subjects. Consider this mnemonic device that combines the planets in the solar system with stories from mythology:

- Swift-footed Mercury is closest to the Sun and so, like the god, runs fastest around our star.
- Next is Venus, named after the goddess of love and beauty as it's also the most stunning thing in sky.
- War-like Mars glares red and angry at its nearest neighbor, Earth, who holds a coveted place closer to his lover, Venus.

This blends literature and culture with cold facts about the planets and their locations. (When it comes to Mediators, adding a poetic feel doesn't hurt, either.) Such a combination makes learning a list of planets more palatable to these creative types.

Mediators in High School

Mediators are perfectionistic in their ideals – and, in high school, they begin to look at the world as a place that holds meaning and takes dreams seriously. This adds enough gravitas to the high school experience that these insightful individuals do well overall. In their striving to maintain harmony, these types work hard to get grades that please parents and teachers. Although their burgeoning presence in the world propels them to excellence even in challenging subjects, Mediators often must pay special attention to whether a course is too mundane or detail-oriented for them.

Balanced High School Learning

Curious and Idealistic

The childlike wonder and curiosity of Mediators is a strength that lets them joyfully hop from topic to topic, making instant connections along with their inclination to easily communicate abstract concepts. In environments where structure and standardization are preferred, Mediators can find approaches to guide their curiosity in more practical ways rather than quashing it all together.

By creating a high school schedule that works with their interests, they can develop points to look forward to during a long day of subjects they may not exactly be interested in. An art class, for example, where they can freely pursue their painting

passion, can serve as encouragement for them to pay attention to required courses as they pursue their own passions as well.

Making the Mundane Interesting

The courses that speak to Mediators most are the humanities and social sciences. Literature, language, history, political science, psychology, philosophy, and similar subjects resonate best with these students, who are riveted to any course that includes overcoming human dilemmas. Commiserating with character from well-written stories appeals to both their imaginations and their emotions, and studying an individual or culture from history feels like home for these learners.

Much of the zeal Mediators show for a social studies course disappears if a teacher assigns lists of dates to memorize – any learning-by-rote class will lose their attention. These types prefer a class that's lighter on the hard facts, and they connect far more with Hamlet's existential crisis than the physical properties of uranium. A proper synthesis of the two might grab these types, however: Pair that same uranium discussion with an account of Marie Curie's trailblazing accomplishments as a scientist, and the subject becomes more meaningful and interesting for Mediators.

Unbalanced High School Learning

Uneven Attention to Subjects

When a subject comes easily to them, Mediators may not apply themselves to learning. They may take it for granted that they'll do well and not put as much effort into tests and papers, especially if the subject doesn't excite them personally.

Mediators aren't typically bound by conventional rules and structure in their inner lives. They wouldn't necessarily perceive neglecting a subject that comes easily as

laziness on their part: The bigger picture always takes priority for these types, and putting a lot of labor into seemingly mundane or unimportant work may seem senseless. Mediators won't lose sleep at night over their own lackadaisical attitude: They'll probably do just as well anyway, regardless of whether they invest time and attention.

However, this easy success isn't always wise. Even the smallest details have value: Learning discipline independent of how it feels is a valuable life lesson. In fact, the more these students step out of their comfort zone, the broader their influence on the world around them, and the more likely they are to experience personal growth. This doesn't mean these types should giving up their inherent Mediator strengths – simply that expanding their repertoire of behavior beyond what they're used to and prefer can be the best way to address their priorities.

Relying on Intuition

It's at this stage in life that Mediators begin to realize that natural precociousness may not be enough. This is a personality type who, at an early age, may have moved from regular classrooms into more advanced classes. During that period, they may have learned their inherent talent was enough and that studying wasn't necessary. This fixed mindset begins to fail them in high school, as things like structure and studying become more important to academic success than what their Intuition can readily provide.

Instead of recognizing that their habits are keeping them from well-rounded knowledge, they may blame themselves for not being smart enough or working hard enough. They can fall into the trap of believing that there's no room for growth, and that their natural talents fall short of what's needed to succeed.

Rebalancing High School Learning

Creating a Personal Path

The main issue within Mediators' academic careers is that their learning style doesn't quite fit the mold. In high school, learning how to create efficient ways to utilize their creativity can benefit them most throughout life. While covering the required benchmarks, these students can work at home in customized, independent ways that allow them to learn in their own style.

Mediators can motivate themselves to deal with courses that feel mundane and narrow by reminding themselves that discipline can work in all parts of their life. These types might not show much enthusiasm for algebra, but learning the material despite a lukewarm attitude can be a great exercise in self-growth. Like all Diplomats, the idea of becoming someone better is always lingering in the background for Mediators. If they reframe any subject as an exercise in personal development, rather than an exercise in math, (or science, or geography), they may find the energy needed to engage more fully in the subject. Of course, this may be asking a lot of most adolescents. However, if nothing else, it answers the question, "How will I ever use [subject] in my life?" Answer: You can use it to learn to become more disciplined.

Here's how Mediators can create personal paths fit to their academic needs:

- Consider a required subject that they're not particularly interested in.
- Research a prominent figure in the subject – consider Katherine Goble for mathematics, for example.
- Find out why this person was a revolutionary in their time.

Developing a Growth Mindset

Carol Dweck, a renowned professor of psychology, has developed a working theory called “Growth Mindset” that focuses on motivation, learning, and the problem with the idea of a “fixed mindset” – the idea that individuals are unable to learn anything beyond what they’re naturally good at. Mediators can easily fall into this “fixed mindset,” as they’re told from a young age that they’re gifted and talented, and often resent themselves for not remaining so as they grow older. To fix this, they must first reframe “can’t” into “not yet.”

The consequence of this “fixed mindset” is an aversion to risking failure or success, as either could “disprove” the innate qualities Mediators see within themselves. By embracing failure, or even success, these students can grow exponentially within their academic careers.

Steps on how Mediator students can embrace failure:

- Consider one failure: This could be a single assignment, a course, or an entire subject of study.
 - What about this experience makes it a failure? Take notes.
- Revise this failure into an opportunity.
 - Then, write about that source of failure as an opportunity for growth: a failed exam shows the material that could be better understood; a failed course shows an instructor or set of ideas that never quite clicked; a failed subject shows an area of expertise that is something to work for.
- Gather information about how this could improve.

- Speak with the instructor who taught during this moment of failure about improvement. Did they notice any specific or persistent problems?
- Look up educational resources: test-taking strategies, study help for the subject, flash cards...
- Ask for help setting expectations. Sometimes failure is a difference in how people define success, and by following other standards it's easier to recognize where those differences lie.
- Consciously accept lessons that occur from the experiment.

Work or College?

The question of whether college is the right option is important. For some, it's a natural move that requires little forethought. Others may ask if college is something they want to pursue, or when they want to pursue it. So-called "gap years" are becoming a more popular option, as busy students seek to catch their breath before taking their seats at their chosen universities. Older adults are more regularly pursuing degrees later in life. Some individuals who see the success of college dropouts like Bill Gates or Steve Jobs wonder if getting a degree is worth it at all.

While all students need to examine their motives for going to college, Mediators need to more than others. They're almost compelled to find meaning and authenticity in all that they do. Participating in anything that doesn't fit their exacting standards leaves them experiencing regret and dissatisfaction.

Balanced Decision-Making

Taking the Steps Needed

Mediators may see college as a step to a career. However, they're unlikely to see a career as the be-all and end-all reason for making their choice. It can lead to a career, they may think, but can the experience enhance their lives as well? Can college help them grow? Or can they learn more from going straight into the working world? While their sometimes-dreamy approach to life may indicate otherwise, those who take a balanced approach to choosing college or work take practicality into consideration. Dreams, after all, won't pay the bills.

It's also not far-fetched to say that, with their unconventional thinking, some Mediators may choose alternative lifestyles off the conventional economic grid. This might mean choosing a "grow your own" style of self-reliance over joining the traditional workforce. These types understand their responsibilities enough to actively participate in keeping themselves alive and thriving – they may take off-the-beaten paths like exploring the world for a year, or becoming sustainable farmers in far-off countries.

Understanding Their Reasons

These students know that only they can make the decision to go to college. Pressure from family or other people in their lives can lead to disaster – Mediators must see higher education as aligned with their unique values to invest themselves fully. Other types may be okay going to college just because others expect it of them; Mediators find such expectations problematic.

Jobs right out of high school also need a sense of purpose for Mediators. Choosing employment simply to mark time and make a few dollars won't work for them any better than going to college without a good reason. However, "good reasons" sometimes come in interesting forms. Higher education often serves as a stopgap for young adults until they figure out what they want to do with their lives. Young Mediators may want to explore this option if their search for a meaningful type of work comes up empty. College can be a chance to explore ideas and discover new vistas while hunting for a job title that truly fits.

Unbalanced Decision-Making

Appealing Only to Instinct

Mediators' Prospecting trait may push them toward too many diverse interests. Their Intuition sees a big world, and their Prospecting trait wants to reach out and embrace it all. It can be difficult for some to choose a path. It may be easier for them to acquiesce to the wishes of others if their own desires are too overwhelmingly complex.

This is a personality type that doesn't always make strong cases based on objective facts. There are times when going on instincts works well. However, there are others when adhering to facts is essential. Mediators might rely too heavily on an almost spiritual direction in deference to their Intuitive and Feeling approaches to life. While powerful intuition is a gift, when used in an off-balanced way, it can counter reasonable arguments and lead to poor decisions.

Mediators need one foot on solid ground and the other in the heavens, metaphorically speaking. Deciding something as important as whether to attend college or not may be one of these occasions. Since going to college is such a

significant investment of time and money, deciding whether to or not needs to combine both rationality and instinct.

Selecting for Others

The opinions of parents or other admired mentors are important to many people, and to Mediators especially. Family may come first for these types, and they make sure to include their loved ones in most aspects of their lives – past, present, and future. Always conscientious of societal expectations, they may pick routes that are deemed “proper” or “acceptable” by authority figures in their lives.

It’s at this point these students can begin down a path of passive living – letting powerful loved ones have the majority say of the choices in their lives – even if they’re choices that Mediators don’t particularly like.

Rebalancing Decision-Making

Choosing Their Own Path

In many areas of life, these types may need to spend time deciding what they want and separating it from what others want. If people-pleasing is part of their college decision, they can rebalance this by pushing themselves to discover their true preference in reasonable yet assertive ways. However, Mediators who are standing their ground need to understand they can’t be responsible for the reactions of others. The college decision is one that affects their lives. Making the decision that suits them best is the highest form of authenticity in this matter. That alone may help motivate them to make their own choices.

Once they explore the hard facts, they can then start asking, “What is it that I want?” “What would give my life the most meaning now?” “Am I doing this to make someone

else happy, or is it the right thing for me?” Some of the answers may be complex and take some time and thought. However, the objective is to avoid doing something simply as an act of pleasing others. While this doesn’t mean that others can’t be pleased, Mediators need to be faithful to their values and aspirations. Without them, they’re not likely to benefit from involvement in college – or anything else, for that matter. Here’s a small exercise that can help:

Mediators can answer the following questions with one- to two-sentence responses, trying to remain as clear and concise as possible.

- When do they feel engaged and enthusiastic, work- or academic-wise?
- When have they overcome a difficult challenge successfully?
- When have they achieved peak performance?
 - What were they doing at the time?
 - What were the principles they followed?
 - What did they reach that goal?
 - Did they feel personally satisfied with that accomplishment?
- Bearing in mind the challenges they face now (and possibly in the future), how can they build on what they know works?

When these types become aware of what works for them, it makes the decision of choosing work or college somewhat easier. And the information gathered through this assessment applies throughout the lives of Mediators, if they’re creative in how they apply it.

Mediators in College

After their more limited high school experiences, Mediators may find they're finally home when they enter the hallowed halls of higher education. College can certainly cater to their artistic tendencies. There may be more opportunities to exercise their powerful imaginations, and to approach some topics from the "What if?" perspective that all Diplomats cherish. The shift from high school to college ratchets up Mediators' excitement for learning.

In the college setting, where they'll likely find approval for their intellectual curiosity, these types can spread their Intuitive wings. Mediators are allowed, perhaps even encouraged, to explore the ideas that the high school curricula couldn't accommodate. Communication often becomes central to what these students do in college. They often write impassioned pieces about subjects they feel are important, in the process learning the value of critical thinking and purposeful writing. These types can grow into impressive writers or even orators, often with a poetic flair.

Balanced Approach to College

Selecting the Right Courses

Mediators tend to discover that most college courses are pleasantly challenging. These types have the passion to do well in any niche they choose, though they're likely to engage more in courses with a humanistic bent, which allows them to feel genuinely connected to the subject they're learning. Mediators need to know that their work speaks, either to them or for them; anything less leaves them unsatisfied. Since there's much more latitude in college, students can more readily select courses that speak to them. As in high school, those that fit this bill are likely to be courses

they can connect with personally, rather than those simply needed for future financial success.

When a human element is involved, it changes everything about a course. Medicine can draw Mediators if they possess a vision of the subject that exceeds labs and medical codes. These types might well anticipate a practice with a holistic approach that includes spiritual and cultural considerations, and that's enough to help them trudge through the weeds of science to prepare for a psychiatric or clinical practice. When the reasons *why* are compelling enough, Mediators may tolerate any number of specific *hows* or *whats* presented in the classroom, even against their typical inclinations.

The Right Motivation

Those who take a balanced approach find subjects that resonate within themselves and then find a way to make that passion a reality, whatever challenges may be present. They search through several fields, learning from each until they've settled on one that feels right.

Mediators go to college to explore ways to gain more insight and help others become better people in a holistic sense. Of course, these types understand they must make a living to survive. In consideration of their financial needs, they may try to find ways to combine making a living with that which benefits society. However, the allure of courses that foster their growth in some other way than just as a commodity or a cog in the economic machine is always there.

Unbalanced Approach to College

No Room for Imagination

In every college career, there are unappealing but necessary courses, often under the larger umbrella of obligation that is “prerequisite courses.” Statistics courses may not appeal to Mediators interested in psychology, for example, yet they’re a required and necessary tool in the discipline. As it was in high school, Mediators may respond in such courses by exerting minimal effort. This is never a comfortable way for these types to operate: They may complete the courses, even successfully, but with the recognition they’ve just gone through the motions. This can feel like a waste of their time, and even a bit phony.

It’s also conceivable that Mediators inspired by the new-found freedom of higher academia may not bother to put in minimal effort in courses that don’t fulfill their expectations. They may instead pursue things that resonate more fully with them and simply neglect the rest. They may feel they’re being authentic – and their GPA may authentically drop to match.

By disregarding the fundamentals, these types undermine their foundation. In our example, statistics is a requirement for psychology majors because statistical literacy is essential for applying that psychology effectively. A half-hearted effort limits Mediators’ ability to pursue their interests meaningfully, leading to dissatisfaction that can extend far beyond the college years.

Missing the Flow

Along the same lines, there may be times when Mediators’ Intuition cobbles together ideas that aren’t easy to explain and aren’t constructed in a simple linear fashion.

While other students are walking through the steps to a conclusion, these types may find it annoying to wait for an answer by adhering to a more organized, critical process. They may think they've connected the dots, not realizing how many dots they've missed. This rush to provide answers can hold Mediators back when processes become complex enough that instinct alone isn't enough. This can lead to frustration and perhaps withdrawal from the system – and a consequent abandonment of achievement in this aspect of their lives, further leading to that ever-present potential of an unfulfilling life.

Beyond that, there's a certain tyranny in needing the last word, even in an individual's own mind. Mediators are open-minded. However, once they've decided something is true, when something falls outside the realm of this truth they can become stubborn. It's not that they're "hard-headed" as much as they believe they're honoring the truth: They're likely to simply let alternative facts wash over them without consideration at all, their Intuitive trait rejecting a reality check.

Not all professors are open to students questioning their material. Also, fellow students may say things that sound too conventional to Mediators. These types understand that their unique perspective can have them needlessly challenging standard academic material. However, when it comes to the truth as they see it, those who take an unbalanced approach may feel they need to push forward and stand their ground – oddly, by withdrawing from the situation, especially mentally and emotionally, into their own safe world.

Conflicts arise when Mediators see a need to both create harmony and to maintain their sense of authenticity. Suppose they're asked to write an exam essay reflecting the thoughts of a professor with whom they don't agree. What happens when their professors or classmates insist they accept or write something they don't believe is

true? The decision to stand their ground for the “truth” or simply play along can cause lots of anxiety within these students. It can feel like a no-win scenario.

Rebalancing Their Approach to College

Prerequisites as Self-Help

As in high school, Mediators may need to approach duller courses as workouts in self-discipline. Reframing these courses from meaningless inconveniences into a training regime may help students find value in them. Life imposes necessary but boring things on everyone. Detail and memorization that a more strictly defined course requires, with the right attitude, can help them become better at tolerating and dealing with the mundane.

Many worthwhile things may happen if Mediators adjust their attitude. Firstly, they may gain discipline that provides much-needed balance to their more free-form way of thinking. They may learn the value of being stricter with themselves when it comes to life’s more insistent details. Secondly, they can view the time spent in such classes as valuable, rather than a useless and artificial waste of time.

To change their perception of unappealing classes, Mediators can try these tips:

- Review the syllabus carefully to get a clear feel of the course. Sometimes refreshing expectations puts Mediators back on the same page as others.
- Alongside the main course objectives and deadlines, Mediators can create small, fun tasks for themselves that align with the course: Studying European History? Read a Wikipedia article or two (our suggestion? Start with Boudica, the Celtic warrior queen) and follow links wherever the interest leads.

- Divide large projects and assigned readings out to manage an undesirable workload. Knowing the assigned readings, and reading, say, five difficult pages a night over three weeks, instead of 100 difficult pages over a three-day slog, can make something tedious into something halfway enjoyable.
- Allow time to explore the course in whichever way is preferred. Some units and lessons don't appeal in any way, while others captivate – this is natural. Mediators need to follow their interests, and can do so here.

By following these tips, Mediators can find that learning is a joyful and authentic experience that allows their natural curiosity to run free while also completing all course requirements.

Humbly Genuine

When these types need to reproduce ideas they don't agree with in papers and on exams, it can be trying for them. Mediators can become stuck in their need to be true to themselves, which might prove impractical, as they are after all college students learning the truths of the world around them.

A possible solution is to consider the rules of improvisation. Those comedians and actors who practice improv are trained to say, "Yes, and..." to everything. They accept a premise and find a creative way to add to it, even if the premise they're accepting is ridiculous. To avoid conflicts while maintaining integrity, Mediators may want to start thinking of the classroom as an improv club, and every moment they're called on to speak as a chance to explore a new possibility.

By practicing this, these students can decide ahead of time to accept the standard thesis of a lecture as the recognized premise for the class. They can accept that an instructor who has dedicated considerable time and effort to their subject is now

trying to impart new knowledge to them, an act that's inherently commendable. Mediators now accepting the standard can add any of their flourishes whenever opportunities arise.

They can apply this concept with the following steps:

- Consider a subject that doesn't perfectly align with accepted beliefs.
- Consider the subject as it is to find inspiration in it.
 - Subject: Trigonometry
 - What has mathematics meant for humanity?
 - It leads to medicine and the creation of enough food. It was integral to the Enlightenment era's unprecedented growth of human potential and well-being from illiteracy and starvation.
 - Math is a metaphor for this human growth.

Using this approach, Mediators can both enjoy the idea that they're being true to their understanding of something while maintaining harmony with others.

Lifelong Learning

Lifelong learning goes beyond the rigors of school, though a return to academia is certainly an option. Older Mediators who have embraced themselves fully are better able to give the benefit of the doubt to areas of study or schools of thought that might have struck them as irrelevant – or worse – in their younger years.

Balanced Lifelong Learning

Tempered Idealism

If personality types had superlatives, then Mediators would be awarded “Most Idealistic.” Their idealism persists throughout their entire academic career and colors what they want to learn, how they learn it, and how long it takes them to master the subjects that interest them. They’re easily excited by the prospect of learning something new, but when they discover how much time and effort is required once they’re further along in the process, they’ll often feel disappointed. Mediators with a more balanced approach reign in their idealism every so often, and learn to ruminate less and implement more.

Consider learning Japanese, for example. It may begin with an interest in a cultural aspect of the people who speak that language – having an online friend from a Japan, for instance – which then inspires them to take that next step. The balanced approach is see the language-learning process as personally meaningful, and therefore worthy of practicing more and more, perhaps with a goal of one day visiting Japan. Mediators draw on so many facets of an experience for lifelong learning – their sense of adventure, their inspirations, their culture, their drive for growth, and their curiosity – all while staying true to their own strengths.

Work and Play

Mediators have difficulty enjoying learning when the subject at hand is, as they see it, boring. And “boring” by their standards usually means “highly technical,” and otherwise lacking their favored humanistic traits. While they may feel inclined to completely abandon these subjects, most Mediators ought to consider their value, and how learning about them can enrich their lives in the long run.

One of these values, for example, can be developing focus for work. It seems easy enough for most people, but Mediators typically have a particularly rough time concentrating on things that aren't personal priorities. They can learn to focus with time and effort, and then they'll find that homing in on even undesirable tasks is easy – the trick is getting there in the first place.

Unbalanced Lifelong Learning

Only Idealism

The world constantly enamors these softhearted spirits – sun filtering through the trees, a lazy bumblebee crossing their path, snow falling around them – and this enthusiasm translates to their learning as well. The innumerable possibilities swirling in their heads makes them excited to learn about anything and everything. However, while idealism is perhaps their best trait, it can also, ironically, limit them the most.

One can look to Mediators' initial excitement over learning a new subject. They feel the inspiration, then overthink it and talk themselves out of it before they even try. Barriers to concrete action affect these types disproportionately.

This is more about the sheer scale of any given interest making it so that they have no starting point. Mediators are masters of *correlation* – they see that everything fits together – but are terrible at *causation* – understanding where things start and end. Taking such a clear starting action is uncharacteristic, even if the lack of follow-through is.

Indulgent Learning

Learning is something that's innately valuable and should feel joyous. Mediators should indulge in learning what brings them joy, and recognize that learning itself is

an expression of joy. However, just as the saying goes, there can be “too much of a good thing.”

When interest in a subject is absent, Mediators may feel incapable of sitting through it. They might justify not taking the time to learn, and instead focus only on the topics that interest them. This complete investment in interests, especially if they don't coincide with skills necessary for life, can be detrimental.

Focusing only on what they want, rather than what they need, can lead to huge knowledge deficits that later reveal themselves in their professional development: If they never learn the technical basics of writing, for instance, they'll struggle in their writing careers despite their inherent talent.

Rebalancing Lifelong Learning

Research and Idealism

While research isn't Mediators' forte, it's sure to save them a lot of grief (and money) in the long run. These types, though Introverted, can also be more impulsive and indulgent with their learning, and prefer ideation over implementation. Being aware of this trait, students with a balanced approach to learning temper their idealism with research to preserve their most precious resource – time.

They can use their Prospecting trait to lead them to topics they find engaging and interesting, but before they invest themselves wholeheartedly into these subjects, they can first do in-depth research to unmake their bad habit of readily committing with little context.

Here's an exercise that mixes their research and idealism, and can give them a realistic peek at adding a potential new course to their schedule:

- Consider the options:
 - Location and time of the course: Can they make it on time? Do they face any conflicts significant scheduling conflicts?
 - Instructor: Are they well-regarded? Strict, lax? Look up online ratings, and ask peers.
 - Price: Can they afford the extra cost? Are there community-driven alternatives to community college or university courses?
 - Make sure it fits the schedule. Ask, “Am I overcommitting myself by adding this to my daily schedule? Do I have enough time and resources to wholeheartedly engage in the course?”
- Look for outside opinions:
 - Look up course and instructor reviews on the Internet.
 - Ask friends if they’ve studied the same subject, and how it suited them.
 - Contact the instructor of the course. Many instructors hold open office hours, and a conversation can reveal whether the course is a good fit.

The information gathered can help Mediators decide whether the new course fits into their schedule. Exhaustive consideration prevents these types from committing long-term to an incompatible interest.

A Creative Plan

Sitting down and analyzing the basics can be difficult for all Intuitive types, but even more so for Mediators, who are notorious daydreamers. Their wonderful minds conjure up grand stories, but once their dreams are over, they may be left with a huge gap between where they are and what they imagined. They may begin with Step “A,” and their Intuitive minds skip over “B,” “C,” “D,” and all the way to “Z” – at which point they may have no idea where to start. But some students have learned to erase

this confusion by going back and building a well-researched timeline that begins with learning the fundamentals of the subject they want to pursue.

Planning can add some structure to Mediators' often vague, lifelong goals. By developing a loose plan that incorporates their values and desires, they can saunter forward with confidence rather than confusion. The following exercise can help clarify things:

- Take the time to visualize what brings happiness – not what society says brings happiness, but what your own experience tells you.
- What is a goal that can be achieved a week from now?
 - Remember to start small – when planning for the future, even tiny changes can add up to big commitments.
- What are the benefits of achieving this goal?
- List out ten steps to take to achieve this goal.

Mediators should take their time to write out their ideal vision statement, and tailor it their lifelong learning desires. It's easy to begin! Start the exercise in the morning, and look at the results at the end of the day. This is an easy exercise to repeat, and growing Mediators often find themselves surprised at the changes they see from day to day.

Conclusion

Life is Learning

For Mediators, education is a way to move closer to the world and people around them. But it can be so much more for those willing to take a chance. The challenge for these types isn't so much in the hard work of learning – the challenge is managing

their imaginations and finding a reasonable footing so that education is rewarding experience. For Mediators, balancing their passion and soft hearts with practical and realistic expectations is quite achievable, and even more satisfying.

They can achieve this balance by taking time for setting plausible expectations for themselves, taking time to find meaning and merit in the mundane, understanding that an A+ doesn't equate to self-worth, and allowing themselves room to be wrong, as well as celebrating their accomplishments and failures in equal turn.

In the end, it's important to note that balance and imbalance are states, and neither state lasts forever. All of us, as a collective, go back and forth. Like the seasons, balance comes and goes. The trees grow taller and stronger, and people grow smarter and wiser, all of us advancing in our way. As we make progress, we come to knowing those seasons.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your academic path? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

Thirst for Knowledge Test

What is your interest in gaining knowledge? How does your desire for learning affect your life? This tool will help you explore that.

Academic Exploration Test

Do you ever wonder what areas of study might suit your personality? Find out which subjects might be the most satisfying for you.

Perfectionism Test

Perfectionism is a desire to be remarkable and outstanding in everything you do. Let's see what role it plays in your life.

Type Guesser (Academic)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your classmate belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

Career and Professional Development



Rare, complex, and enigmatic, Mediators seek careers that are more than just jobs. Whatever their profession, they need a role that enables them to support worthy causes and exercise creative freedom. This combination motivates them to make great contributions and do their best work.

Throughout this section, we'll discuss how Mediators can maintain balance, excel in their professional development, identify the factors that may frustrate that development, and learn how they can utilize their strengths to regain their balance and thrive in their careers. Ultimately, we hope this guide offers the understanding and tools to help Mediators find professional fulfillment.

Putting Idealism to Work

Some people strive for materialistic or egoistic goals – a salary, title, number of subordinates, or impressive degree. Mediators, however, want to do something meaningful and help others. To put this idealism to work, they must find roles that suit them.

Mediators often find the greatest happiness when they dare to explore their interests rather than settle for a typical path. Although doing so may require trial and error – and, at times, great effort – the journey is certainly worthwhile. Following their instincts while still challenging themselves to do their best work can help Mediators grow both professionally and personally.

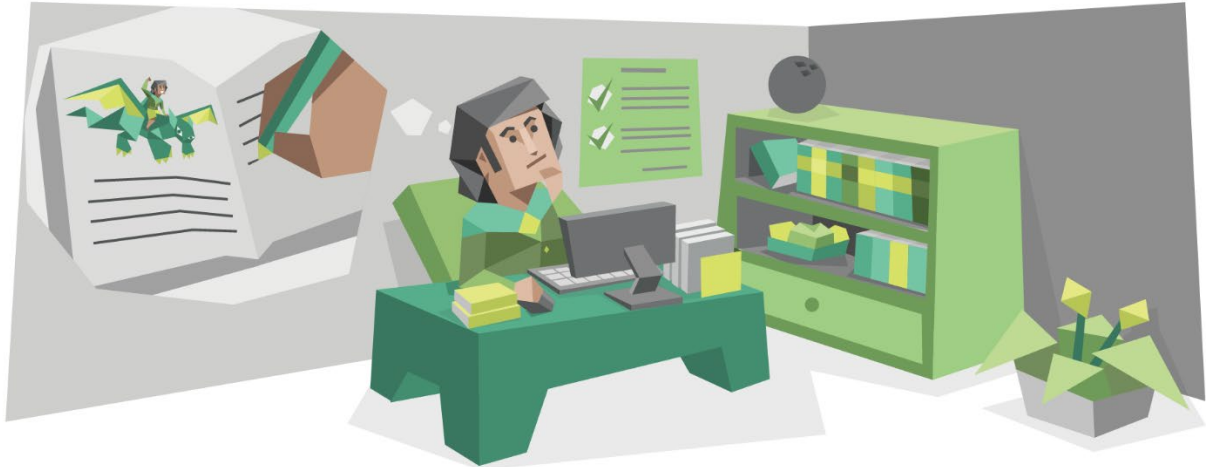
Restless Hearts

Mediators like to feel that their actions have purpose, and they aim to foster harmony, understanding, and connection. Unfortunately, those qualities aren't often the currency of the world of business. Common career paths may not fulfill Mediators, leaving them feeling isolated, restless, or unsatisfied.

Although they're capable of great dedication when inspired, Mediators usually dislike routine tasks, strictly impersonal work, and analysis of minor details, so they may not thrive in careers that focus on data rather than people. To be happy, people with this personality type usually need creative roles. But, with inspiration, even the most data-driven or technical field can be pursued as an art, whether coding a video game or riveting an airplane.

Despite their longing for human connection, their Introversion means that they can be exhausted by prolonged contact with others. People with this personality type need to be on their own occasionally; if that doesn't happen at work, stress can build. Some jobs, such as most sales and customer service positions, require that employees be "on" throughout their shifts. These jobs can be exhausting – though potentially still fulfilling – for Mediators.

Suitable Careers for Mediators



Professional development takes place across all stages of life, from early education through retirement, and it's interwoven with personal development as well. Gaining increased self-understanding – by determining values, goals, strengths, and weaknesses – is essential. In this section we'll help Mediators gain a deeper understanding of the role personality type plays in choosing a suitable career.

What follows isn't a firm prescription as to what Mediators must do to be successful or happy. Rather, we hope it provides some decision-making insight. Perhaps the most important question for Mediators to ask when searching for a career isn't, "What do I want to be?" but, rather, "Who do I want to be?"

Creative Arts

It can be difficult to turn artistic talent into a paycheck. Fortunately, Mediators who pursue creative careers needn't be starving artists. As freelancers or employees within a larger corporate structure, such as a staff writer at a magazine or a commercial artist at a brand-strategy firm, they can earn a solid and sustainable

living. Almost any subject imaginable has an accompanying publication, and a knowledgeable Mediator might be the best candidate for their creative direction.

The world isn't always as non-hierarchical as Mediators would like, and they may find that specific training or education facilitates their entry into artistic fields. For careers such as architecture, the right credentials and degrees can open doors, allowing Mediators to conceive and execute truly grand, creative masterpieces. Similarly, formal training in programming may help Mediators find work in web design, video game design, or even certain types of multimedia production.

If Mediators struggle to balance financial demands with their creative impulses, they have the option of pursuing their passions as side projects. Thanks to technology, reaching a wider audience no longer requires a full-time career in the arts: In their free time, Mediators can experiment with self-publishing their fiction, sharing their films on streaming video services, selling crafts through social media markets...the possibilities grow with each passing year.

Of course, in-person connections also help. To maintain their motivation, Mediators may benefit from connecting with other artists in their communities, sharing time and inspiration with them. Taking classes is a great way to find other people who care about making art.

Here are a few careers particularly well-suited to the Mediator personality type:

- Artist: fine arts, commercial art, graphic design, photography, illustration, sculpture
- Musician: songwriter, composer, producer, performer
- Crafts: fiber arts, pattern designer, woodworking
- Architect

- Writer: novelist, editor, essayist, copywriter

Health Care

Positions in health and wellness leverage Mediators' empathy, giving them a sense of purpose and enabling them to make a difference. Whether they specialize in mental or physical health, Mediators can help others gain insight into their behaviors, achieve self-discovery, and improve their well-being. An ideal position also allows Mediators to exercise their creativity to help their clients feel better. Certain healthcare jobs also suit Mediators' Introverted natures, such as those that allow them to serve patients individually, with time between clients to reflect on the experience.

Healthcare positions that may suit Mediators include:

- Medicine: physician, nurse or nurse practitioner, school nurse, physician's assistant, midwife or doula, physical therapist, dentist or dental assistant, optometrist, paramedic, dietician, health coach, massage therapist, veterinarian or veterinary assistant
- Counseling: therapist, addiction counselor, marriage counselor, psychiatrist (with emphasis on psychotherapy), psychologist, child or developmental psychologist, school psychologist, licensed clinical social worker
- Alternative health: practitioner of acupuncture, traditional Chinese medicine, Ayurveda, sound healing, Reiki, the Alexander Technique, the Feldenkrais Method, Emotional Freedom Technique, etc.; herbalist; yoga or meditation teacher; breath-work teacher

Education

Mediators are well suited to teaching and working with students. They connect with younger students through imagination, intuition, and empathy. With older students, they present topics with passion and creativity, especially when teaching the humanities.

Regardless of whom they teach, Mediators treat their students as individuals with specific traits and needs. They look beyond test scores and conventional metrics of success, glimpsing the unique potential of each student. Although Mediators may find constant contact with students and colleagues throughout the day taxing, they nevertheless enjoy the sense that they're changing lives for the better.

In addition to roles as teachers or professors, Mediators might consider other education-related careers such as guidance counselor, school nurse, school psychologist, or even sports coach. Depending on their personal religious beliefs, Mediators also make excellent religious instructors and leaders, sharing their compassion and love for humanity within their belief system.

Some educational roles that may fit Mediators' skills and preferences:

- Preschool, elementary, or high school teacher
- College lecturer (especially in religion, philosophy, or literature)
- Adult-education teacher
- Guidance counselor
- Sports coach
- Religious educator

Public Service and Social Work

Thanks to their ethical standards and caring natures, many Mediators are drawn to public service and social work. Despite their acute sensitivity, their desire to serve others gives them the strength to face tragic and painful situations. They can support, comfort, and advocate for those in need through a variety of roles. Any administrative tedium can be balanced by Mediators' love of directly talking to, comforting, and helping people in need.

Of course, public service isn't limited to office jobs. Some Mediators feel called to do environmental work, such as nature conservation and restoration, or positions within the public, state, or federal parks system. Such roles offer opportunities for outdoor solitude as well as personal contribution – a combination that appeals to many Mediators.

Specific public service jobs Mediators might enjoy include:

- Social worker: specializations include community, health care, family, or military
- Non-profit employee or director
- Librarian
- Community organizer
- Outdoors: conservationist, park ranger, environmental researcher, landscape architect, forester, wildlife researcher, marine biologist, geoscientist, oceanographer

Service Industry

For Mediators, making a difference in someone's life – or even just their day – is deeply gratifying. Provided they find environments that allow meaningful interactions with customers, Mediators can thrive in retail or service businesses. By offering personalized recommendations and truly listening to customers, people with this personality type can cultivate a loyal, appreciative clientele.

Beyond the constant opportunities to help people, lower-pressure service jobs can offer the flexibility to continue their education or pursue personal goals in their free time. Such roles can even prepare entrepreneurial Mediators to open their own independent businesses. For those who enjoy it, the service industry can be a long-term career fit. From luxury hotels to fine restaurants, some high-end businesses offer surprisingly generous compensation to experienced employees, particularly in cities and travel hubs.

That said, it's important for Mediators to find employers whose missions and cultures resonate with them. People with this personality type require jobs that align with their values and allow them to be their authentic selves.

Some positions in the service industry that may be a good fit:

- Food service: restaurant host, server, or manager; barista; bartender; sommelier
- Hospitality: hotel employee or manager, bed-and-breakfast owner, vacation rental host
- Retail store associate or manager
- Tour guide

Career Alternatives

We live in an age of possibilities, and selling one's time to a corporation isn't the only way to earn money. Mediators are imaginative individuals, and their ability to make connections between seemingly unrelated things and ideas can be very valuable beyond the realm of conventional employment.

Self-Employment

Many people find the notion of self-employment quite scary, but the working world has changed radically, and job security is less of a guarantee, even with stable, large employers. On the plus side, self-employment comes with a range of benefits, such as the ability to plan one's time, direct oneself, and see the tangible results of work done. Mediators enjoy independence and creative latitude, and being self-employed provides both – whether as freelance writers, graphic designers, tutors, coaches, consultants, or something else entirely.

Unfortunately, starting a business without a solid plan can lead to frustration, heartache, and an empty wallet. Mediators have a strong aversion to the pressures of salesmanship, but finding a worthwhile cause and turning it into an ethical business idea can be incredibly rewarding, both financially and morally – enough to justify a little risk and stress. The keys to success include good ideas that speak to others and strong relationships with vendors and clients. Mediators' human insight and vibrant imaginations serve them well in these areas.

If considering the path of self-employment, Mediators must be willing to experiment, work hard, and fail along the way. Success is far from guaranteed, and at times the demands of going solo may stretch them beyond their comfort zones. Fortunately,

self-employment grants Mediators the independence to follow their passions, and their natural charisma reflects well on whatever service or product they offer.

Professional Volunteerism

Those who devote themselves entirely to pursuing matters of conscience and progress can move mountains. Although unlikely to lead to financial prosperity, the path of volunteerism can offer unparalleled personal satisfaction and growth. Early on, such efforts may have to be supported by minor income from other endeavors, but Mediators may also transition into volunteerism later in life, offering wisdom and vigor as well as skill sets from previous occupations.

Regardless of their background, experienced and educated Mediators can find ways to apply their abilities and knowledge to worthy causes, especially if they're willing to travel. From welders and carpenters to teachers and doctors, any skill set can be useful in the right environment. Mediators can establish small volunteer groups or even act individually. For example, almost anyone with warmth, patience, and a high school education can contribute by tutoring children in reading and math, and doing so can make an incredible difference in the youngsters' futures.

By following the path of volunteerism, Mediators can satisfy their desire to create harmony and healing in the world. They can dip their toe in while keeping a day job, or plunge into the deep end and devote their time entirely to helping others.

Workplace Roles

Many Mediators enjoy working without any sort of hierarchy or leadership structure, at a level neither above nor below anyone else. Directly interacting with the people and ideas that are relevant to what they're trying to accomplish is the dream for these

types. That said, Mediators do sometimes need to step into leadership roles or positions of authority to transform their visions into reality – and for these types, that transition to leadership can represent a monumental challenge. Fortunately, Mediators are creative and inspired people: Under the right conditions, most any position can work.

Mediators as Subordinates

Balanced Subordinate Behavior

Infectious Positivity

Managers who recognize excellence and correct errors gently can expect strong commitment and cheerfulness from Mediator employees. If Mediators believe in their work, they throw their hearts into it. Praise from managers and coworkers reinforces their enthusiasm and delight, cementing their natural positivity into lasting loyalty.

When they feel appreciated, Mediators find additional ways to be helpful around the workplace, whether by chipping in on an additional project or by developing a plan to tackle a longstanding problem. In validating environments, they're more likely to speak up in group settings and offer their insights. Even better, their positive energy is infectious, brightening the workday for their peers – and often their managers as well.

Helpful Accountability

Mediators can most easily leverage their strengths when given sufficient time and space. They don't like time crunches or tight deadlines, preferring instead to consider

and review their work. Many Mediators have a perfectionist streak; given the opportunity, they take as much time as possible to assess and revise their ideas and efforts before inviting outside scrutiny – a trait that garners them a reputation for being insightful and reflective.

However, some jobs – particularly subordinate roles – don’t offer this latitude, which means that self-aware Mediators must find strategies to work efficiently. Although it goes against their independent natures, they may need outside support to avoid procrastination and stick to deadlines. They might create accountability by asking a manager or a colleague for regular check-ins, allowing them to track their progress – or lack thereof – rather than ignore it. Counter to their own intuitions, Mediators often find that strict deadlines help them by forcing them to break their habit of passive idealism and perfectionism. Over time, people with this personality type can ease into doing work that’s “good enough,” rather than holding out for perfection.

Unbalanced Subordinate Behavior

Hypersensitive to Criticism

Although they want to grow, Mediators are highly sensitive to conflict and criticism. Often suffering from fragile confidence, they’re vulnerable to becoming hurt and confused when people disagree with them, dislike them, or are unkind. In the workplace, even minor corrections or negative feedback – from coworkers, clients, and especially managers – can take the wind right out of their sails.

When conflict or criticism is aimed at them personally, they lose their objective negotiating skills. They’re at risk for becoming social loners if they don’t find kindred spirits, or at least respectful peers, in the workplace. Emotionally marginalized

Mediators may withdraw like hermits, viewing the outside world and other people with anything ranging from wavering wistfulness to reserved resentment.

To cope with workplace critics, these types may find themselves acting in a host of unproductive ways. They might amplify the self-critical voice in their heads, aiming to anticipate every possible rebuke that might be launched their way – a surefire recipe for perfectionism, procrastination, burnout, or worse. Or they might shut down, shying away from new challenges and avoiding people who've criticized them in the past. Unfortunately, such reactions prevent Mediators from distinguishing between helpful and unhelpful feedback, adjusting their course accordingly, and making their full impact in the world.

Disillusionment

Principled and idealistic, Mediators need to feel good about the culture of their work environment. To them, the moral and emotional foundation of any pursuit matters more than quantitative returns. When managers prioritize profits and pecking orders while disregarding morale and fairness, then Mediators can turn from whistling workers into disgruntled detractors.

Ideally, they can transform this disillusionment into positive action, either by advocating for reform or by seeking a better work environment, but if they allow themselves to feel helpless, their disappointment with management simply saps their motivation. Mediators can numb out by dragging their heels on tasks, withdrawing from people or projects they disagree with, or wasting precious energy bemoaning the situation rather than working to change it. This dynamic is doubly destructive, as it not only prevents Mediators from doing their best work, but also damages their sense of personal integrity.

Rebalancing Subordinate Behavior

Reassessing Praise and Criticism

Many Mediators are tempted to avoid criticism and pursue praise. This can lead to imbalances in their skill sets, robbing them of opportunities to bolster their weaknesses, benefit from constructive feedback, and understand their true goals for their work, independent of other people's opinions. All too often, this approach prevents them from tackling the grand challenges that result in lasting change.

To escape this trap, Mediators must learn to balance their inner wisdom with feedback from managers, colleagues, and clients. They can do this by reminding themselves that other people's opinions provide valuable information – about the *opinion-giver*, not only the person being judged. If a manager criticizes them for writing long emails, that may simply mean that the manager prefers concise communications. A different manager might appreciate the thought and nuance that go into longer messages.

On the flipside, if they're praised for making a big sale, that doesn't necessarily mean they should work as a salesperson. The key is for Mediators to *respond* rather than react to feedback, by reflecting on its motivation, value, and potential helpfulness before absorbing or deflecting it.

Here are some ways Mediator can adjust their reception to feedback:

- Rather than accepting managers' opinions as fact (or dismissing them out of hand), insert them into the following formula: "My managers believe [insert opinion]. This teaches me that they would prefer [insert corollary preference]."

- Example: My managers believe that decisions should be made based on statistics rather than emotions. This teaches me that they would prefer that I ground my suggestions in data.
- Decide whether to honor the corollary preference: in the example above, this can be done by bolstering all suggestions with data going forward.
- If the managers' preferences or opinions seem out of line, approach the situation as if a miscommunication has occurred. Broach the matter directly with managers. It may not be easy, but an honest discussion clears the air and eliminate any false assumptions. (Mediators' diplomatic skills serve them well in such sensitive conversations.)
- When faced with constructive feedback, look for ways to grow – and develop a plan to pursue them.

By steering themselves away from assumptions and remember not to take criticism as a personal attack, Mediators can choose *how* to respond to feedback, rather than reacting on instinct. Integrating helpful critiques and leaving the rest behind equips these types to steer by their internal compass.

Quashing Helplessness

When managers violate their principles, Mediators lose motivation. They might isolate themselves from colleagues or perform their tasks halfheartedly, no longer bringing their typical creativity and optimism to their work. Over time, this can lead to underperformance, which is likely to erode Mediators' self-esteem and sense of purpose.

The culprit in this situation is helplessness – an emotion that clashes with Mediators' hopeful, idealistic spirit. To cope, they can brainstorm concrete ways to improve their

work environment, and then follow through with action. Steps can be large or small, from bringing in baked goods or leaving nice hand soap in the bathroom to chatting with coworkers who are struggling.

Mediator subordinates can also stand up for their principles in ways that are available to them. The following ideas can empower Mediators to do this:

- Before suggesting changes, consider what changes are desired and why. When presenting any change in policy or idea for improvement, take stock of existing resources. Knowing what policies already exist can further emphasize the benefit of new ideas.
- Note the reasoning, including the pros and, when they're obvious, cons of the plan. Even a plan with drawbacks yield overall improvement – and sometimes more feedback can eliminate or minimize flaws.
- Approach a respected colleague for feedback. A second perspective can spot hidden flaws in the plan, as well as opportunities.
- Practice presenting the ideas before meeting with a manager. Schedule enough time to ensure the entire idea can be presented, as well as any questions answered.
- Offer to take responsibility for implementing the idea. Trust the vision enough to make it a reality.

Even without managerial authority, Mediators can be beacons in their workplaces, ushering positive change and brightening their own experiences as well as those of their colleagues.

Mediators as Colleagues

Balanced Colleague Behavior

Goodwill and Empathy

Mediators' empathy and sensitivity can be a balm to coworkers. Always offering gentle support, friendship, and a helpful attitude, they add warmth and human understanding to nearly every aspect of their workday, setting up themselves and everyone around them for success. Regardless of where they fall on the career ladder, they model kindness and consideration, inspiring others with their sincere efforts.

Their goodwill is more than a morale booster – it can increase productivity. Although they do well independently, Mediators are wonderful team players, thinking less about their own acclaim than about how they can elevate and energize the team. When they allow themselves to fully develop this quality, they can increase a team's productivity by encouraging harmonious cooperation, staving off conflict, and fostering true team spirit.

Unbalanced Colleague Behavior

Naïveté

Mediators' positivity charms many people, breathing fresh life into stale workplaces. That said, this trait may cause blunt or cynical coworkers to judge them as naïve. Hard-edged colleagues often roll their eyes at Mediators' tendency to assume that every problem is solvable and that everyone is well intentioned.

When faced with workplace conflict, Mediators may put their trademark positivity into overdrive, refusing to take sides or even acknowledge tension. Such situations make people with this personality type deeply uncomfortable, and their desire to remain friendly with everyone may alienate them from frank, straight-shooting colleagues. As a result, Mediators may end up accidentally at odds with people they haven't wronged, simply by refusing to speak up about a situation.

No Solitary Time

Despite their need for solitary time, people with this personality type may struggle to withdraw to be on their own. This phenomenon becomes particularly pronounced if coworkers or clients keep requesting their help, which is common because many Mediators struggle to establish boundaries around their time and space when they feel people need them. This consideration for others may seem beneficial, but in the long run, it sticks Mediators in "survival mode."

Solitude is essential for these types to refill the fonts of energy and empathy that fuel them to be such powerful agents of positive change. When they force themselves to be in constant contact with others, Mediators' morale suffers, leading them to exhibit uncharacteristic negativity, which can dampen their colleagues' spirits as well. Unless they manage to carve out pockets of alone time, Mediators won't do their best work. Quiet reflection typically enables them to generate their best ideas; without it, they can feel uninspired, unmotivated, or simply down.

Rebalancing Colleague Behavior

Facing Conflict

Although Mediators might wish for drama-free lives, the reality is that all workplaces break into conflict occasionally. When this happens, they may struggle to identify the source of the tension, leading them to “take everyone’s side.” However, in some situations, they must face conflicts head on and take sides.

When faced with workplace drama, the first question Mediators must ask themselves is: “Is this any of my business?” If the situation involves one of their own projects, a close colleague, or a clear ethical infraction, then they probably need to get involved – whether by helping to remedy the situation or by weighing in with their professional opinions.

If the situation doesn’t involve their work or their close colleagues, Mediators may do well to curtail their instinct to help – otherwise, they may be viewed as meddling, particularly if they don’t have the authority to put their natural diplomacy and people skills to full use. Here are some ways Mediators can refrain from involving themselves unnecessarily:

- When workplace conflict arises, pause to reflect: “Would the situation benefit from my involvement?”
- If the answer is yes, consider your response. If someone pushes for a snap judgment in a non-emergency, then reply, “I need time to find out what’s going on first.”
- If the answer is no, don’t step into the conflict unless asked. However well intended, such efforts can backfire.

- Speak to a trusted colleague and ask what's going on, especially about the origin of the tension. Nebulous, unbounded conflict can trigger catastrophizing among Mediators, so gaining a clear awareness of the situation may help mitigate stress.
- Manage your own resulting stress, if necessary: Take deep, slow breaths; listen to a guided meditation, such as progressive muscle relaxation or *yoga nidra*; or set aside some alone time.

Rather than rush to involve themselves, Mediators can evaluate conflicts and then decide how to respond. By doing so, they maximize their chances of making a positive impact – whether that means helping to resolve an argument or simply keeping their heads down to focus on their own projects.

Creating Alone Time

Without pockets of alone time, Mediators tend to burn out. As much as they might enjoy helping and listening to others, they need to retreat from time to time to restore their energy, inspiration, and sense of capability. Otherwise, their satisfaction with their jobs – and themselves – gradually wanes, as does their confidence that they can make a difference.

For the many workers who lack private offices, taking alone time poses a challenge. Fortunately, Mediators excel at finding creative solutions. Those in sales or retail might approach their managers with requests to take on solo tasks, step out for solitary lunches, or start their workdays before others arrive. From time to time, Mediators in noisy, open-plan offices can put on headphones. This not only tunes out other people's conversations, but also broadcasts that they're trying to focus, minimizing the likelihood of social distractions.

To gracefully withdraw from unmanageable workplace environs, Mediators can employ any of the following:

- Pay attention to your personal tolerance level for sustained social interaction. Some people go for hours without becoming depleted, whereas others can manage less, and certain activities, such as group meetings or watercooler chat, drain more. By knowing how you respond to such situations, you can anticipate when you'll need a break.
- Devise a list of ways to take alone time at work: wearing headphones, walking around the block, eating lunch alone, switching to a task that requires less social interaction, retreating to a bathroom stall for a few minutes, etc.
- Take a few deep breaths while counting down from 10, and relax into the present moment. This can help minimize the stress response, even during prolonged social exposure.
- Take on more independent tasks. Brainstorm a list of tasks in advance and approach your supervisor, and come with a willingness to negotiate so you get what you want. Or, approach colleagues with offers to take on or trade tasks.

Many Mediators adapt creatively to social workplaces by carving out pockets of solo time. As a result, these types can excel in a range of fields, even those that require significant interaction with others. Mediators as Managers

Balanced Manager Behavior

Egalitarian Leaders

Unsurprisingly, Mediators don't impose their will on the people they manage. Instead, their cooperative tendencies lead them to solicit the opinions of their employees, creating an egalitarian and democratic work environment. Unlike

micromanagers, Mediators give the people who work for them plenty of space to innovate and experiment, and they encourage creative thinking over strict adherence to protocols and deadlines.

Because Mediator managers view their employees' potential as more important than their pay grades, their team members' talents are used rather than left to languish. This fosters a non-hierarchical workplace where even junior staff members can make suggestions, exercise their judgment, and receive credit for their contributions. The result is that Mediators – despite their general reluctance to exercise authority – often bring out the best in the people they manage, encouraging them to grow and develop both personally and professionally.

Cultivating Talent

As managers, Mediators are open-minded, respectful, and always willing to offer support. Aiming to act as mentors rather than rule as dictators, they get to know their employees as individuals, learning the strengths and abilities that each person brings to the table. As a result, they excel at cultivating talent, allowing their mentees to grow into capable allies.

Trusting the talent of their employees, Mediator managers often delegate responsibility. They're comfortable sharing their power and discretion with people who have earned their respect and trust. Mediators also encourage the people they manage to put their own spin on projects, valuing their employees' creativity, spontaneity, and unique perspectives above adherence to predetermined standards or procedures.

Unbalanced Manager Behavior

Letting It Slide

Although Mediators have high expectations for themselves, they don't always apply the same expectations to others. People with this personality type are averse to conflict and reluctant to criticize, and they tend to see the best in other people. If left unchecked, these traits can lead them to overlook bad behavior in their employees, prioritizing their relationships with team members above the success of the team.

As a result, Mediators can be too lenient, even when genuine incompetence surfaces – a situation that ultimately damages team morale. It's fine for them to give their employees the benefit of the doubt, but they should try not to ignore poor performance or bad behavior. When they don't uphold standards, Mediators not only diminish their teams' chances of success, but also de-motivate the employees who hold themselves to a higher standard.

Pressure Cooker

Mediators don't often seek out leadership positions, in part because the burden of managerial responsibility weighs heavily on their shoulders. Unfortunately, the pressures of command can get to them, especially in high-profile or particularly visible positions. If they don't keep their inner perfectionism in check, Mediators may overreact to stressful situations, lose their cool in crises, or overthink every decision.

Such tendencies can affect their ability to lead. Because they so desperately want to do things right, Mediator managers may delay important decisions, allowing themselves to get distracted by other priorities. As a result, they may find themselves

either becoming paralyzed by indecision or making impulsive choices – neither of which ultimately benefits their workforce.

When they or their teams don't succeed, Mediator managers may criticize themselves harshly, feeling they've letting others down. Their powerful imagination might envision scenario after scenario of future failures, leaving them reluctant to maintain their managerial responsibilities. In the absence of firm encouragement and guidance from colleagues – which may be difficult to find at the managerial level – the pitfalls of a typical workplace can leave Mediators feeling lost, stressed out, or even depressed.

Rebalancing Manager Behavior

Establishing Expectations

Mediator managers don't have to refashion themselves into tyrants to set expectations for their employees. In fact, their positive natures can work in their favor when it comes to communicating new, higher standards. Although other personality types might use criticism to spur on employees, this strategy can be incredibly discouraging.

The Gallup Leadership Institute has found that teams perform best when their managers think they're capable of great things. Mediators can leverage this phenomenon – known as self-fulfilling prophecy – by communicating the potential they see in each of their employees and praising people for doing things right. They might even encourage their teams to take on “moonshot” projects that bring them to the edge of their abilities in pursuit of grand challenges.

That said, even smaller suggestions can lead to self-fulfilling prophecy. Whether their aim is improved sales or better workplace conduct, Mediator managers can explain themselves in positive terms – for example, “improved productivity” as opposed to “reduced distractions.”

To reinforce positive self-image among their employees, they can also conclude discussions by explaining to their subordinates that they’re fully capable of creating change. Here are some ways they can frame feedback in productive ways:

- Comment on team members’ strengths and talents, highlighting each person’s capacity to grow into their potential.
- Praise employees for their effort and their improvement.
- Suggest “moonshot” projects that encourage employees to push in new directions.
- Use positive language to communicate new expectations.
- Emphasize to employees that they can achieve what is being asked of them.

Positive reinforcement can help Mediator managers encourage their teams to perform to higher standards – without shaming them for past failures or slipups.

Pressure Relief

When faced with crises, impossible deadlines, and past failures, Mediator managers may feel helpless and overwhelmed. No matter how much they doubt their abilities, they’re often more than capable of rising to such challenges. To do so, however, they need to take off some of the pressure they place on themselves. Although they might think their inner critics motivate them to improve themselves, Mediators are more effective leaders and change agents when they embrace a balanced view of their abilities.

To keep perfectionism from undermining their leadership skills, Mediators must set realistic goals, enjoy their successes, and curb procrastination. Although they may want to achieve great things – such as turning around a company’s culture, or providing millions of people with access to clean water – Mediators can become overwhelmed and distracted unless they establish smaller, shorter-term objectives. When they or their teams do achieve their objectives, they should take a moment to acknowledge each success, reminding themselves of their essential capability.

Mediator managers must take note when they lapse into procrastination – whether putting off tasks or postponing decisions. They can enlist a more decisive or proactive colleague to help them move forward rather than stall out. As this tendency to delay action can escalate quickly, consider these tactics:

- Within the scope of larger visions, establish achievable, shorter-term objectives. If you normally think in years, consider goals for the next day or the next week.
- Celebrate progress, no matter how incremental. Whether with a team dinner, an office announcement, a calendar entry, or even a private journal entry, it’s important to counterbalance memories of past failures – which tend to dominate our minds, thanks to a phenomenon known as negativity bias – with awareness of successes and accomplishments.
- Recognize procrastination when it arises. For many Mediators, a dead giveaway is physical uneasiness or a sense of being scattered or dissatisfied. Enlist support, ideally from an action-oriented colleague, to maintain progress.

These actions create a cycle of progress, affirmation, and momentum. Even better: If they mitigate their stress levels by setting realistic goals and enjoying their successes, Mediators can feel less inclined to procrastinate in the first place.

Workplace Cooperation Between Types

Even when they don't share similar backgrounds or experiences, Mediators and coworkers can forge a healthy and productive workplace relationship. The following section explains how Mediators can use their strengths and counterbalance common sources of conflict to build meaningful work relationships with various personality types. As these types well know, conversations that include mutual understanding tend to be much more productive than those that proceed with assumptions or stubborn perspectives.

Mediator-Analyst Cooperation



Balanced Mediator-Analyst Cooperation

Kindred Insights

Both Mediators and Analysts prefer to advance the “big picture” rather than fiddle with mundane details of facilitation. Both absorb knowledge almost subconsciously and then incorporate it into a larger constellation of meaning, often connecting

concepts in deep ways. Their similarity in style and shared love for the abstract give Mediators and Analysts ample opportunities to imaginatively combine their talents.

In the workplace, they excel at working together to generate new ideas, identifying areas that need improvement, and departing from the status quo. Their pattern-recognition skills enable them to investigate the root causes of problems and detect unexpected relationships. Not only would they notice their organization isn't gaining enough publicity, but they might also recognize the origins of the problem in the way their organization presents itself to the outside world. Together, these two types can steer companies in new directions, spotting avenues for growth and improvement that others may miss.

Compatible Differences

Mediators' values and deep empathy can provide necessary balance to Analysts' interest in optimization – and vice versa. Mediators can add to Analysts' perspective by emphasizing emotional elements and offering human insight. As a result, Mediators can infuse “soul” into any system that Analysts devise, ensuring that objectives aren't met at the cost of people's well-being.

Of course, an organization that values love, peace, and harmony sometimes needs a reality check to sustain its mission. Rational, impartial analysis – something that doesn't necessarily come easily to Mediators – is often required for a project to succeed in the long run. They can rely on Analysts to provide a critical counterpoint to their potentially damaging optimism. If running an organization together is like captaining a ship, then Mediators can be entrusted to conceive the journey and Analysts can be relied upon to optimize the route.

Unbalanced Mediator-Analyst Cooperation

Hiding Hurt Feelings

To put it mildly, Analysts share their opinions freely and they are less conflict-averse than Mediators. When Analyst colleagues disagree with them, even in minor or constructive ways, especially sensitive Mediators may interpret the comments as judgmental or unfair. This can hit Mediators hard, making them feel unappreciated or unwelcome in their workplaces.

Faced with blunt commentaries from Analysts, Mediators may disengage, avoiding their Analyst colleagues whenever possible. They may also hesitate to share their views and opinions, shy away from challenging projects, or struggle to maintain focus on their tasks. Because they don't interpret disagreement as a personal affront (and often even enjoy it), Analysts may not even realize they're having such a strong detrimental effect on their Mediator colleagues.

Caring or Naïve?

When Mediators and Analysts don't respect each other's priorities, their working relationships can become tense and unbalanced. Mediators may become alarmed when Analysts make decisions based purely on logic and expediency rather than taking relationships and people's feelings into account. When Mediators voice their objections, they might find themselves labeled "naïve" or "soft."

Confident and ever rational, Analysts are likely to shoot down Mediators who advocate for kindness over logic, accusing them of emotional decision-making (as though it isn't a valid perspective) or even questioning their intelligence. Mediators may suffer such brusqueness quietly but feel deeply hurt. If they truly feel their

principles are being violated, however, they may hit an emotional breaking point, unleashing uncharacteristic anger and frustration on their colleagues.

Rebalancing Mediator–Analyst Cooperation

Nothing Personal

As intelligent and insightful as they are, Analysts are notorious for being emotionally chilly, often unintentionally (but not always!). In many cases, they dispense with common cordiality in favor of efficient, to-the-point communication. It may seem to sensitive Mediators that Analysts are intentionally unfriendly, when their intent is efficiency.

Once Mediators realize that Analysts' behavior rarely indicates any actual negativity, they can lower their defenses and enjoy their relationships. Of course, "Don't take things personally," is easier said than done. Here are some strategies that can be helpful:

- Pay attention to personal beliefs and expectations about how people "should" act in the workplace – for example, "People should offer feedback gently and considerately."
- Notice the interpretations that underlie these expectations. Does it feel like a personal attack if someone cuts down an idea without acknowledging its merits? Does it feel as if they're trying to convey personal disdain rather than impersonal feedback?
- Pay attention to situations that trigger your expectations. In the moment, come up with alternative explanations, even if they seem unlikely. Could the person just be doing things the way they think is best? Might their behavior

reflect their personality and their life experience – rather than a personal attack?

Many Analysts don't ascribe to common societal expectations, even those that seem "obvious." When Analysts seem rude, harsh, or inconsiderate, Mediators can generate alternative explanations rather than taking the behavior personally.

Direct Communication

As much as they might want to avoid difficult conversations, the best way for Mediators to communicate with Analysts is directly. When they feel that communication is blocked, or a misunderstanding has occurred, they can ask Analysts where the disconnect lies and how they might work together to prevent similar problems in the future.

Candor is important in this case – not only because Analysts respect it, but also because they're less emotionally attuned than Mediators and may not be aware of the issue in the first place. By adopting a straightforward yet sincere approach, Mediators can gently – by Analyst standards – draw attention to any rifts and steer the conversation toward solutions.

Mediators can also facilitate communication by asking insightful questions. Analysts love to share their opinions, so by asking questions, Mediators can better understand their opinions without getting sidetracked into disagreement. In fact, this type of conversation may motivate Analysts to inquire about Mediators' opinions.

Analysts generally respect people who ask good questions and prompt interesting discussions, so a questions-based conversation may pique their curiosity about Mediators' alternative viewpoints and ideas. Here are some suggestions for facilitating communication:

- Cultivate genuine curiosity about the situation.
- Communicate directly yet sincerely – for example, “What would you identify as the best possible outcome for this project?” or “How do you think we can work better together in the future?”
- Ask thoughtful questions. Don’t be afraid to dig deep. Analysts love follow-up questions that allow them to delve into the many layers of a situation.
- If Analysts ask questions in return, be honest and straightforward. Don’t hesitate to share opinions, but don’t be surprised if Analysts expect the opinions to be supported by facts, data, or theories. This is simply how their minds work.

Shying away from conflicts with Analysts is rarely productive. Although it isn’t easy for them, Mediators can facilitate productive interactions with their Analyst colleagues by being direct and authentic, rather than walking on eggshells or withdrawing altogether.

Mediator-Diplomat Cooperation



Balanced Mediator-Diplomat Cooperation

Visions and Ideas

Mediators and other Diplomats have the advantage of speaking the same “language” – they’re visionaries focused on growth, humanity, and exploring ideas. Others may talk about the nuts and bolts of an organization, but these personality types talk to one another about creating harmony and growth in the workplace. Although they may appear overly idealistic to other types, they agree among themselves that progress is always possible.

Together, Mediators and other Diplomats can breathe fresh air into any workplace. They might brainstorm a plan to more fairly distribute time or labor, for example, or they might launch an initiative to donate a portion of proceeds to charity. Although they delight in the kindred spirits of their fellow Diplomats, their empathy and openness allow them to understand the value of different perspectives.

For example, Mediators might consult a Thinking or Judging type for help with logistics or implementation. When other types offer critical feedback, Mediators and Diplomats know instinctively how to support each other through the process – or support each other in their next effort, if their initial idea turns out to be truly untenable.

Finding Purpose

For Mediators and other Diplomats, work is most exciting when its purposeful on a deep level. These two quickly target any injustice or unfairness in a business, and they may form strong alliances around such matters. Unwilling to sacrifice their values to turn a profit or meet a benchmark, they agree that a cold, calculated

approach to work or business is never the right path, particularly if it's conducted at the expense of people's feelings or well-being.

In balanced situations, these two augment their idealistic, principled perspectives by collaborating with other colleagues, even those who might be more utilitarian or analytical. Provided they remember the inherent fairness of respecting others' opinions, Mediators and Diplomats are poised to recognize the unique strengths their coworkers bring to the table.

By bringing together different perspectives and styles of thinking, they can allow their purposeful ideas to reach fruition in a way that aligns with everyone's interests and takes advantage of everyone's abilities. This not only gets things done – an arena where Mediators and Diplomats may struggle on their own – but also fosters egalitarianism and meritocracy in their workplaces.

Unbalanced Mediator-Diplomat Cooperation

Diplomat Island

Mediators and Diplomats often delight in working together, recognizing each other as all-too-rare kindred spirits. They must take care, however, not to limit their interaction with colleagues who think differently – even those who think “conventionally.” Otherwise, they put themselves at risk of becoming stuck in their own style of thinking, missing out on opportunities to challenge their opinions and expand their worldviews.

In business and in life, it's good to have varied personality types around to provide balance. With their focus on ideas instead of deadlines, Mediators and Diplomats who opt to work in a vacuum may generate grand ideas that go nowhere, or their

inherent optimism may cause them to underestimate practical challenges. Unless they enlist – and listen to – other opinions, they may fail to effect the positive changes that mean so much to them.

Talk, Talk, Talk

When Diplomats sequester themselves from other viewpoints, they tend to focus on guiding principles, mission statements, and long-term visions – at the expense of tactical plans. Inspirational discussions can be an important launching pad toward a better future, but without a concrete how-to strategy, idealistic discussion may lead to gridlock. Endless discussions do more harm than good, and these two types must be particularly careful not let inertia set in when the job calls for action.

This dynamic often manifests itself when Mediators and other Diplomats face tough decisions, such as axing failing projects or slashing budgets. These are difficult topics for Diplomats to analyze objectively, given their idealistic drive to search for solutions that benefit everyone – solutions that, in some cases, simply doesn't exist. Without reality checks from other personality types, these two may put off necessary decisions for too long, ultimately damaging their – and others' – prospects of success.

Rebalancing Mediator-Diplomat Cooperation

Second Opinions

Mediators and Diplomats may enjoy each other's company so much that they inadvertently become cliquish, excluding colleagues who think differently. These two types are fiercely egalitarian in principle, but at times the joy of finding a kindred spirit can completely blind them to the ways that they wall off others. Not only does this make their coworkers feel unwelcome or unheard, it also robs Mediators and

Diplomats of the opportunity to hear alternative perspectives. In many cases, outside perspectives are essential for progress, as they offer an important counterbalance to Mediators and Diplomats' dauntless optimism and big-picture worldview.

To correct for any imbalances, Mediators and Diplomats can solicit the opinions of other coworkers – even coworkers who might seem stodgy or pessimistic. To broaden the conversation, they can include other coworkers in brainstorming sessions, meetings, and even informal discussions. Mediators' natural desire to include and listen to others comes in handy here.

Mediators and Diplomats can also solicit others' opinions to loosen the reins on their self-imposed perfectionism. When they fall short or fail to deliver, these two may languish in self-blame to the point that they cannot move forward at all. Instead, they can use their natural empathy and compassion to support each other in acknowledging their weaknesses and asking for help from colleagues whose strengths provide counterbalance. It's perfectly fine to approach a colleague and say, "I'm struggling with this project. Would you mind looking over my work for blind spots or other issues?"

To solicit help from others, Mediators and other Diplomats can:

- Create a list of all colleagues who might be approached for help. Briefly note their strengths, such as troubleshooting, financial analysis, or neutral analysis of workplace politics.
- Approach those people one-on-one when help is needed with a specific issue.
- Explain that you'd like an opinion on something, and ask whether they have time to speak now or if a later time would be better. If approaching them in person is too daunting, set up a time over email or text message.

- Come armed with specific questions, such as, “Does this seem feasible to you?” and “What would you recommend?”
- Establish appropriate expectations. Make it clear that you are asking for an opinion, not directives, and that you may proceed differently.
- Take notes during the conversation. Afterward, look through your notes and circle action items. Schedule a time to implement the actions or integrate them into the current plan.
- Afterward, thank the person for their time. Follow up to let them know how you have implemented their advice, if appropriate.
- Remember that, however awkward it may feel to ask for help, people are generally flattered and intrigued when asked to give their opinions.

Everyone has something to contribute. By drawing others into the conversation, Mediators and Diplomats leverage the full diversity of their colleagues’ strengths.

Slow It Down

Idealistic goals often benefit the workplace, but they must be crafted one piece at a time with focus and care, not just hope. Mediators and Diplomats can encourage each other to slow down just a little, even when they feel success is guaranteed. Instead of leaping forward to an assumed outcome, they should take the time to assess and review each stage of a potential project. This enables them to use their imaginations to identify potential pitfalls as well as opportunities for improvement.

In meetings as well as informal discussions, Mediators and other Diplomat types can remind each other to devise action plans to back up their big ideas. Failing that, they can enlist other personality types who take a more hands-on approach: Sentinels and

Explorers in particular can help Diplomats identify realistic, achievable steps in pursuit of any grand goal.

- After identifying a promising goal or idea, take a moment to assess it. How many people-hours would the project entail? What benchmarks would have to be met? Who would need to contribute, and what specific tasks would they handle? If you focused on this idea, what other projects or tasks *wouldn't* get done? Write out answers to these questions.
- Solicit opinions and advice from people with other thinking styles.
- Chart out each stage of the project, incorporating the insights received in the previous step. Specifically consider any potential issues that might arise. What adjustments can be made to preempt or address them? Do they make the idea unfeasible?

Without sacrificing their trademark optimism, Mediators and Diplomats can support each other to translate their big ideas into action steps and timelines. That way, they won't get derailed or distracted as they tackle the wonderful projects they conceive together.

Mediator-Sentinel Cooperation



Balanced Mediator-Sentinel Cooperation

Human Interest

Both Mediators and Sentinels see the value of human connection in the workplace, albeit in different ways. Mediators' interest is more intuitive and ideological, whereas Sentinels focus on the practical groundwork necessary to forge and maintain relationships. For example, Mediators might quickly detect the mood of a potential client or customer. Upon hearing those insights, Sentinels can navigate the necessary steps to bolster the underlying relationship.

As a result, Mediators and Sentinels can excel at collaborating on matters that involve people, such as human resources, hiring, and even negotiations. With Mediators offering a high-level view of what is right, fair, or just, Sentinels can then tackle the on-the-ground practicalities necessary to structure benefit packages, collect references, or get a contract approved. When these two types communicate and cooperate fully, their differing strengths create a human-centric synergy that facilitates goodwill as well as progress.

Creativity Meets Diligence

Mediators and Sentinels complement each other by providing different kinds of support for an organization. For Mediators, the larger picture and big ideas are important. Directives that come across as strict or nitpicky may feel frustrating or needlessly harsh to them, so they sometimes miss small but essential details. Sentinels don't, and their diligence and guidance can complement Mediators' creativity to ensure that work runs smoothly, and the organization prospers.

Mediators can help Sentinels tune into the intangible side of human interaction, and Sentinels can help Mediators stay on target when it comes to precision, productivity, and tough but necessary decisions. Sentinels can encourage and guide Mediators when practical focus is needed, helping them keep their feet on the ground while striding in the right direction. In a balanced relationship, Mediators recognize that Sentinels' insights – however nitpicky they might initially seem – will foster improvement and progress. As a result, Sentinels can motivate Mediators to stick with work that seems tedious to get things done.

Unbalanced Mediator–Sentinel Cooperation*Rules vs. Flexibility*

Sentinels may place procedures and professional responsibility above other people's feelings, which can alienate and even hurt sensitive Mediators. When Mediators are tired, uninspired, or struggling, they consider it reasonable to take personal time and adjust expectations. However, Sentinels may well expect them to push through and get the job done anyway – an expectation Mediators might take personally, especially if they struggle with insecurity.

In such situations, Mediators might feel trapped. On one hand, they may believe that Sentinels are being unreasonable; on the other hand, it pains them to fall short in their colleagues' eyes. Typical workplace issues such as tardiness, precision, policy adherence, and follow-through can trigger this dynamic, with Sentinels insisting on strict accountability and Mediators struggling to juggle workplace performance with their life circumstances – an inherently stressful situation.

Good Enough?

Driven by idealism and grand visions, Mediators always strive toward improvement and a better future. Because Sentinels generally value and adhere to proven standards and methods, Mediators' dreams of different realities may exasperate them. Sentinels appreciate the status quo and are reluctant to fix things that aren't broken, especially when the bottom line is already adequately served.

As a result, these two may disagree about engaging new ideas, whether a new social-media strategy or a different way to arrange merchandise. When Sentinels disregard Mediators' visions for change, Mediators may interpret the feedback as a personal attack. In turn, Mediators may find themselves accused of wasting time or “messing with success” in their search for better ways to do things.

Rebalancing Mediator–Sentinel Cooperation

Reasons for Rules

Although practical strictures may stymie their optimism, Mediators can cultivate an appreciation for what might seem like nitpickiness in their Sentinel colleagues. In many cases, details matter immensely; sometimes someone must uphold rules and keep an eye on the bottom line. Instead of resenting Sentinels for their traits,

Mediators can learn to value having help with things that aren't necessarily their strongest qualities.

When Mediators spot this silver lining, they should thank Sentinels for their efforts. Although they might not ask for praise, Sentinels work incredibly hard, even in the face of personal challenges, and they're grateful when their dedication is acknowledged. A simple acknowledgment and word of thanks can help them maintain motivation or get through a difficult day.

Mediators can work most effectively with Sentinels by demonstrating – rather than talking about – cooperation and compromise. For Sentinels, actions truly speak louder than words. Here is a framework that can facilitate the process:

- Fully listen to and consider Sentinels' suggestions. Ask questions about their rationale and the results they'd like to see.
- Implement – or at least experiment with – one of their suggestions. Approach the endeavor with an air of curiosity, open-mindedness, and discovery. The experiment can take many forms, such as conducting "AB" testing (comparing two ideas simultaneously) or piloting an idea for a specific amount of time.
- Track the results of the experiment, noting the full range of micro and macro benefits. Have budget cuts been avoided? Did a process go more smoothly than it usually does? Review your insights with colleagues – including Sentinels – and work together to decide how future scenarios might be handled.
- Thank Sentinels for their ideas and their contributions.

By experimenting with Sentinels' rules and noting the benefits, Mediators may come to recognize these colleagues as hardworking, principled allies, always willing to pitch in and help to move things forward.

Progress and Compromise

In tense working relationships, Mediators and Sentinels lock horns over new ideas. Because Sentinels often defend the status quo, Mediators are left to demonstrate the merits of the alternatives they envision. However, because of their Intuitive and Perspective traits, Mediators may have difficulty supporting their ideas with concrete, specific evidence – the type of evidence that would sway Sentinels.

There are several potential remedies to this situation. If Mediators don't have their Sentinel colleagues' trust, they may need to prove their ability to structure an effective plan – for example, by learning project-management techniques or by creating SMART goals (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-Bound). The frameworks may help Sentinels feel confident that Mediators can balance their inherent idealism with an awareness of logistics and practicalities.

Mediators can also adopt the following approach to suggest changes to Sentinels:

- Review the current protocol thoroughly. Collect data on its performance, if available. List benefits and weaknesses.
- Outline the proposed alternative in concrete terms. What specific changes need to be made? Who will do the work? How long will the project take to reach fruition? What are its specific advantages? For example, will it bolster customer satisfaction or increase sales? How can its success be measured?
- Consider potential counterarguments to the new idea. Evaluate their validity and plan replies in advance.
- Meet in person with the Sentinel and present the above analysis. A written copy is helpful, as are charts (if relevant).

- Suggest changes as evolutions of the current procedure rather than a radical departure.
- Solicit feedback and take notes. Integrate the feedback into a revised version of the idea, if possible.

Mediator-Explorer Cooperation



Balanced Mediator-Explorer Cooperation

Always Improving

The common ground between Mediators and Explorers may be difficult to define, but it certainly exists. Both enjoy moving forward in life and striving for improvement, although their approaches are different. Whereas Mediators often approach challenges by considering large-scale ideas and implications, their Explorer colleagues excel at finding practical solutions to specific problems.

When it comes to workplace issues, these two can approach any issue from different angles to solve it complementarily. Mediators can offer creative vision, opening the doors for change and improvement. Explorers can then tackle problems that arise,

explaining how to make things work – often in unique and exciting ways. Given their shared respect for flexibility and experimentation, these two types are powerful allies in pursuit of innovation.

Here and Now

When Mediators get lost in their mental chatter, they can count on Explorer colleagues to snap them out of it. Explorers find the exciting side of things, whether they're learning how to use a new tool or troubleshooting on the fly. As a result, Explorers can teach Mediators to set aside their worries – which are almost always about the future or the past – and encourage them to fully inhabit the present moment.

Working with Explorers offers Mediators a break from their minds and a chance to lose themselves in the work at hand – a respite that suits their Introverted and Intuitive natures. If they struggle with perfectionism, Mediators may frequently second-guess themselves in the workplace – losing their nerve, leaving tasks undone, and failing to act on their ideas. Given their delight in the here and now and their keen eye for novelty, Explorer colleagues can be a refreshing change for otherwise restrained Mediators. Their energy and vigor can reignite Mediators' motivation, helping them to follow through on their plans.

Unbalanced Mediator-Explorer Cooperation

Values vs. Utility

Although established standards don't bind either Mediators or Explorers as tightly as they might Sentinels, Mediators do live by a code. Their values are active forces in their lives, as real as any actions. Explorers have values of their own, but they focus

more on utilitarian solutions than ideals, which influences the way they handle business. For instance, Explorers might be relatively willing to fire underperforming employees or bolster sales by taking client lists from their competitors – two behaviors that would probably wound Mediators' sense of principle.

In discussing workplace plans and practices, Mediators may sometimes be concerned about Explorers' disregard for human consequences over goal achievement. This can build into a mutual resentment, with Mediators seeing Explorers as disregarding ethical standards and Mediators being constant downers who let nothing slide or who have no fun, leaving the two unable to cooperate at all.

Second-Guessing

If their worries outweigh their self-confidence, Mediators fall into the trap of overthinking everything and indulging in endless *what-ifs*. By contrast, Explorers like to move quickly into action. If Mediators get in Explorers' way, they may find themselves labeled “wet blankets.” Although it sounds innocent enough, this criticism may be disheartening to Mediators, who view themselves as free spirits at heart. Faced with this type of feedback, Mediators may doubt their abilities, second-guess themselves even more, or shut down altogether.

Of course, these aren't ideal conditions for collaboration and cooperation. If Mediators retreat from their Explorer colleagues to escape judgment, they compromise the incredible potential these two must cancel out each other's weaknesses. In addition, Mediators may carry their hurt feelings and self-doubt to other arenas of their lives, from their relationships to their passion projects.

Rebalancing Mediator–Explorer Cooperation

Calls to Action

Mediators may not agree with Explorers' utilitarianism – in other words, their prioritization of expediency and results no matter the consequences for other people – but that doesn't mean they can't work together productively. In fact, open-minded Mediators are uniquely poised to appreciate Explorers' creativity (if it isn't too impulsive or outlandish). This appreciation can go a long way with Explorers, many of whom aim to achieve mastery in their work.

So how can Mediators work with Explorers in a way that leaves both parties feeling capable, confident, and creatively energized? First, Mediators should avoid long-winded explanations and philosophical musings – two surefire ways to lose Explorers' interest. However poetic or insightful, these conversations strike Explorers as idle chitchat, and they won't persuade them to pitch in on a human-centric project.

If they ask for assistance on a project that upholds their personal values, Mediators may be pleasantly surprised by Explorers' willingness to help – *if* Mediators frame their requests in a way that captures Explorers' interest, that is. Wherever they stand on the workplace hierarchy, Explorers love fixing things; if a task interests them, they take it on without hesitation. Here are some hints Mediators can use to approach their Explorer colleagues:

- When asking for help from Explorers, specify how they can act. “Can you find a way to improve our company's image?” is too vague. But, “This is driving me nuts. Can you help me find the bug on this web page?” outlines a concrete, present-moment problem that needs solving.
- Explain further only if asked. Lengthy explanations don't motivate Explorers.

- Feel free to use colloquial language, joke, and create a fun environment.
- End the conversation on a clear call to action, which is ideal for Mediators and Explorers. Both benefit from a sense of actionable urgency.
- Pay attention to how Explorers proceed, most likely taking immediate action and finding the fun or novel side of the task. Note the benefits of their approach.
- Thank Explorers for their help.

For Explorers, lofty philosophical discussions are less compelling than practical benefits and a sense of discovery. By tailoring their communications accordingly, Mediators are more likely to persuade their Explorer colleagues to collaborate on a variety of projects, including those that are close to Mediators' hearts.

Appreciation

Compassionate and creative, Mediators can use their interpersonal attunement to establish common ground with Explorers. Specifically, they can strive to translate their big ideas into the specific, tangible problems that capture Explorers' imaginations. This may not come naturally to Mediators, but it enables them to view their work from an entirely new – and uniquely helpful – perspective.

Over time, Mediators can use their empathy to cultivate a wholehearted appreciation for Explorers' perspective. Perhaps more than any other personality type, Mediators viscerally understand the value of diverse approaches. If everyone were alike, the world would be a dull, barren place – and this goes for the workplace as well. With Explorer colleagues, they can marvel at the opportunity to work with people who are wholly different from themselves. With that perspective, Explorers' behaviors – even their criticisms – are worthy of curiosity, as they offer a window into a different way

of seeing the world. Here are some suggestions that can help Mediators with embracing their perspective:

- Approach Explorers with a sense of genuine curiosity.
- Seek out the lessons that they can teach, including how to take quick action and seize opportunities.
- Take notes on how Explorer colleagues behave in urgent, high-stress situations. How do they communicate? What do they do? Explorers' example can be helpful for Mediators, many of whom struggle under pressure.
- When appropriate, experiment with replicating Explorers' behavior; for example, take immediate action after a meeting rather than leave it for another day.

When communicating and cooperating fully, Explorers and Mediators cover each other's weaknesses and complement each other's strengths. These two can tackle just about anything, and their interest in progress and innovation can unite them in unexpected yet powerful ways.

Conclusion

Mediators' strengths – including creativity, empathy, and human insight – are invaluable in many workplaces. To achieve job satisfaction, however, they must harmonize their work with their personalities. This often entails unhooking from praise and criticism, balancing social interaction with alone time, and relieving some of the pressure they place on themselves.

In interacting with coworkers, Mediators must balance their sensitivity and optimism with the necessities of facing conflict, managing criticism, and soliciting alternative

viewpoints. It isn't easy, but it's certainly achievable, and the resulting confidence and equanimity will only bolster Mediators' overall growth and development. Provided they approach work with a mindset of service and self-efficacy, Mediators can carry the resulting sense of meaning and purpose into every aspect of their lives.

Additional Tools and Tests

Want to dig even deeper into your professional development? If you have access to the toolkits area of the website, we offer a variety of additional tools and tests to help you explore.

Job Preferences Test

Among the most important things you decide in life is how you're going to make a living. Discover which job fields fit you best.

Job Burnout Test

We've all heard the term "burnout." But what does it mean to you? This test will guide you as you take a look at how burnout affects you.

Career Values Test

What should your job look like for you to call it "ideal"? What aspects matter most to you? This tool will help you answer these questions.

Leadership Styles Test

What is your leadership style? There is no right or wrong answer to that question. This test will help clarify your preferred approach.

Leadership Styles II Test

The second part of our Leadership Styles test will explore your desire to be a leader and willingness to delegate power.

Motivation Test

On average, we work for about 90,000 hours over our lifetime. With that in mind, it's helpful to figure out exactly what motivates you.

Ambition Test

How eager are you to succeed, and at what cost? Ambition can be a double-edged sword – explore how it works in your case.

Professional Authenticity Test

When at work, are you acting in a way that is consistent with your true self? Explore difficult questions about authenticity with this test.

Goal Orientation Test

What's the underlying motivation you feel when confronting a challenge? See which of the Goal Orientations influences you most.

Type Guesser (Workplace)

Are you trying to figure out what personality type your coworker belongs to? You may find that this simple tool helps.

Final Words



Progress from the Heart and Mind

In all aspects of life, Mediators can use their natural qualities to wonderful potential, advancing themselves and others through conscious change. In a world of diverse challenges, these types can develop skills to handle whatever they may encounter without compromising their values, allowing them to function effectively and complete what they put their minds to. The adaptive yet focused mindset of Mediators opens endless possibilities, whether in romance, career, or personal expressions of creativity. Their open-mindedness can be one of their greatest virtues, especially when combined with willful action. Mediators have the great advantages of adaptability and imagination: if you can dream it, there's a good chance Mediators already have, and if it's a passion of theirs, they may have taken the first steps to turn dream into reality.

Their hearts are no less open, and no less a virtue for progress. Whether they're looking inward to discover the nooks and crannies of their own being, or forming strong relationships with family members, coworkers, or friends, Mediators' deep

human understanding helps move them forward in life. Although they're not likely to desire positions of social leadership, these types nonetheless often naturally become a nexus of bonding. People can't help but be enchanted when they discover how warm and caring these types are, as well as what they can offer. When Mediators choose to step out of insecurity and isolation, their open hearts provide them with endless opportunities to strengthen their lives by surrounding themselves with good people – and to develop their own inner strength.

Adapting Natural Qualities

This openness and flexibility can become liabilities when Mediators lose sight of their own goals and needs, whatever they may be. They know in their hearts what's right for them, but can get distracted by sweeping emotions, external pressure, or even their own unending curiosity. By deciding on and committing to their own priorities, these types can create personal growth and success in all areas of life. Whether this means working on self-discipline in school or on the job, or standing up for their own needs in their personal relationships, their amazing potential can be fully realized only when they balance their receptive spontaneity with some consistent determination.

This isn't to say that Mediators should abandon their dreamy, contemplative, impulsive side – it's the wellspring of their creativity and the source of their great potential. If anything, these types can find balance by acting on the many wonderful ideas within them, welcoming others' input without losing their own sense of power, and sharing in people's emotions without being subject to them. For Mediators, learning how to navigate the external world while maintaining happy individuality is a lifelong process. They may make just as many mistakes as anyone, but their optimism gives them an advantage over many other types.

Even in the face of failure and heartache, Mediators bounce back. As these types mature and grow, they learn to craft their flexibility into a structure of internal support with just the right amount of give – their strength is supple enough to never break. Likewise, Mediators turn their variability into an asset when they apply focused energy, remaining highly adaptable in the pursuit of their goals and passions without straying from them. With personal balance, practice, and a healthy dose of self-forgiveness, there is nothing in the world that people with this sweet, sensitive personality type cannot achieve when they step forward in life.

We've covered many different topics in this profile, and we hope that the chapters have offered insight and answered questions about the Mediator personality type. We hope that readers will now find it easier to understand other people and their perspectives. This profile isn't meant to be read just once. When trying to understand another person better, or struggling to understand oneself, another read-through can offer fresh insight.

Furthermore, spend some time on our [website](#) – for example, by exploring our [articles](#) or additional [Tools & Assessments](#). If you lead a team, our [Team Assessments](#) can help you understand its unique dynamics. There is a wealth of inspiring advice and information on the website, and we strongly recommend that you take a look. If you have some spare time, consider lending us a helping hand by taking additional [surveys](#) or simply [sending us a message](#) and sharing your thoughts about this profile or the website in general. We would love to hear from you.

We wish the best of luck to all Mediators. What matters most in Mediators' lives is that their paths through life reflect who they are, deep within. Reflecting on values, dreams, and ideals often reveals the right path through life by clearing out superficial distractions. Our lives are often too full of troubles, conflicts, and worries. By working

to better understand each other, we can make our relationships, communities, and world more aware, more genuine, and more peaceful.

Until next time.

Addendum: The Puzzle of Personality

Often the very first question people ask after completing our personality test is “What do these letters mean?” We are of course referring to those mysterious acronyms like INTJ-A, ENFP-T, or ESTJ-A. As you may have already learned from the Type Descriptions or articles on the website, the five letters of these acronyms each refer to a specific trait, with certain trait combinations forming various types and type groups. But before we discuss those traits in depth, let’s explore their historical foundations.

The Historical Detour

Since the dawn of time, humans have drawn up schematics to describe and categorize our personalities. From the four temperaments of the ancient civilizations to the latest advances in psychology, we have been driven to fit the variables and complexities of human personality into well-defined models. Although we are still some time away from being able to do that, the current models account for our most important personality traits and can predict our behavior with a high degree of accuracy.

Personality is just one of many factors that guide our behavior, however. Our actions are also influenced by our environment, our experiences, and our individual goals. On our website, we describe how people belonging to a specific personality type are likely to behave. We outline indicators and tendencies, however, not definitive guidelines or answers. Significant differences can exist even among people who share a personality type. The information on this website is meant to inspire personal

growth and an improved understanding of yourself and your relationships – not to be taken as gospel.

Our approach has its roots in two different philosophies. One dates back to early 20th century and was the brainchild of Carl Gustav Jung, the father of analytical psychology. Jung's theory of psychological types is perhaps the most influential creation in personality typology, and it has inspired a number of different theories. One of Jung's key contributions was the development of the concept of Introversion and Extraversion – he theorized that each of us falls into one of these two categories, either focusing on the internal world (Introvert) or the outside world (Extravert). Besides Introversion and Extraversion, Jung coined the concept of so-called cognitive functions, separated into Judging or Perceiving categories. According to Jung, each person prefers one of these cognitive functions and may most naturally rely on it in everyday situations.

In the 1920s, Jung's theory was noticed by Katharine Cook Briggs, who later co-authored a personality indicator still used today, the Myers-Briggs Type Indicator® (MBTI®). Briggs was a teacher with an avid interest in personality typing, having developed her own type theory before learning of Jung's writings. Together with her daughter, Isabel Briggs Myers, they developed a convenient way to describe the order of each person's Jungian preferences – this is how four-letter acronyms were born.

Of course, this is just a very simplified description of the Myers-Briggs theory. Readers interested in learning more should read *Gifts Differing: Understanding Personality Type* by Isabel Briggs Myers. As we define personality traits and types differently in our model, we will not go deeper into Jungian concepts or related theories in this article.

Due to its simplicity and ease of use, the four-letter naming model has been embraced by a number of diverse theories and approaches over the last few decades, including frameworks such as Socionics, Keirsey Temperament Sorter, Linda Berens' Interaction Styles, and many others. While the acronyms used by these theories may be identical or very similar, however, their meanings do not always overlap. One of the reasons behind such a lengthy introduction is that we want to make it clear that there is no single definition assigned to these type acronyms – each theory defines them in their own way and it is entirely possible that if you meet five people who all say “I am an INFJ”, their definitions of what INFJ means are going to differ.

Types vs. Traits

Regardless of its structure, any type-based theory will struggle to describe or characterize people whose scores lie near the dividing line. A different way to look at personalities is through the lens of a trait-based rather than a type-based model. What do we mean by that? Instead of creating an arbitrary number of categories and attempting to fit people within them, a trait-based model simply studies the degree to which people exhibit certain traits.

You may have heard the term Ambivert, which is a perfect example in this case. Ambiversion means that someone falls in the middle of the Introversion-Extraversion scale, being neither too outgoing nor too withdrawn. Trait-based theories would simply say that an Ambivert is moderately Extraverted or moderately Introverted and leave it at that, without assigning a personality type.

A trait-based approach makes it easier to reliably measure correlations between personality traits and other characteristics – for example, political attitudes. This is why trait-based approaches dominate psychometric research, but that's more or less

the only area where these approaches are dominant. Because they don't offer types or categorizations, trait-based theories don't translate as well as type-based theories into specific recommendations and takeaways. Assigned categories such as Extravert or Introvert may be limiting, but they allow us to conceptualize human personality and create theories about why we do what we do – something that a more scientifically reliable but colorless statement, such as you are 37% Extraverted, simply cannot do.

Our Approach

With our NERIS® model, we've combined the best of both worlds. We use the acronym format introduced by Myers-Briggs for its simplicity and convenience, with an extra letter to accommodate five rather than four scales. However, unlike Myers-Briggs or other theories based on the Jungian model, we have not incorporated Jungian concepts such as cognitive functions, or their prioritization. Jungian concepts are very difficult to measure and validate scientifically, so we've instead chosen to rework and rebalance the dimensions of personality called the Big Five personality traits, a model that dominates modern psychological and social research.

Our personality types are based on five independent spectrums, with all letters in the type code (e.g. INFJ-A) referring to one of the two sides of the corresponding spectrum. You can see where you fall on each scale by completing our free personality assessment, NERIS Type Explorer®. This approach has allowed us to achieve high test accuracy while also retaining the ability to define and describe distinct personality types.

Five Personality Aspects

This section will describe five personality aspects that, when combined, define the personality type: Energy, Mind, Nature, Tactics and Identity. Each of these aspects should be seen as a two-sided continuum, with the “neutral” option placed in the middle. The percentages you would have seen after completing the test are meant to show which categories you fall under, and how strong your preferences are.

Let us now go through the personality aspects one by one:

Introverted vs. Extraverted

More Than People Power

When considering people who are Introverts (I) and Extraverts (E), it's natural to go straight to the more social aspects of these personality traits. However, they are more than this. These traits are also defined by their broader response to their environments, which includes other people but isn't exclusively about them.

Introvert (I) Personality

Strength in Reserve

Introverts are well-suited to many situations. A tendency to be reserved helps these personality types to pace themselves. They're likely to listen to others more carefully. Very introspective, Introverts enjoy more focused “alone time” – leading to more and deeper insights. And, while sometimes too sensitive to their environments, this often helps them pick up cues more quickly, making them great at reading many situations.

However, this same reserve means that Introverts tend to find outside stimuli like noise, motion, or intrusive lighting frustrating. Some of this can be an invigorating change of pace – too much unsettles them and drains their energy. These personality types often prefer to be in their own space where they can adjust their environments. Add a human factor to this sensitivity – for example, insistent conversations where they're expected to be just as insistent – and it can exhaust them. They need time alone to regather their energy and restore their calm.

Introverts' reserved, more solitary nature presents challenges, as many societies favor Extraverts and their bolder approach. But it helps Introverted personality types to take things slowly, cautiously, and with less fanfare. Fortunately, if they're willing – and create the time to recharge on their own – most Introverts can handle society's strenuous demands.

In fact, many successful leaders and entertainers come from their ranks, often remaining humble and avoiding an unnecessary spotlight in fame. The Introversion personality trait never needs to disqualify those who possess it from pursuing a goal.

Extravert (E) Personality

The Power of Engagement

Extraverts are interested in engaging with their environment, and they feed off the responses of the people and events around them. They enjoy pushing limits and seeing what the world can do. This all depends on many other factors and life's natural limitations, but Extraverted personality types lean toward taking the initiative and relying on the world around them for validation.

While all of this is noble and often admired in society, it can also become unbridled. Extraverts may put too much value in their engagement with those around them. Being with others can be so important to these personalities that they often find it difficult if they're stuck alone. Boredom comes too easily. This can lead them to do things simply for excitement rather than thinking through more subtle but important considerations. Becoming the center of attention – at any cost – might be too appealing.

However, when they suitably address these challenges, Extraverts are forces to be reckoned with. People with this personality trait tend to advance projects important to them quickly, whether personal or professional. They often choose to lead when given a chance – and can be dynamic in that role. Their outgoing energy can be vital to a social gathering, and their liveliness can be contagious. And there always remains a sense that people are important to them.

Intuitive vs. Observant

Thought at Every Scale

Our second personality scale includes the Intuitive (N) and Observant (S) styles. These traits describe what people are more likely to do with the information gathered from the world around them. Intuitive personality types rely on imagining the past and future potential of what they see. Those with the Observant style are more interested in observable facts and more straightforward outcomes. They prefer to avoid layering too much interpretation on what they see.

Being Intuitive doesn't mean someone can't be practical, and being Observant doesn't mean a lack of imagination. They both use their minds and their physical

senses well. The difference is the spin they put on their experiences – it's where their thinking goes after an encounter with their environment. If Intuitive personality types appreciate Observant types' practicality, and Observant personality types appreciate Intuitive types' imaginative perspective, they can complement each other in ways that make for unbeatable partnerships.

Intuitive (N) Personality

Eyes on the Horizon

People with the Intuitive trait prefer to exercise their imaginations as they seek new ideas and possibilities. They live their day-to-day lives just like any other personality type. But while that's happening, their minds tend to point inward while at the same time gently focusing somewhere beyond the horizon. Their lives are ones of questioning, wondering, and connecting the dots in the "bigger picture," and they love the theoretical. They often ask, "What if?" and ponder the possibilities the future might hold.

But Intuitive people aren't always the most practical, preferring instead to give things deeper meaning. There may be a long wait as these personality types allow their imaginations free rein. They may also leap in too quickly to more complex matters. An entire theory can come together in moments, leaving others confused. In either case, they can appear out of touch to the Observant individuals in their lives. For some Intuitive folk, there may be some truth to this observation.

That said, when there's a need for innovation or a different perspective, people with Intuitive personality types can usually step up and provide a new direction. Practicality can sometimes be overrated, especially when a situation calls for serious change and "coloring outside the lines." This is where Intuitive people shine. They

bring interesting dimensions to life beyond everyday ideas – and take those who decide to go along with them.

Observant (S) Personality

Do What Works

The phrase “real-time” was created with Observant individuals in mind. They’re most in touch with what occurs in front of them, in the present. This doesn’t mean Observant personality types have no regard for the past and future. But they view both from the perspective of how each influences their present actions. This makes them focused and practical people. They mostly root their thinking in the actionable, tangible, and useful. But make no mistake, these personalities can be creative within that realm.

One challenge people with the Observant personality trait may face is a too-narrow perspective. They may reject far-reaching solutions in favor of something more obvious. By continuing something that appears practical at arm’s length but doesn’t fit the bigger picture, they might reduce their hard work to busywork.

People with the Observant trait are often a steadying force that tends to get things done. Their energy is very “hands-on” in the sense of working on real things in real-time. While they’re often smart people, spending a lot of time sitting around and pondering possibilities doesn’t cut it for Observant personality types. They want thoughts and talk to lead to action.

Thinking vs. Feeling

How to Think and Feel About the Thinking and Feeling Traits

Our third, Nature scale reveals the extent to which we value emotions or rationality more when considering options. Does a person tend to use the Thinking (T) personality trait, which relies on the head, or the Feeling (F) trait, which relies on the heart?

But let's not oversimplify. Think of it instead as you might your hand preference: A left-handed person leans more heavily on their left hand, but they still use their right hand, albeit less. We can apply the same approach to a person with a dominant Thinking trait or a dominant Feeling trait – they aren't without some qualities of the non-dominant trait.

Thinking (T) Personality

"How Does This Help?"

When presented with a decision, people with the Thinking trait typically lean on objective information. Knowledge is their indispensable tool. Once these personality types gather the facts, they test their alternatives against logic and reason to see which decision, by those standards, proves the most effective or realistic. They generally manage their relationships by employing fairness and effectiveness as their primary method of dealing with others. Their passions are born of respect.

Whatever value people with the Thinking personality trait place on relationships, they can still dismiss emotional responses, either their own or those of others. This is often because of their discomfort with emotions, which don't always follow the rational path they value. Sometimes, emotions just puzzle them. But that doesn't

mean they have hearts of stone. They often feel in deep, profound ways – they would just rather not decide matters from that place. And, perhaps unfortunately, they may see those who do as weaker decision-makers.

Personality types with the Thinking trait are likely to evaluate things almost relentlessly. This isn't as bad as it sounds. They aren't satisfied if they believe something is not well thought out – they revel in the brilliance of an elegant plan. This makes them great to have around when critical thinking and impartiality of any kind is the focus, and this makes them immensely helpful for sorting out ideas and methods. Their primary filter is, *"How does this help?"*

Feeling (F) Personality

"Who Does This Help?"

People with the Feeling (F) trait follow their hearts and emotions – sometimes without even realizing it. They may show it to different degrees and in different ways, but however they do it, Feeling personality types tend to be caring, compassionate, and warm. These concerned people can be highly protective of those they care about – whether that is their immediate family or remote populations in need.

However, people with the Feeling personality trait often find they become excessive in their concern for others. They may easily burn out – or cause others to – when they become too involved. These emotionally aware individuals can become depressed if they feel they haven't been as selfless in life as they imagine they should be, or if those they have helped seem to fall down regardless.

Feeling personality types' concern for others typically affects all their endeavors. This can be practical and close, as with family, friends, and colleagues. Or it can be broader, as with world peace, ending hunger, and giving the disadvantaged a boost.

But this reliance on feelings doesn't mean there is no logic – theirs is just a different logic. They see that emotions can't simply be waved away, so feelings and the welfare of others shape their lives more than stark facts and cold objectivity. Weighing things this way makes these personalities valuable to have around when the big question is, “*Who does this help?*”

Judging vs. Prospecting

Crossing the Finish Line (By Whatever Means)

The Tactics scale, which includes the Judging and Prospecting personality traits, reflects how people plan and deal with the options they have. But this definition doesn't just concern what individuals write in their day planners. It's much broader. These traits answer questions like, “Do you prefer spontaneity or certainty?” “Do you feel more comfortable acting only with all your ducks lined neatly in a row? Or does a certain amount of flexibility or chaos excite you and prove motivating?” “Do you need more choices or fewer?”

Judging (J) Personality

Making Things as They Ought to Be

People with the Judging (J) personality trait feel most comfortable when the course ahead is well-marked. They would rather come up with five backup plans than deal with events as they come. Preferring to consider their options ahead of time,

personality types with this trait prefer clarity and closure, sticking with the plan rather than going with the flow. It's as if Judging types always keep a mental checklist. When they cross something off their list – or even start an item on their list – they consider it complete and not open to reconsideration.

The downside is, if they take this too far, those with the Judging trait sometimes come across as rigid. However, most are not unreasonably stubborn. It's important to remember their need for structure always is a preference and reality often calls on them to respond in unforeseen ways. Too many surprises in a row can leave these personality types frustrated and stressed. When this happens, they can still be relied on to develop a plan (and a contingency plan), but however well they handle the unexpected, they rarely enjoy it.

Judging individuals tend to have a strong work ethic, putting their duties and responsibilities above everything else. To them, rules, laws, and standards are the key to success. They can be too dependent on these measures, whether applied to themselves or others. But the intent is almost always one of fairness and results.

Prospecting (P) Personality

Figuring Things Out as They Go

Prospecting (P) individuals are much more flexible when it comes to dealing with unexpected challenges. This flexibility helps them seize unexpected opportunities as well. These personality types tend to react to their environments rather than try to control them, helping them to make their own luck in whatever the world delivers. People with this trait hold that life is full of possibilities.

All this opportunism can lead to impulsive decision-making, though. At the same time, they can be overwhelmed by the sheer number of options on their radar. People with the Prospecting personality trait can be slow to commit to something because of uncertainty or the potential of everything else. If they don't moderate this trait, indecision or a lack of conviction can be a problem. They can seem unfocused. What was important to them one week may be forgotten the next.

Despite those concerns, this personality trait can offer a great deal of creativity and productivity. Theirs is almost a stream of consciousness quality. In many ways, it's like these types are constantly brainstorming as their minds create a web of options. This can be a powerful tool for finding solutions. And if they aren't satisfied with something in their lives, it's easier for them to let go of it and choose something else. This can lead to serial passions that keep Prospecting individuals stimulated as they explore the buffet of choices always before them.

Assertive vs. Turbulent

Confidence, Achievement, and You

The Identity scale, made up of the Assertive and Turbulent personality traits, affects all other scales and indicates how confident we are in our abilities and decisions. Identity triggers the way we react to the things life constantly throws at us. How do we respond to success and failure? Criticism or feedback from other people? Unexpected events that suddenly change many things or everything? Even the unknown future?

Assertive (-A) Personality

Calm in the Storm

Assertive individuals are self-assured, even-tempered, and resistant to stress. They don't worry too much, but this is different from apathy. They aim for goals and want successful results, but they typically won't let nervousness color the path to their accomplishments. They're unlikely to spend a lot of time thinking about their past actions or choices. According to Assertive personality types, what's done is done.

However, problems may arise for them if their confidence turns into overconfidence. Assertive individuals may gloss over problems or details that can interfere with their goals and desired results. They may lean toward assuming all will be positive. Assertive people also sometimes presume they are free to do much more than others would allow or tolerate. If overconfident, these personality types may come to believe their confidence overshadows what others want.

But their confidence remains. It can help them move forward where others might hesitate. People with this personality trait report more satisfaction with their lives. They feel more assured of their abilities to handle the difficult and the unexpected. Through this lens, they often create the kinds of success that matter to them.

Turbulent (-T) Personality

Power of Stress, Activate!

Turbulent individuals are success-driven, perfectionistic, and eager to improve. They are always trying to counterbalance their self-doubts by achieving more. Just as they push themselves to become better, they're as likely to push their projects or efforts

in the same direction. Turbulent personality types tend to notice little problems and often do something about them before they become larger ones.

There are potential downsides to all this attention and achievement. Always feeling the need to do more, to have more, and to *be* more, Turbulent individuals can also get caught up in endless thoughts of criticisms, slights, or regrets. This can either bog them down or motivate them to do better. Their sensitivity to potential problems can be useful – unless that’s all they think about and the problems clutter their attention. Turbulent personality types may compulsively scan for what might go wrong instead of keeping their eyes on more positive targets – on what could go right.

Careful and attentive people are always important to society and keep it safe. At the same time, a fear of stagnation can bring about great change. Turbulent individuals beautifully cover both. When these personalities balance their worries and concerns with positive action, they’re likely to prove themselves to be of great value.

Type Groups

Now you know what each type consists of. But how do they fit together?

Our system has two layers: the first (inner) one defines our Roles, the second (outer) one – our Strategies.

Roles

Personality theory is a study of similarities among people with shared traits and how these traits might be expressed through behaviors and attitudes. Traits are the most fundamental part of our framework and include characteristics like Introversion or

Thinking. The next level contains personality types, in which four of the traits are combined and sorted to create 16 personality types. Roles, simply put, are the next level. At the Role level, the 16 types are divided into four groups.

Which personality types belong to each Role depends on two shared traits that they have in common. While all traits influence behaviors and attitudes, the two traits that determine a Role are shared by only four personality types and instill in them some unique, matching characteristics.

Those with the Intuitive trait (Analysts and Diplomats) are paired with the Thinking/Feeling traits because the Intuitive trait focuses on internal processes like thinking and feeling. While they may ultimately play out in the external world, they are primarily inward-looking.

In like manner, those with the Observant trait (Sentinels and Explorers) are paired with the Judging/Prospecting traits. Judging and Prospecting, while they have their internal aspects, are more likely to be played out in the external, concrete world of action and doing. Sentinels with their Judging trait are likely to bring order to their worlds, while Explorers with their Prospecting trait are likely to instill spontaneity into all the actions they perform.

The four Roles are primarily used when they are more likely to explain concepts in a clearer, less complicated way than involving all 16 personality types might. Using Roles this way is particularly warranted if the topic consists of a trait or traits that are a prominent part of the core traits of the various Roles – such as when Intuitive or Observant have a greater influence. But use is not limited to just that. They're like shorthand when Role commonalities suffice in talking about a subject.

In summary, Roles are just another level of the same theory, with each of the four containing four personality types. Those within a Role share a combination of two prominent traits and, therefore, share some similar characteristics.

The Role layer determines our goals, interests, and preferred activities. There are four roles:

Analysts – Intuitive (N) and Thinking (T)

Thinkers, Not Robots

The personality types in the Analyst Role – Architects (INTJ), Logicians (INTP), Commanders (ENTJ), and Debaters (ENTP) – are known for their love of rationality. Because they share the Thinking trait, these types often aim to make decisions with their heads rather than their hearts. But Analysts are far from being robots. Their Intuitive personality trait energizes their imaginations, helping them to come up with creative strategies and motivating them to explore things deeply – whether that’s an intellectual pursuit, a new interest, or even a crazy scheme or thought experiment.

These personalities are driven to understand and create. They have no problem switching between speculative musing and tactical problem-solving. Of course, these broad abilities need to be honed – and, when appropriate, they need to lead to action. Otherwise, Analysts’ active minds can give them a false sense of accomplishment.

These types often love ideas and speculation more than the realities of follow-through. As a result, they risk being outpaced by those who simply sit down and do the work. This can earn these types a reputation for being “armchair analysts” – and, at times, Analyst personalities may forget that they actually need to test their ideas in the real world.

Driven by Curiosity

Analysts are innately curious. This helps them to ensure that their ideas are workable, rather than just clever. These personality types have a strong drive to learn, and they want to find out things for themselves rather than accept received wisdom. These types may be found stockpiling books, questioning teachers, spurring debates, or driving conversations in forums across the Internet.

Analysts are also relentless self-improvers. Once they've recognized a flaw, they apply all of their rationality, imagination, and desire for results to make it right. Especially when it's balanced with self-understanding, this drive can enable Analyst personalities to push the boundaries of what's possible – no matter what anyone else may think.

Socially Selective

Analysts can have a reputation for being lone wolves. These personality types don't necessarily care about befriending everyone they meet, and they definitely don't surround themselves with random people just for the sake of having some company.

Given a choice between spending time with someone incompatible or spending time alone, many Analysts would choose the latter. And they may not be so subtle about it. 71% of people with Analyst personality types say they're good at shutting down unwanted conversations – far more than any other Role. This brusqueness can make Analysts seem rude, unapproachable, or antisocial, particularly to types that value social harmony.

That said, it's important to note that only 17% of Analysts actually describe their ideal social life as “mostly by myself.” Much greater numbers – 30% and 41% respectively

– say they’d prefer to have a few good friends or a partner and a few good friends. As a result, it’s inaccurate to view these personality types as antisocial.

Instead, it makes sense to view Analysts as socially selective. Like other types, they crave social connection. But these personalities won’t feel socially fulfilled by spending time with just anyone. They want to surround themselves with people who really get them – even if it takes effort to find those people. That might be why 46% of Analysts say they actively seek new friendships – which is more than any other Role except Diplomats.

Independent Minds

Analysts have little patience for following in others’ footsteps. 58% of these personality types describe themselves as “very independent” – far more than any other Role. Independence isn’t just a characteristic of these types – it’s an important part of their self-image.

This mindset shows up vividly in how Analysts approach academic and professional settings. These personality types are questioners, reluctant to take anything on faith. And “anything” includes what their teachers or bosses say.

From the outside, this might look like a lack of respect. In our Teachers Survey, Analysts were far less likely than other Roles to say they admired their past teachers. And this mindset persists in the professional sphere as well. 43% of Analysts in the workforce say they would be better than their boss at their boss’s job – again, far more than any other Role. Analyst personalities are also far less likely than other Roles to express admiration for their bosses.

But does this represent a lack of respect? Maybe – but this choosiness might well have other roots. Analysts tend to hold themselves to high standards, and they often hold the people around them (bosses and teachers included) to these high standards as well. In addition, Analyst personality types tend to care a great deal about learning and professional success. 85% of Analysts say they have a strong desire to be an important and successful person.

It makes sense, then, that these personality types hold their teachers and bosses to rigorous standards. After all, an Analyst with a poor teacher or boss may be less likely to become successful. Of course, Analysts – just like anyone – will almost certainly find themselves faced with a less-than-stellar teacher or boss. As a result, figuring out how to navigate these situations is an important part of their development.

Problems? What Problems?

You know who talks a lot about their problems? Not Analysts. In fact, 83% of Analysts say that most people complain too much about their problems.

But that doesn't mean that people with these personality types don't *think* about their problems, and they certainly don't shy away from challenges. 61% of Analysts say they're excited by the idea of being responsible for solving problems, and 85% say they enjoy tackling difficult challenges.

A core strength of Analysts is their faith in their problem-solving abilities. Analyst personalities tend to express the highest intellectual self-confidence of any Role, and this gives them the willingness to try their hand at things that may be hard. Taken too far, this can turn into cockiness – which is rarely an asset, whether in relationships or in other spheres. But as long as Analysts balance their intellectual self-assurance

with their innate curiosity, these personality types can find success and even enjoyment in the face of challenges both large and small.

Diplomats – Intuitive (N) and Feeling (F)

Longing for Connection

Diplomat personality types – Advocates (INFJ), Mediators (INFP), Protagonists (ENFJ), and Campaigners (ENFP) – care about helping and connecting with others. They prioritize being kind and generous, and in general, they'd rather cooperate than compete. Empathy seems to come naturally to these personalities. It can almost seem as if their hearts and minds resonate with other people's emotions.

These types aim to understand themselves and others. They often have deep insights into human nature, and they can use these insights to influence the people around them. Fortunately, Diplomat personality types tend to do this with care. They are sensitive to other people's feelings, and they want to nudge the people around them in positive directions.

Striving for Change

Diplomats have a deep belief in the ideals of humanism – altruism, compassion, and understanding. These personality types believe it is possible to create a kinder world, and they strive to do so every day.

The Intuitive trait fuels this optimism. Paradoxically, though, it also makes these types hyper-sensitive to wrongdoing. This sensitivity provides Diplomat personalities with the motivation they need to tackle injustice, which is important. If left unchecked, however, this personality trait can trigger self-righteousness or single-mindedness.

In general, Diplomats are motivated by principles rather than practicality. This helps them to stay true to their big dreams and ideas. That said, these types may have trouble enacting plans that are pragmatic rather than passion-driven. Diplomats can be tempted to ignore day-to-day tasks in favor of their big dreams and ideas. As these personalities mature, however, they often learn to balance these necessary tasks with the big-picture thinking they enjoy.

A Higher Purpose

Among friends and family, Diplomat personalities can range from quietly caring to brightly gregarious. Unfortunately, their open hearts can make them vulnerable when others are inconsiderate. That said, these types wouldn't have it any other way. Someone must trust first, and Diplomats will almost always volunteer.

These personality types see magical beauty where others see the humdrum of daily life. This trait attracts many Diplomats to creative expression. These types can be passionately inspired by music, writing, cuisine, theater – or many other creative pursuits.

Diplomats want to bring progress and beauty to the world around them. These types are led by a sense of higher purpose, and they care about serving the greater good. As a result, activism, spirituality, healing, and volunteering are common interests for these personality types.

The Need to Belong

For Diplomats, authenticity and connection aren't just buzzwords. These concepts – which might seem vague or wishy-washy to other types – form the bedrock of

Diplomats' lives. This explains why relationships matter so much to these personality types – and not just *any* type of relationship, but rather real, meaningful bonds.

When asked about their ideal social life, only 8% of Diplomats would like to spend most of their time alone. Instead, the majority of Diplomats express a desire for a partner and a few good friends. These personalities may also worry more about loneliness than other types, with nearly two thirds of Diplomats saying they worry about being lonely in their old age.

For many Diplomats, a central challenge of their lives is to balance their need for authenticity with their need to belong. More than any other personality Role, Diplomats say that the need to belong often motivates them to do things they otherwise wouldn't. This sort of behavior might not bother other types, but it poses a real dilemma for Diplomats. Being fake can feel literally painful to these types, who long to be loved and accepted for who they are, not for their ability to fit in.

For Diplomats, an important part of self-development is learning to be real – even if they fear that doing so won't make them popular. The irony is that many Diplomat personalities only feel a deep sense of belonging and connection once they learn to approach relationships as their whole, true selves.

What is Success, Anyway?

If your life goals are to earn pots of money, land an impressive job, buy a fancy car, and be better than everyone else – well, you're probably not a Diplomat.

But that isn't to say that Diplomats don't have their own type of ambition. 85% of Diplomats say it's important to them to make a lasting impact on other people, outside of their family and closest friends. In other words, these personality types

want to make a lasting difference in the world – which is no small feat. This might explain why Diplomats are second only to Analysts in saying that they sometimes set impossibly high standards for themselves.

Perhaps because they have such a lofty view of success, Diplomats are the Role least likely to consider themselves successful. It's important to note that the great majority of people with these personality types still say they'd be upset if they never became successful. As a result, many people with these types may feel as if they're constantly striving toward ideals and expectations that they'll never meet.

To address this sense of inadequacy, many Diplomats find they must let go of comparisons to other people. 79% of Diplomats say they consciously compare themselves to others either often or very often. By releasing these comparisons, Diplomats can free themselves to do things their own way, in their own time – rather than fretting over whether they're successful yet.

Time to Leap

You know that expression, “Leap and the net will appear”? Diplomat personality types can fall into the trap of thinking they've leapt – metaphorically speaking – when they're actually still perched at the ledge. Because these personalities have such active mental lives and imaginations, they can forget that thinking about starting a business isn't the same as actually starting a business, or that watching videos of dancers isn't the same as throwing themselves into a pirouette.

For many Diplomats, the secret to tackling their greatest challenge is simply to take action. Of course, that's easier said than done. The majority of Diplomats say they overthink simple tasks – so you can only imagine how much they might overthink major life decisions or their most precious dreams.

Fortunately, Diplomats tend to have a deep intuitive sense of what is right for them. Many of these personality types find that by tuning into this wisdom – and honoring it – they can find satisfaction and meaning in their everyday lives, no matter what challenges arise along the way.

Sentinels – Observant (S) and Judging (J)

Character and Competence

Sentinels – Logisticians (ISTJ), Defenders (ISFJ), Executives (ESTJ), and Consuls (ESFJ) – are cooperative, practical, and grounded. They feel comfortable with who they are, and they take pride in their good character and their competence. These personality types seek order, security, and stability, and they tend to work hard to maintain their way of things. This leads to a deserved reputation as the cornerstone of any group or organization, from family to church to the office and the factory floor.

Careful and consistent, Sentinel personalities tend to be self-motivated. This means that they rarely need external inspiration to be productive and focused. They work hard and aim never to let anyone down, and they expect other people to embrace this same ethic as well. Given a choice, these personality types prefer to collaborate within a clear set of rules. Following proven methods makes more sense to them than swanning around in search of innovation. Their motto is, “If it works, don’t break it.”

Steady Progress

That said, Sentinels are hardly unimaginative. They simply take inspiration from the past rather than the future. These personality types remain loyal to established best practices and traditions, whether that’s the best way to make a pizza crust or the

most efficient way to write an algorithm. This enables them to make steady, consistent progress – which is exactly what they enjoy. Sentinels would much rather guide a single project to completion than start (and abandon) a flurry of interesting ideas.

Sentinel personalities thrive in environments that have clear hierarchies and rules. Whether or not they're in a formal leadership role, they care about setting a good example, and they gain great satisfaction from guiding a well-functioning group. This can make them excellent teachers, managers, and community officials, as well as caring parents and hosts.

Guidance and Wisdom

In their personal lives, Sentinels want to offer stability and wisdom to others. They see it as their duty to give their families safe, happy lives that prepare them for the real world. An appreciation of strong relationships allows these personality types to share generously with those they respect and love. Sentinels feel bolstered by having reliable people in their lives, and they make sure they hold up their end of the bargain. Birthdays, dinner parties, and camping trips are delightful events under their enthusiastic direction.

These personality types are happiest without drama – though they can occasionally be stubborn. In particular, inconsistent people can test Sentinels' patience. It can be difficult for Sentinel personalities to accept people who lack their conscientiousness. Fortunately, they often serve as engaged and caring mentors to those who wish to grow in that direction.

Love and Care

Sentinels are the personality Role least likely to say they fall in love easily – but don't let that fool you. Sentinels may not spout love poems, but they do express affection and admiration – they just do it a little differently than other personality types. Sentinels often show their love in practical ways, such as checking the tires on their partner's car or making them a nutritious dinner. To other types, these actions might not look romantic, but Sentinels do these things with love and care.

In all of their relationships, Sentinels want to make contributions. This attitude informs how they treat not only their nearest and dearest but also their acquaintances, neighbors, and coworkers. These aren't the personality types who neglect their responsibilities or leave the office kitchen a mess – in fact, they're often the types who quietly clean up other people's messes, both literal and metaphorical.

Of course, Sentinels wouldn't *mind* being recognized for the ways they help others, but these personalities rarely demand attention. Instead, they work behind the scenes to make everyone's lives run as smoothly as possible, even if that means taking on unglamorous tasks like remembering to buy toilet paper or handling their family's income taxes. They may not be obvious with their feelings, but Sentinels do care and care deeply – you just have to know how to spot it.

Due Diligence

Sentinels have a core set of principles that they bring to their academic and professional pursuits. These principles include diligence, honesty, and respect. The result is that Sentinel personality types tend to work hard, striving to meet deadlines, and generally get things done. This can be seen even from a relatively young age –

Sentinels are far more likely than other Roles to say that they developed productive work habits in school.

These personality types have a clear vision of what it means to do things “right,” and they take great pride in living up to these standards. Sentinels are rarely willing to cut corners and do shoddy work – even if doing so would help them get ahead. They are less likely than any other Role to say that they could compromise some of their principles to advance their career.

Above all, Sentinels stand out for their ability to stick with their work until it’s done – even if the work is tedious or rote. These personality types are far less likely than others to say that they often abandon work in favor of doing something more interesting and fun, and they’re also less likely to say that they get distracted from what they’re working on. For Sentinels, productivity is a bit of a superpower – and they get great satisfaction from exercising their ability to get things done.

Planning Ahead

Sentinels know the value of a well-made plan. Compared to other Roles, Sentinel personalities are far more likely to say they’d rather prepare for problems rather than tackle them as they arise. And Sentinels aren’t afraid to think up every contingency that might arise – as long as they can do something to avert disaster, that is.

Of course, we can’t prepare for everything – although if anyone could, it would be a Sentinel. Like everyone else, these types must occasionally face unforeseen problems. Learning to roll with the punches, so to speak, is an important part of their personal development. Over time, Sentinels can learn to distinguish between when they should stick with their plans and when they’d do well to change course. And

when they do so, these personality types can press through even the most challenging of circumstances, bringing together determination and adaptability.

Explorers – Observant (S) and Prospecting (P)

On the Fly

Explorers – Virtuosos (ISTP), Adventurers (ISFP), Entrepreneurs (ESTP), and Entertainers (ESFP) – tend to be self-reliant and quick-thinking. These personality types don't mind handling uncertain situations on the fly – in fact, they live for those types of situations. Explorers' flexibility helps them to adapt to the moment, even if they don't feel particularly prepared.

These types tend not to be obsessed with precise detail – unless they're really in the zone, in which case they can muster a level of precision and focus that would make a seasoned engineer blush with envy. Usually, they prefer workability and usefulness to perfection. Explorer personalities enjoy learning different tools and techniques, from rotary saws to sheet music to emergency response strategies.

Living for Change

Explorers can change their minds with minimal regret or second-guessing. People in this Role dislike monotony, and they may stray from their obligations in order to try new things. If these personality types sometimes leave business unfinished, let clutter build up, or misplace important things – it's because they've moved on to something fresh.

These types enjoy being free of obligations, where they can indulge themselves or their interests on their own time. They love delving into something interesting, but their interest tends to wane as soon as something becomes "mandatory." An

Explorer personality might design and build their own dream house, but end up procrastinating on simple repairs after a few years.

Social Ingenuity

This free-form attitude can make Explorer personalities socially dynamic as well. Their spontaneity draws them to appealing strangers and interesting experiences. When things get in the way of a good time, they apply their ingenuity to get around it. Explorers want to see what happens next!

Explorers enjoy being on the leading edge of things – whether that means having the latest technology, trying out fashion trends, or checking out the newest restaurant in town. Many Explorer personalities enjoy sharing these findings with others, and they take pride in introducing their friends and loved ones to the latest and greatest things. The result is that time spent with Explorers is almost never boring or repetitive – and Explorers wouldn't have it any other way.

Explorers in Love

Explorer personality types have a reputation for constantly being on the move – and some people might wonder whether this restlessness applies to their romantic relationships as well. According to our research, however, relatively few Explorers (32%) say they're easily bored by romantic relationships that are stable and predictable. In fact, Analysts and Diplomats are significantly more likely to agree with this statement.

So, what *are* Explorers like in romantic relationships? First, Explorers are slightly less likely than other Roles to say that falling in love scares them. These personality types thrive in unpredictable situations, and what is falling in love if not unpredictable? The

early phases of a relationship are energizing for these types – full of new experiences and fresh discoveries.

It's true that Explorer personalities are somewhat more likely than other Roles to avoid commitment. Still, the majority of Explorers – 63% – say they usually seek commitment in their relationships. And overall, Explorers are slightly more likely than average to say that intimate relationships have increased their maturity more than anything else. So, while Explorers might have a reputation for being commitment-phobes, it's clear that these personality types see the deeper value of long-term relationships – and, more often than not, this is exactly what they're looking for.

Doing the Work

Explorers are highly spontaneous, connecting with their environment in a way that's almost childlike in its wonder and sheer fun. But when they need to work on something that's frustrating or unexciting – well, that can prove something of a challenge.

This may show up in how Explorer personality types approach their academic and professional lives. Explorers are slightly less likely than other Roles to say that they developed productive work habits in school. They're also less likely to say that it was easy for them to do well in school. Many school environments are relatively prescriptive, filled with required courses and standardized curricula. As a result, Explorer personalities often find themselves forced to sit through classes that just don't excite them – which, for these types, can be unmotivating. Unfortunately, this can persist in their professional lives as well – after all, most jobs require at least some degree of routine, unglamorous work.

This isn't to say that Explorers are slouches – far from it. When they're working on something they're passionate about, these personality types can move heaven and earth. And, over time, they often find ways to deal with the necessary evils – in other words, the unexciting tasks – that make work and life run more smoothly.

Perhaps it's most accurate to say that Explorers look for ways to balance work with leisure. They're the Role least likely to say they make themselves finish all of their tasks before they allow themselves to relax. While some personality types might brand this behavior as laziness, this isn't necessarily the case. Explorers' ability to balance work with fun can help them avoid burnout. Ultimately, this can help them to enjoy more fulfillment – and yes, a surprising degree of productivity – in their lives.

The Power of Risk

51% of Explorers say they take risks simply for the fun of it – far more than any other personality Role. This might sound reckless, and indeed it can be. But, done responsibly, risk-taking can be one of the best ways to learn new things, solve tricky problems, and grow as people. As Explorers know, we can only make so much progress in life if we stay in our comfort zones.

As long as they temper this trait with a degree of self-control, comfort with risk can be one of Explorers' greatest strengths. It can motivate them to open up in their relationships and empower them to seek out new academic and professional opportunities.

These personality types don't resign themselves to the "lives of quiet desperation" that Henry David Thoreau famously wrote of in *Walden*. Instead, Explorers can use their own brand of bravery to free themselves from conventionality and create lives that work for them.

Strategies

The word “strategy” suggests a course of action. In our use, Strategy describes how personality types act in response to the world around them and how they might choose to accomplish things.

Strategies express themselves primarily in two ways: social style and resistance to stress. Social style entails how other people factor into an individual’s Strategy and to what degree. One example might involve whether a person prefers working in a team or alone.

Resistance to stress includes the degree of impact that a stressful situation might have on an individual and their efforts, as well as how resilient they might be when trying to restore themselves after a challenging event. An example of this might involve whether a person quits after a jarring setback or presses forward.

The Energy aspect (Introverted/Extraverted) brings to each combination a social piece. When individuals pursue their goals or satisfy their needs and wants, to what degree will they involve other people? Do they want to achieve things independently, or are they collaborators and team players? Extraverted personality types often wish to have more people around, and Introverts tend to prefer doing things more independently.

But the Energy aspect also speaks to risk and taking leaps of faith. Extraverts tend to be more adventurous, and they are brimming with enthusiasm for the activities in their lives – especially if they involve other people. Introverts feel a pull toward lone activities and are usually calmer and quieter, preferring quiet and solitude or smaller, more intimate groups when possible. Introverted personality types are not as interested in adventures as their Extraverted counterparts.

The Identity aspect (Assertive/Turbulent) describes levels of confidence and resistance to stress. It helps us understand what might motivate someone. Are they being pulled along by their self-confidence, or are they pushed to excel because they are perfectionists focused on preventing mistakes and failures?

Assertive personalities are much less likely to worry about things – even results. Their motivation may involve boldly realizing the potential that they assume they have. They are less concerned with the opinions of others and may stand up to their critics – not to impress them but to “correct” them. Turbulent personalities are self-conscious, cautious, and perfectionistic. They may go one of two ways. They may push themselves to high levels of success to avoid disappointment in themselves, or they may opt out of doing something because of the potential for stress and the chance of failure.

In summary, Strategies combine the Energy aspect and the Identity aspect. Together, they describe how individuals respond to life and reflect their preferred ways of doing things. When merged, the Energy and Identity personality traits influence many areas of life, including social preferences, confidence, stress, and risk-taking, to name a few.

The Strategy layer shows our preferred ways of doing things and achieving goals. There are four strategies:

Confident Individualism – Introverted (I) and Assertive (-A)

Substance Over Superficiality

Confident Individualists tend to trust in themselves. They enjoy their own company and don't mind spending time alone to pursue their interests. Over time, this can give these personalities an impressive range of skills and interesting ideas.

But these types take pride in their skills for their own sake, not to impress others. They tend not to see the point in social displays and bragging. While they're proud of who they are, these personality types don't always feel the need to prove themselves to anyone else. They prefer substance to superficiality and personal honesty to playing along.

Confident Individualists are motivated by their inner world rather than outside expectations. They're opinionated, but they aren't excessively worried about what others think. These personality types express their thoughts unapologetically. They're rarely pressured into agreeing with others – even if agreeing would be more convenient.

Self-Assurance and Self-Reliance

If left unchecked, this relaxed self-assurance can lead to complacency. These personality types' live-and-let-live attitude goes both ways: They don't push others to change, and in return, they don't particularly want anyone to push them to change. At times, Confident Individualists may miss information and opportunities that challenge their views because they simply don't place much importance on others' approval.

In their personal relationships, these types tend to be strong and honest. Their loyalty and affection are genuine rather than forced. These personalities only express respect and care if they really feel them. Fortunately, if they do feel them, they see no reason to hide how they feel.

No matter how strong their relationships, these types also value self-reliance. They can handle difficult situations well because they tend to be emotionally secure and resistant to stress. Although these personalities rarely seek the spotlight, their quiet examples of determination and honesty can be nothing short of inspiring.

Confident Individualists in Love

Confident Individualists tend to be a bit choosy about their closest confidants. This is especially true when it comes to finding a romantic partner. Perhaps because Confident Individualists know how to find contentment and fulfillment even when they're single, they're in no rush to settle for a partner who's less than a good match.

These personality types may also be less likely to stay with a partner who lets them down. Confident Individualists are less likely than any other personality Strategy to say they often give second chances to those who fail to fulfill commitments to them. Again, perhaps because of their strong intrinsic sense of worth, these types don't necessarily feel compelled to stay in a relationship that isn't working out.

Confident Individualists are the Strategy least likely to say they believe in soulmates. They're also the least likely to say they know a lot of couples whose marriages they envy, or would aspire to have. And it might not come as a surprise, then, that they're the most likely to say they don't want to get married.

It would be inaccurate, however, to assume that Confident Individualists are lone wolves with no interest in committed intimate relationships. The majority of these personality types – 79% – *do* express an interest in getting married. A similar percentage say they're unafraid of being committed to a single partner for the rest of their lives. It's true that Confident Individualists are independent, and they probably won't get into a relationship just for the sake of being in a relationship. That said, these types often do have an interest in romantic connection – they just want to find the right person before they become attached.

Unlikely Leaders

Confident Individualists bring their love of independence into their academic and professional pursuits. They're more likely than any other Strategy to say that learning as part of a group is distracting rather than helpful. As you can imagine, group projects can be frustrating for these personality types – whether at school or in the workplace.

This isn't to say that Confident Individualists *can't* work well with others – far from it. But if given a choice, these types would prefer to operate independently and figure things out on their own. At school, these personalities may be drawn to independent study opportunities. At work, they may try to develop a specific area of expertise that allows them to make their own decisions and do most of their tasks on their own.

From this description, Confident Individualists might not sound like natural leaders, but that isn't necessarily the case. Just over half of these personality types say they're inclined to seek out leadership and management roles. This is well less than their Extraverted peers, but it's still a majority. In addition, nearly 70% of these types say

they have excellent leadership skills. A quick look at famous Confident Individualists includes real-life leaders (Bill Gates) as well as fictional ones (Gandalf).

Confident Individualists tend to hone their ideas and skills on their own, and they often prefer to work alone. That said, these personalities may be willing to take up the reins of leadership if that's what is necessary to turn those ideas and skills into real-world progress.

The Right Mindset

Confident Individualists are more likely than any other personality Strategy to say that control over their mindset is the most important factor in determining their happiness. On average, they rank their mindset as a more significant factor in their happiness than their financial situation, their friends and family, their job, or their health.

This statistic reveals a great deal about Confident Individualists. These personality types believe in their personal effectiveness and their individual worth, and they know how important it is to maintain this mindset. As long as they balance this self-conviction with a willingness to learn from others, Confident Individualists' positive mindset can become a self-fulfilling prophecy, helping these personalities to not only achieve great things but also find lasting happiness.

People Mastery – Extraverted (E) and Assertive (-A)

Bold and Confident

Personality types with the People Mastery Strategy are known for their ability to handle stress. This helps them to act boldly and maintain confidence, even in the face of challenges or criticism.

Thanks to this confidence, people with this Strategy feel energized and at ease in social situations. They seek social contact as well as stimulating and challenging experiences. These personalities like traveling to see things, people, and places, and trying something new – even things they don't end up liking can be exciting for them.

Nothing to Prove?

If they don't keep themselves in check, though, People Masters can become too confident. These personality types tend to be insulated against self-doubt and the need to prove themselves. As a result, they don't always test, or even consider, their own limits or ambitions.

Taken to the extreme, this can create a pattern of comfort-seeking. They may even roll their eyes at people who chase more intimidating goals. At the other end of the spectrum, these personality types can ignore sensible caution, landing themselves in extraordinary and dangerous situations.

At times, People Masters may not be considerate to those who aren't able to maintain such a comfortable boldness. But this doesn't have to be the case, by any means. By taking others into account, these personalities can actually help to draw other people out of their shells in a way that's energizing and empowering.

Finding Balance

Fortunately, most People Masters fall somewhere in the middle. Ideally, they embrace healthy ambition while finding social fulfillment and connection. Social interaction plays a big part in People Masters' happiness. Although these personality types are self-confident, they still appreciate praise and recognition. They don't need

people's approval, but they still crave friends and loved ones with whom to share their lives.

These types may be opinionated, but they don't always worry about having others agree with them. This can help these personalities to be moderate even in disagreements because their ego and confidence aren't at stake the way they often are for Turbulent Strategies. People Masters are not fond of grudges, and at heart, they want to bring people together to make things happen.

These types often stand out for their charisma and self-assurance. As long as they don't use their talents to steamroll or put down others, these personality traits can be quite appealing. These types have little fear of rejection, and they love including others. This can make these personalities wonderful friends, loved ones, and colleagues, who always aim to energize those around them.

People Masters in Love

According to our research, People Masters seem to fall in love a bit more frequently than the other Strategies. They're also less likely to say that falling in love scares them. It's easy to imagine why this is the case – People Masters' Extraversion leads them into situations where they're likely to meet new people, and their Assertive personality trait helps them to feel confident about the prospect of new relationships.

Some might wonder whether this would make People Masters less reliable than other personality types when it comes to being a good partner. Is it possible that these types' self-assurance would make them complacent or uncommitted once they're actually *in* a relationship? Not necessarily: About half of People Masters say it's necessary to go out of their way to please someone they love, and this response

puts them on par with other types. In addition, People Masters are the Strategy least likely to say that long-term commitments make them anxious.

In other words, although People Masters' confidence and social ease might make them sound like players, these types can be as committed and eager to please their partners as anyone else. And being in a relationship with a People Master can be a wonderful thing – even for people who are completely different. After all, People Masters' social energy and their can-do take on life can be infectious in the best possible way.

Speaking Up

People Masters don't tend to filter their opinions. These personality types say what they think, and they think what they say. As with nearly any trait, this can be a strength or a weakness.

People Masters are often seen as straight-shooters who can be trusted to speak honestly. In academic and professional settings, many teachers, classmates, colleagues, and managers appreciate this quality. After all, if used appropriately, candor is a powerful way to connect with other people. The “what you see is what you get” nature of a People Master personality can be refreshing, whether in the classroom or the workplace.

But there's a difference between being candid and being rude – and at times, People Masters may toe that line. In academic settings, this can put them at odds with their teachers and classmates. And in professional settings, these personality types may gain a reputation for being inconsiderate, arrogant, or even ruthless.

Learning to speak honestly *without* speaking over other people is a step on many People Masters' path to personal development. Fortunately, once they master this balance, People Masters can unleash the many gifts they bring to their schooling and their work. In particular, People Masters can excel at dealing with awkward or tense interpersonal situations – whether that's getting a group project back on track or delivering bad news to a customer in a straightforward but considerate way.

Going for It

79% of People Masters say they see problems as opportunities. These personality types trust themselves to tackle hard problems – *and* to gain insight and experience from the process. Ideally, this conviction becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy, with People Masters taking on ever harder challenges and learning important lessons along the way.

What sets People Masters apart isn't just their confidence, however. It's also their willingness to team up with others. These personalities know that we tend to be more effective when we collaborate and ask for help. People Masters can be especially good at creating opportunities for the people around them to use their strengths. And that may just be one of the secrets to People Masters' success.

Constant Improvement – Introverted (I) and Turbulent (-T)

Sensitive Souls

Constant Improvers tend to be sensitive and introspective. They are often deep individuals who enjoy having their own space and freedom. In general, these personality types feel more comfortable on their own than mixed up in the judgment of the real world.

This may be because they share the two personality traits most representative of sensitivity to their environment – Introversion and Turbulence. As a result, they may find it stressful to deal with tense environments or new situations. In these moments, Constant Improvers can be deeply uncomfortable – although they may not want to let on how they really feel. In reaction, these personalities might retreat inward, react defensively, or try to escape the situation altogether. Alternatively, they might give up their own wants or needs in an effort to keep the peace.

Driven by Doubt

Constant Improvers tend to experience self-doubt. They have a strong drive, but it comes paired with a strong fear of failure. These personality types invest a great deal of their identity in their successes. As a result, even a minor misstep or embarrassment can be crushing.

On the upside, this vigilance offers these personality types a knack for sensing trouble. This can be quite useful in situations that need to balance risk and reward – whether a financial investment or a romantic opportunity. When faced with a potential risk, these types look for ways to prevent problems. Although it slows them down in the short term, this approach can prevent longer-term issues.

Constant Improvers direct much of their attention toward their personal interests. They strive to master hobbies, careers, or new means of self-expression. This level of dedication can create impressive, beautiful results.

People with Constant Improvement personality types can be perfectionistic, dedicating tremendous time and energy to their pursuits. Unfortunately, if they put too much pressure on themselves, this approach can backfire. For example, Constant

Improvers may feel forced to abandon an endeavor because a single detail doesn't line up right.

Reality and Romance

At times, Constant Improvers may experience a nagging feeling that something is missing from their lives. It's worth noting that often this really is just a feeling, not a reflection of reality. These personality types have it in their nature always to be seeking something more – even if their lives actually are going just fine.

But as Constant Improvers assess their lives, wondering what might be missing, they may find themselves focusing on their romantic relationships – or lack thereof. These types are significantly less likely than their Assertive counterparts (also known as Confident Individualists) to say that they enjoy being single. And these personalities are more likely than Confident Individualists to say they often construct an ideal partner in their heads when they're single.

Although Constant Improvers may find themselves longing for romance, they don't necessarily find it easy to start up a relationship. They're less likely than other personality Strategies to say that they usually take the initiative in asking someone out. This makes sense, given that Constant Improvers can feel hesitant about putting themselves out there – and asking someone out is an incredibly vulnerable position to be in.

This might sound like bad news, but it doesn't have to be. As they grow and mature, Constant Improvers often learn how to transform their feeling that something is missing into positive energy – and by doing so, they not only discover gratitude for the good things in their lives, but also become proactive about making helpful

changes. This mindset shift can empower these personality types to find fulfillment in their relationships – as well as in every other aspect of their lives.

The “Right” Career?

Constant Improvers’ longing for “something more” extends to their professional lives. Just over a quarter of these types say that their career is a great fit for them – a rate of agreement that is less than the other Strategies.

This doesn’t necessarily mean that Constant Improvers are in the wrong careers for them – although they might wonder if they are. More than half of these personality types say they often think about switching careers, and they’re more likely than the other Strategies to say that they feel stuck in their current job.

This restlessness doesn’t have to be a bad thing. In fact, restlessness can be an incredible motivator to do great things. The trouble comes when Constant Improvers feel trapped: wanting to make a change, but suspecting they’re unable or helpless to do so. This feeling can have a number of roots, such as self-doubt or a general worry that other people don’t “get” them.

As in other areas of their lives, Constant Improvers who pursue personal growth often discover that their feeling of helplessness is exactly that – a *feeling*. This can be a powerful discovery. In its wake, these personality types are better able to harness their personal and professional strengths and deal with their feeling of “stuckness.” This may take the form of finding a new career, or it might involve advocating for themselves in their current workplaces so that they get more of their needs met. Either way, Constant Improvers often find that they have more agency in their professional lives than they’d realized.

The Strength of Sensitivity

In general, Constant Improvers care a great deal about what others think of them. This can trigger insecurity, to be sure, but when kept in balance, it can create some truly wonderful traits. These personalities are often curious about and sensitive to others' feelings. This can make them excellent listeners, friends, confidants, and partners.

Some types might think that sensitivity is synonymous with weakness, but Constant Improvers know that isn't the case. These personality types often exemplify how sensitivity and vulnerability can be hidden strengths. Their attunement to their own struggles and insecurities can help them to bond deeply with others. It can also motivate them to act with kindness and compassion.

Although they may not always realize it, Constant Improvers offer the world a wealth of gifts. Once they learn to trust themselves as much as they trust others' opinions, these personalities can shine.

Social Engagement – Extraverted (E) and Turbulent (-T)

Boldly Sensitive

Those with the Social Engagement Strategy are an interesting group. In some ways, Extraverted and Turbulent personality traits conflict with each other. Extraversion leads to risk-tolerance and boldness, and Turbulence leads to self-doubt and sensitivity.

This can mean that Social Engagers tend to do what comes naturally first and think about it later. In this way, they are almost an exaggeration of their underlying personality traits. This may sound like a bad thing, but it doesn't have to be.

Social Engagers venture into the world with enthusiasm. They enjoy being the center of attention and enjoy social status. At times, this may mean that they hide their true selves to impress other people, pretending to be someone else in order to be liked. Fortunately, Social Engagers' genuine interest in others often shines through, helping these personality types to create authentic connections with the people around them.

Social Engagers in Love

Romantic relationships aren't always the easiest – hence Shakespeare's observation that "the course of true love never did run smooth." You might think that Social Engagers' self-doubt would cause them to play it safe when it comes to the rough waters of love, but that isn't the case. These personality types tend to dive headlong into relationships – they're more likely than any other Strategy to say they fall in love easily. And they're also less likely to say they enjoy being single.

Social Engagers are far from passive about their romantic lives. These personalities care deeply about pleasing their partners – in fact, they're the Strategy most likely to believe they need to go out of their way to please the people they love. Social Engagers are deeply devoted, willing to pour all of their affection and care into their partner.

But not everyone is willing – or able – to do this in return. Social Engagers may feel it acutely if their partner doesn't seem equally affectionate or devoted. This can be especially challenging because these personality types care so deeply about receiving praise and admiration. As a result, they might feel hurt by a partner who is reserved in expressing their affection.

As they go through life, many Social Engagers discover that not everyone is as expressive as they are – and that's okay. These types may need to use their social

acumen to connect with the ways their partners *do* share love. For example, they may realize that their partner expresses affection through physical touch, spending time together, or even helping out around the house. Once they attune themselves to the ways other personalities demonstrate their love, Social Engagers can find incredible fulfillment and joy in their romantic relationships.

Working It

Social Engagers may find themselves drawn to lines of work that involve plenty of human interaction. The service industry can be a natural fit for these personality types, as can nearly any job that involves helping customers solve problems. Social Engagers are energized by the opportunity to talk with others, and they're especially invigorated when they can tell that they've actually made someone's day a little better.

This isn't to say that Social Engagers are anything less than ambitious. In their own way, these personalities do care about being successful. Everyone has a unique definition of "success," of course, but many Social Engagers feel especially successful when they receive recognition, such as awards, promotions, or positive feedback on their work. These types tend to be motivated by a desire to impress and please others – not only because they enjoy praise, but also because they genuinely value the good opinion of their bosses, coworkers, and customers. And of course a salary increase is always nice, too.

Social Engagers' ambition and desire to please can make them wonderful employees and colleagues. At times, however, these personality types often discover a need to pause and make sure they're being true to themselves as well. Their personal development path may lead them to consider their own values and needs – and make sure that their professional lives line up with these values and needs.

That said, these types know that their career is just one aspect of their lives. 74% of Social Engagers say they're always looking for new hobbies to get into – more than any other personality Strategy. Whether those hobbies include volleyball, viticulture, or volunteering, these types care about being well-rounded. Paradoxically, this well-roundedness can help them to find more enjoyment in their careers as well as in other aspects of their lives.

The Highs and the Lows

Social Engagers can experience highs and lows – sometimes within a matter of minutes. Their Extraversion can push their Turbulent need for success into overdrive. Meanwhile, their Turbulent personality trait can trigger almost instant self-doubt. Although these types are capable of taking quick action in a way that seems decisive, they may find themselves plagued by uncertainty afterward.

As they grow, many Social Engagers learn how to use this unusual combination of traits to their advantage. Their Extraversion can help them move past the self-doubt that comes with the Turbulent trait, enabling them to expand their comfort zones even when it isn't easy. Meanwhile, their Turbulent trait can help them to be more considerate in their boldness. The result is that these personality types can hold many contradictory traits in harmony, being both fun and responsible, active and reflective.

This push and pull can be stressful, but it's part of this Strategy's charm. These personality types chase their goals relentlessly, but they also indulge their desires and seek out fun. Thanks to this balance, they can lead happy and fruitful lives – sharing adventures and accomplishments with others whenever possible. Whatever direction these personalities pull, they are sure to pull the crowd with them.

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